Throne Room

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/39791244.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
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by commander_lioness

Summary

"Catra, what are you doing?!" Catra growled:

"Don't think this is easy for me! Trust me, Adora, I don't want to do this but you leave me no choice! Yes, I betrayed you, but you betrayed me first! And you'll keep hurting me and the rest of Etheria unless I stop you right now!" Catra began to choke up when she said that last bit. Adora began to hyperventilate:

"Catra, what are you doing?! STOP!" Using her claws, Catra cut through the webbing holding Adora's right arm up, causing it to fall by her side. The feline sniffled as she said:

"I'm so sorry, Adora. I really am going to miss you…but you're too far gone for me to save… for anyone to save…"

"CATRA!" With that, Catra cut the remaining webs, causing Adora to fall and desperately grab onto a rock on the way to her supposedly guaranteed demise. As Catra walked away, the blonde screamed:

"YOU'LL PAY FOR THIS, CATRA! YOU HEAR ME?! YOU'LL PAY FOR THIS!"

OR

Here is yet another Horde Adora AU because my favorite one has not been updated since 2020 and I wanted to finish it. Love you LadyLazuli97! ;)

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

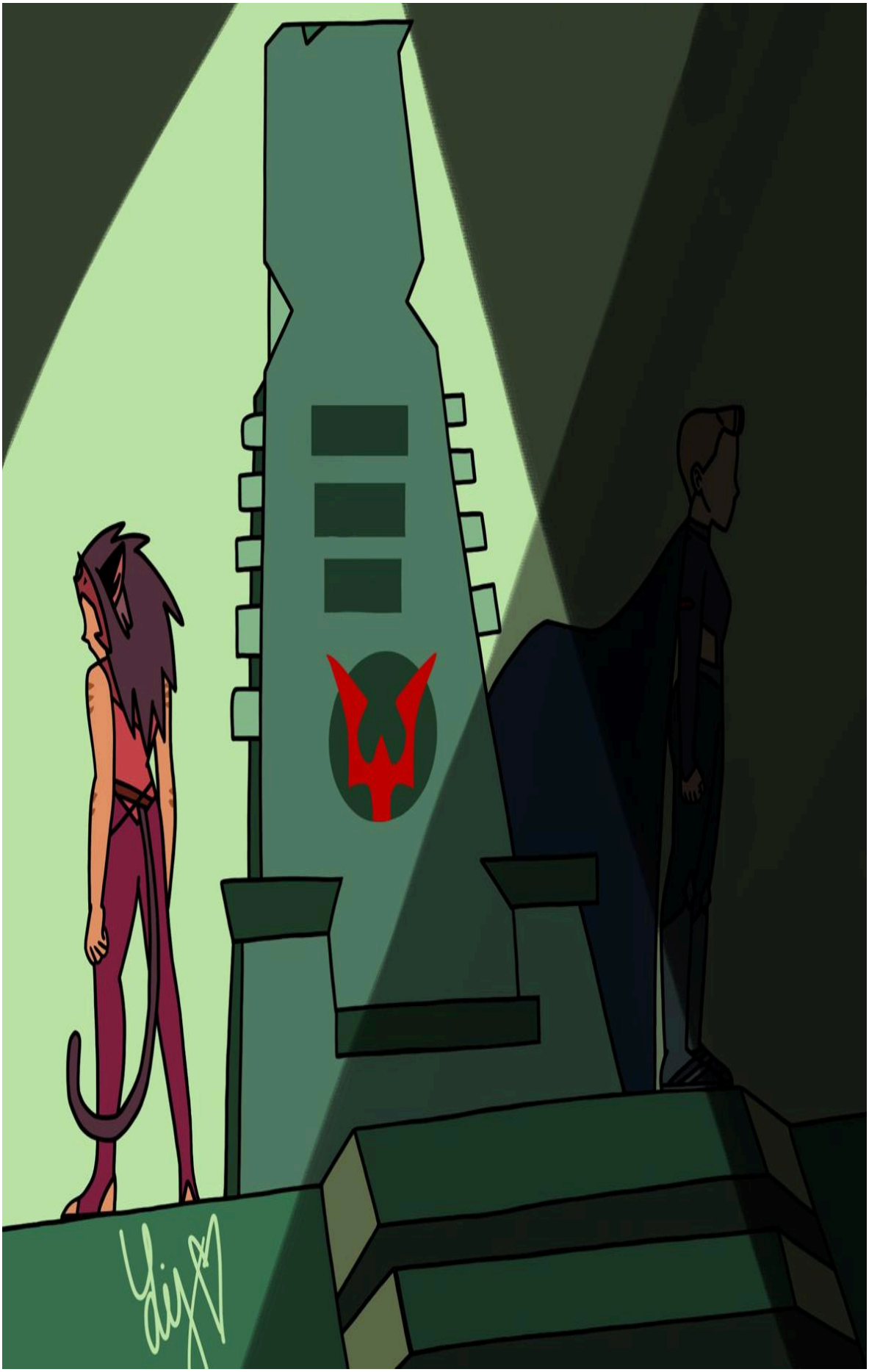
- Inspired by Despara by LadyLazuli97

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

> In this AU, Princess Prom ends differently and Catra gets what she wants - at a price. Special thanks to LadyLazuli97 for inspiring this work and to @profound-drawings (on Tumblr) for not only providing beautiful artwork for this fic, but for also being my beta reader for this chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Amazing cover art commissioned from @profound-drawings on Tumblr! :)

***

"Maybe my plan won't work but, then again…maybe it already has…" Catra's coy smile made Adora sick. And Catra had just dipped her during the dance. It was humiliating – not to mention kind of hot.

Safe to say the evening had not gone as planned. Adora had managed to antagonize Princess Frosta no less than three times. Glimmer and Bow were fighting and *Catra* was here. Even worse, Catra was teasing her, provoking her to do something she would regret.

As Catra pulled Adora back up, she opened her mouth to say something else, but Adora shut her up by yanking her hand away and yelling:

"That's enough! Just stop it, Catra!" With that, Adora stomped off. Catra stared at her incredulously.

As the dance continued, Adora made her way back to the buffet. Tears filled her eyes. It was all too much. The dance with Catra had pushed her over the edge. She had had to leave before she started a fight with her.

As Adora caught her breath and tried to think about where Bow could be, she suddenly felt the familiar brush of Catra's tail on her hand. Adora turned to see Catra standing next to her, looking rather sheepish.

"You know, it's fun watching you get angry. Especially when it's over your new friends. But, that wasn't what that was…right?" Adora raised her eyebrow. Was Catra actually being nice? Like she used to be? Adora sighed and lowered her eyes, too tired to fight anymore:

"No. I mean, yes. Bow's missing, Glimmer just had a fight with him, Princess Frosta doesn't like me and you're…just…" Adora looked like she was about to cry. While not sympathetic regarding the reasons for her distress, Catra had never enjoyed seeing Adora upset. She finished Adora's sentence for her:

"…smokin' hot? Well, gee thanks Princess!" Adora could not help but laugh. Even though it was not that funny, her emotional state was too unbalanced for her to care. Catra gave a small smile and continued:

"Hey, it doesn't matter what they do to us…right?" Adora looked at Catra in astonishment before almost yelling:

"What do you mean? We're not there for each other anymore - of course it matters!" Catra, who had been surprised at herself for even trying to console Adora, instantly got mad:

"And whose fault is that? You left, Adora! You chose your new friends over me!"

"You could've come with me! You still can! You-" Adora was interrupted by a series of explosions. As she looked up, the ceiling began to collapse. A large chunk of ice fell on the buffet and would have crushed Adora had Catra not pushed her out of the way.

As she got back to her feet, Adora realized that Catra had disappeared. Before she could make any effort to find her in the sea of terrified guests, someone grabbed her arm and began pulling her towards the exit: Glimmer.

"Come on! We have to get out of here!" Adora, who still could not see Catra, reluctantly agreed.

"Let's go and get my sword. I can fix this!" Glimmer nodded and the pair of them ran for the door.

***

Catra ran to the rendezvous point. Scorpia's ship should already be waiting for her, along with their rebel prisoner. If this would not get Adora to give herself up, nothing would.

Catra cursed her continued affection for Adora. The evening had been a lot of fun – almost too much fun. Nothing had ever amused her more than toying with Adora. But of course Adora had had to ruin it by spiralling, just like she used to when things got bad back in the Horde. And of course Catra had had to try and help her, just like she always did.

Catra wondered whether that had been the first time Adora had been overwhelmed since leaving the Fright Zone. If not, who had been there to help her? Sparkles? Catra's face went red at the thought.

Narrowly avoiding another falling icicle, Catra literally slid out of the palace – stopping herself just next to Scorpia's ship. Scorpia was standing next to it, holding She-Ra's sword.

"Hey Catra! That was such a cool exit – wow!" Catra frowned, growling:

"You set all the explosives off at once! That was not supposed to happen, Scorpia! I could've gotten hurt!"

"You'll be hurt by the time we're through with you!" Catra instinctively dodged out of the way as a storm of sparkles hit the side of Scorpia's ship. Glimmer and Adora had materialized behind her, and they were intent on getting their friend back.

Scorpia ran onto the ship, yelling at Kyle to fire up the engines. Glimmer teleported onto the ship after her, leaving Adora to charge angrily at Catra.

Catra was very familiar with Adora's fighting style and knew that, without She-Ra's strength, Catra had the advantage. She put her hands in her suit pockets, successfully evading each of Adora's punches without using her claws.

This dance continued for several minutes. The fact that Glimmer did not re-emerge seemingly confirmed that she had been successfully defeated by Scorpia.

Catra gave a snarky grin, finally pulling her hands out of her pockets and almost effortlessly pinning Adora to the ground. Adora did not resist, meaning she was more out of it than Catra realized. She was still pissed though.

"What have you done with Bow? Tell me now!" Catra groaned. This had stopped being fun.

"Nothing permanent. Look, Adora, you're embarrassing yourself. Just admit it – I won and you lost. I got your friends and your sword. Hordak's bound to be impressed..." With that, Adora roared angrily and pushed Catra off her. She had always been stronger, even if she was not nearly as fast and flexible.

Catra quickly gathered herself, preparing for round two. She could see the palace reassembling itself, meaning the ice princess had finally got around to fixing it.

As ice began floating around them, Catra sighed dramatically:

"Adora, come on! I don't want to fight you! I never did! And you're...having a panic attack..." Catra's eyes went wide with concern. Even though Adora had been poised to attack for several seconds, she had not moved. She now began to whimper and collapsed to the ground, holding her head in her hands.

Catra gasped. She had seen Adora spiral before but never like this. It was almost as if she had been holding it in for weeks. Maybe she had. It then occurred to Catra that if she had been successful in getting Adora to attack her in the ballroom, this might not have happened.

Punching things had always been Adora's way of dealing with impending panic attacks. This fight was too little too late.

That was when Catra made a decision which would change the course of Etherian history.

“Adora...I'm sorry.” With that, Catra picked up what she assumed was Kyle’s discarded stun baton, knocking out Adora.

***

When Adora woke up, she did not even need to open her eyes to know where she was. The tell-tale stink of burning sulfur told her that she was in the Black Garnet chamber.

It was empty with the exception of someone else magically restrained in the corner. Adora herself was tied down to a table, and, try as she might, she was unable to see who the other prisoner was. It turned out she did not need to, however.

“Adora? Are you awake?” Adora gasped, eyes filling with tears:

“Glimmer? Is that you?” She heard Glimmer give a weak laugh, followed by an even weaker cough. Adora began to furiously pull at her restraints, crying:

“It’s okay, I can get us out of this! Just hang tight, I promise-”

“Really Adora? Making promises already? You have a nasty habit of breaking them.” The door had opened to reveal Catra. She looked exceptionally grumpy. Adora almost yelled at her:

“How. Dare. You. You’re the one who betrayed me, Catra! You zapped me in the back with a stun baton – twice!” Catra raised her eyebrow before simply sighing and walking over to Glimmer. Adora craned her neck but was unable to see what was happening.

“Catra, if you hurt her, I swear-” She was interrupted by Catra saying:

“Here, drink this. It helps after Shadow Weaver’s...treatments...” Adora heard Glimmer drink something, and then, after another

minute, she heard Catra approach her. Adora then felt the table electronically rise to a vertical position, granting her a full view of the whole room – including Glimmer hunched over in the corner. Before Adora could say anything, however, Catra spoke:

"You're right, Adora. I'm a bad person. I'm not good enough for you. I never was. The only way I could get you to come back with me was with a stun baton." Adora gasped:

"That's not true, Catra!" Catra snarled:

"Really? Because Shadow Weaver just took credit for what I did! She demoted me! I'm a cadet once again, and it's just so you can have your promotion back! I mean, what does that say about me, Adora? You'll always be better than me – nothing I do will ever come close!" Having run out of breath, Catra paused to catch it again.

Adora was speechless. She did not know what to say. How could she convey to her oldest friend that she was good enough, that she was deserving of praise for what she had accomplished (at least by Horde standards), and that Shadow Weaver was a monster neither of them needed to listen to anymore. Then the door opened again, and the woman herself appeared.

***

Catra's hair stood on end the way it always did when Shadow Weaver was near.

"Catra! You should be cleaning out your room! Leave this instant!" Catra slowly moved towards the door, refusing to look back at Adora as she did so. Once she got there, however, she could not help but steal a glance.

Adora looked sad. Not angry – sad. Had that been the desired reaction? Catra could not tell anymore. When it came to Adora, nothing made sense anymore.

As the door closed, Catra turned away and headed for to the Force Captain quarters. In doing so, she passed Shadow Weaver's room.

Catra stopped and took a peek inside. She saw She-Ra's sword, still leaning precariously against the wall where Shadow Weaver had discarded it. It was too tempting an opportunity to miss - Catra went in and stole it. After all, if Shadow Weaver was going to rob her of her future, she may as well rob Shadow Weaver of hers too.

Catra ran to Scorpia's room. She could hardly stash the weapon in the locker-room, and her own Force Captain room was forfeit. When she arrived, she knocked and waited for Scorpia to open the door.

"Wildcat! It's so great to see you again!" Catra raised her eyebrow.

"You saw me fifteen minutes ago." Scorpia nodded:

"Yep, but even that's too long to be separated from my best friend!" Catra scoffed:

"Yeah sure, whatever. Just hide this under your bed or something, okay?" Catra handed Scorpia the sword, to which she gasped nervously:

"Um, Catra? That's Shadow Weaver's property. She said so herself! I could get fired for hiding it!" Catra groaned:

"Well, just say I made you. Or say I hid it without you knowing. Or, even better, hide it so well that no one ever asks!" Scorpia gulped. Catra just realized she had yelled at her. That had not been smart – the corridors echoed and Hordak's little pet was always listening.

Before Catra could say anything else, however, Scorpia silently took the sword and went back in her room. The alarm then sounded – rebels were attacking the Fright Zone.

***

Adora screamed. Shadow Weaver's magic hurt like it had never hurt before. Memories of the last few days were being forcefully ripped out of head and she was beginning to black out from the pain. Then Glimmer screamed and Shadow Weaver fell to the floor.

As Adora opened her eyes, she saw Glimmer and smiled.

"Do you know who I am?"

"Glimmer."

***

Catra, along with Scorpia, the squad and a significant number of Horde soldiers, were outside the Fright Zone fighting the rebels.

Catra was amused that, without Adora, they really had no idea how to plan an attack - especially an infiltration of the Fright Zone.

Despite the impressive power of the princesses (the water and plant ones in particular), they never stood a chance against the sheer numbers of the Horde.

Catra took command and led her troops to victory, successfully driving the rebels back into the forest.

Catra smirked. There was no way Shadow Weaver could take credit for this. Just as she was about to order her soldiers to fall back, Lonnie ran up to her:

"Catra, we have a prisoner!" Catra turned to see Rogelio holding a young woman dressed in white and purple with sentient hair. The woman's face lit up when she saw Catra:

"Hey, I know you! You were at Princess Prom!" Catra grinned:

“Yep. And then I blew it up. You’re...Entrapta, right?” Entrapta nodded enthusiastically. Catra smiled:

“Welcome to the Horde.” She then turned to the squad and ordered:

“Lock her up with Arrow Boy! I don’t want Shadow Weaver hearing we have another princess in custody.”

***

“It’s not here! Where is it?” Adora and Glimmer had ransacked Shadow Weaver’s room to no avail. She-Ra’s sword was nowhere to be found. Glimmer tentatively asked:

“Could it be in Catra’s room?” Adora shook her head, knee-deep in the contents of Shadow Weaver’s desk.

“Catra said Shadow Weaver demoted her and took credit for the whole operation. Confiscating the sword would’ve been the first thing she did!” Glimmer rubbed the back of her neck:

“Well, maybe we should just go? The sword’s useless unless you’re attached to it-” Adora interrupted Glimmer exasperatingly:

“Do you know what that alarm means? Rebels! And it’s not a drill! Our friends are out there and they need our help! They need She-Ra!”

“Well, too bad they’ll never get her!” Adora and Glimmer turned to see Shadow Weaver standing in the doorway. She continued:

“Really, Adora, I expected so much more from you.”

***

As Catra headed back to Shadow Weaver’s room, a giant smile shaped her face. It had been a couple of hours since she had left this room with She-Ra’s sword. Catra had not only had her promotion restored, but Hordak had been so impressed that he

had ordered her to take Shadow Weaver's place as his second-in-command.

Catra now had the pleasure of breaking the news to her former mentor.

When she opened the door, Catra was surprised to find the room empty. After her eyes adjusted to the darkness, she suddenly noticed a whole lot of golden hair on the floor, right next to the wall where the sword had been.

Catra gasped. She knew what Shadow Weaver was capable of, but...

Catra ran to the Black Garnet chamber and opened on the door. She did not care if Shadow Weaver electrocuted her – she needed to know where Adora was. Imagine her surprise, then, when Adora herself opened the door.

Adora's hair was cut short and her face was completely expressionless. Her eyes were distant and her voice was robotic when it said:

"Hello, Catra."

"Adora?" Catra was terrified. To be honest, Catra was frequently terrified but had learned long ago to hide it. At this moment, however, she struggled to do so. She gasped:

"What happened-" A familiar voice interrupted her:

"Leave us, Catra! I did not give you permission to enter!" Catra growled at Shadow Weaver and bravely pushed Adora out of the way:

"I no longer need your permission, Shadow Weaver. Hordak just gave me your job! Now, tell me, what have you done to Adora?" Shadow Weaver, who was standing by the Black Garnet, stared at Catra in amazement before laughing:

“Well, not only are you an insubordinate wretch, but you’re also delusional! I clearly wasted my time raising you.” Shadow Weaver then looked at Adora and pointed to Catra:

“Adora! Remove her from my sight!” Catra felt Adora’s strong hands wrap around both of her arms, but years of training with Adora had taught Catra how to escape this hold. Using her catlike flexibility, Catra did a backflip, pushing Adora to the ground.

As soon as Catra was free, she charged at Shadow Weaver. Shadow Weaver wasted no time in firing some of her electricity at her former protégé. Catra easily jumped out of the way, landing on one of the many machines hooked up to the runestone. Shadow Weaver screamed:

“Insolent child! You’re nothing more than an animal - you’ll never win against me!” Catra raised an eyebrow and snarled:

“Wanna bet?” With that, Catra leapt on Shadow Weaver, easily avoiding the bolts of electricity she knew so well. Catra then sliced her former mentor’s mask in two, causing both Shadow Weaver and Adora to fall to floor screaming in pain.

Catra stood over the witch, out of breath and grinning her face off. She had done it – she had beaten Shadow Weaver. She had finally got revenge for all the years of abuse and neglect. Then her attention turned to Adora, and her face went white.

While Shadow Weaver had simply collapsed, screaming in pain after her connection to the Black Garnet was severed, Adora was lying on the floor convulsing and crying out in pain after her link to Shadow Weaver was cut.

Catra soon forgot about her victory over Shadow Weaver and ran over to her friend. She knelt down and lifted Adora’s head onto her lap, quietly mourning the loss of her beautiful hair and trying to figure out what she could do to help her.

After a few seconds, Catra began to purr. This had worked to calm Adora down when they were kids, before she had discovered the

merits of using violence as therapy. Catra hoped it would help Adora now. It did.

Adora suddenly sprang to her feet, turned to face Catra and glared at her with barely concealed fear in her eyes. She looked like she was ready to attack Catra. Catra quickly stood back up and raised her hands defensively, saying:

"Adora, I don't want to fight you. Stay back." This made Adora stop.

Adora raised her eyebrow in confusion, as if she could not understand why Catra thought Adora wanted to hurt her. Before Catra could process Adora's reaction, the screens all turned on, displaying Hordak's angry face:

"Catra! What is going on? I have received reports of a disturbance in the Black Garnet chamber. Have you informed Shadow Weaver of her demotion?" Catra, who was still focusing on Adora, slowly turned to face Hordak, saying:

"Yes, I did. She didn't take it very well. I'm…handling…the situation." Before Hordak could respond, Adora did something totally unexpected. She began to whimper.

Catra turned to see Adora pointing at Hordak's face in front of her, close to tears and wordlessly pleading with Catra to do something.

Catra was beyond confused. She had only met Hordak a couple of times, and, while she was intimidated by him, she was not so scared of him that she wanted to cry. What was even more confusing, however, was that Adora was scared.

Adora had always been the rock that held Catra together…what had happened to her? And what did Adora want Catra to do? Turn the screens off? Catra's confusion was interrupted by Hordak's yell:

"What is Force Captain Adora doing out of chains?!" Catra took a deep breath and, turning back to Hordak, quickly explained:

"Shadow Weaver did something to her. I'll stay and find out what it was." Hordak growled:

"Don't let her out of your sight. If she escapes, I will hold you personally responsible." Catra nodded hesitantly. Hordak continued:

"I'll send a squad to retrieve Shadow Weaver – I see her body behind you. Did you kill her?" Catra turned to look at her former mentor, now lying unconscious on the floor.

"No, she's still alive." Hordak grunted:

"Fine. You have until the squad's arrival to secure Adora and ascertain what happened to her." As Catra nodded again, the screens turned off and Hordak's face was finally gone.

Catra turned once more to face Adora. She had stopped whimpering and was now hugging herself rather pathetically. Catra slowly moved towards her. She reached out her hand and gently pressed Adora's forehead against hers:

"It's okay, it's just me. No one's going to hurt you." This seemed to calm Adora, who stopped shaking long enough to ask:

"Who…who are you?"

***

Glimmer gasped in pain as she ran down the corridors of the Fright Zone. She could not teleport, had no idea where she was running to, and was barely holding it together after Adora's sacrifice.

"Glimmer, move!" Adora had flung herself at Shadow Weaver, pushing her to the ground. Shadow Weaver had then zapped Adora with such intensity that she had collapsed, pale and smoking from all the electricity coursing through her body.

Glimmer, who had been too weak to intervene sooner, finally summoned enough strength to run forward, punch Shadow Weaver to the ground, and pull Adora towards her. She then checked Adora's pulse - it was not there.

Adora was not breathing. Glimmer screamed:

"You monster! You killed her!" Shadow Weaver laughed evilly from the floor:

"It was more than she deserved. All traitors to the Horde must suffer punishment before their execution." Glimmer roared in anger, kicking the witch where she lay. Glimmer then started to run.

Glimmer was too weak to actually fight Shadow Weaver, and she would be no good to anyone dead. As she ran, Glimmer yelled:

"I'll be back! The entire Rebellion will come and burn this place to the ground! You'll pay for what you've done! You, Catra, Hordak… you're all gonna pay!"

Glimmer had meant what she said. As she turned another corner, she was surprised to see a seemingly unguarded exit out of the Fright Zone (it had helpfully been left open due to the number of robots running about cleaning up after the battle).

As Glimmer stared at the Whispering Woods in the distance, her eyes filled with tears. This had been the worst Princess Prom ever.

Chapter End Notes

It'll only get worse from here. This fic will be regularly updated so feel free to bookmark! All comments and kudos are greatly appreciated! Until next time! :)

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> Hey everyone! Here is the much anticipated second chapter. I hope you like it! :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Are you certain of this, Catra?" Hordak growled menacingly. Catra tried to stay calm but, along with Hordak intimidating her at the best of times, Adora was fearfully squeezing Catra's hand - and it was really distracting. Catra gulped and said:

"Yes, Lord Hordak. Adora's…on our side." It still felt so weird to say, considering Adora had actually been working for the Horde only a few weeks before. Hordak raised an eyebrow, stood up and approached the two kneeling girls. He then cupped Adora's chin, lifting her face to meet his.

Adora looked like she was about to have another panic attack. Hordak said:

"Well, it seems Shadow Weaver did something useful after all. Take Adora with you on your next assignment – see how well she does and report back to me." As Hordak released Adora and returned to his throne, Catra reached over with her free arm to give Adora a quick hug. She desperately hoped Adora would not spiral again. Hordak then yelled:

"Catra!" Catra immediately let go of Adora and turned back to face Hordak, her face red with guilt. Hordak narrowed his eyes, saying:

"Don't fail. Now get out of my sight." Catra nodded, muttering:

"Yes, Lord Hordak." Catra then stood up, pulling Adora to her feet and practically dragging her out of the throne room.

Once the door closed behind them, Catra let out a sigh of relief. She did not have a chance to breathe back in, however, as Adora instantly wrapped her in a tight hug.

Adora was shaking, stuttering:

"I…I hate him…" Catra tapped Adora on her arm, making her aware that she needed to breathe. Adora sheepishly let Catra go. Catra then took a deep breath before replying to Adora:

"I already told you, he's just cranky. He's not going to hurt you – not while I'm here." Adora reached for Catra's hands, squeezing them in her own. Whatever Shadow Weaver had done to Adora had made her way more affectionate – and it was really confusing Catra in more ways than one. Adora then whispered:

"Thank you, Catra. I'm not sure what I'd have done without you." Catra gave an awkward smile, muttering:

"It's…nothing, really…" It really was nothing. Catra had done nothing to help Adora. She had let Shadow Weaver turn her best friend back into the scared little girl she now realized Adora had always been.

"I'm…Catra. Do you not remember me?" Adora shook her head. Catra then glanced back at Shadow Weaver, who was still lying unconscious on the floor of the Black Garnet chamber. Catra asked:

"Do you remember her?" Adora took a deep breath before replying:

"That's…my mother." Catra's eyes went wide. She almost yelled:

"She is not *your mother!" Adora was surprised by Catra's reaction, stepping back in fear. Catra realized her mistake:*

"Wait, um…she's not your mother but…um…she did *raise you. She raised both of us…"*

"Then why'd you hurt her?" Catra stared at Adora in disbelief. Even at her most braindead, Adora did not need to ask why Catra would want to hurt Shadow Weaver. After all, she had witnessed half the things the witch had done to her…

Ignoring the shocking reality of just how much of Adora's memory was gone, the feline took a deep breath and explained:

"Because she hurt me. She also hurt you. I was saving us." Adora nodded slowly. She then asked:

"So…who am I?" Catra's eyes filled with tears. How could she have let this happen? She had known better than anyone what Shadow Weaver was capable of. Why did she think, just because Adora was the golden child, she would not be in danger in the Black Garnet chamber? Catra sniffled:

"You're…Adora. You're my best friend and…it's so good to have you back."

***

It took a long time but Glimmer eventually made it to the Whispering Woods. Every few minutes, her body would become temporarily consumed with electricity, and she had almost passed out from the pain several times.

As Glimmer collapsed in a flowerbed, she tried to remember how far away Brightmoon was. She then realized she had to know the exact time of day to figure it out, and of course it had to be cloudy the one time she needed to see the moon.

Glimmer sighed in exasperation and almost immediately burst into tears. The last 24 hours had been too much for her to handle. That was when she felt something nuzzling her cheek.

Glimmer wiped away her tears only to see an alicorn looking down at her. It was so beautiful that the princess stopped crying. Then it spoke, shocking Glimmer to her very core:

“Hey, why you crying?”

“You can talk?!”

***

Bow was pacing his cell, worried sick about Glimmer and his friends. He had heard the siren and had managed to get his guard, Kyle, to tell him that the Rebellion were attacking. Kyle had also told him that Glimmer was being held in the Black Garnet chamber. Bow shuddered. The name itself sent chills down his spine…Bow’s anxiety was interrupted by two guards arriving at his cell door.

The guards opened the cell door and threw Entrapta inside. They then turned and left. Bow gasped:

“Entrapta? They got you too?” Entrapta nodded enthusiastically before saying:

“Isn’t this great? The technology here is so much more advanced than I expected! Now that I’m living here, I’ll be able to-” Bow cut her off:

“We’re not *living* here, Entrapta! We’re *prisoners*! We need to escape!” Entrapta looked at him blankly before chirping:

“Okay!” Bow nodded:

“Great! Now, here’s the plan: I’ve befriended one of the guards, Kyle. The next time he comes by, follow my lead…”

***

Catra felt sick. She hated the sea and the boat they were on was moving slowly against the wind.

Adora was leaning silently on the railing next to her. She had barely said a word since they had got their assignment: Salineas.

Now that Adora was on their side, She-Ra would not be a problem. Not that anyone besides Catra and Scorpia knew that (and she intended to keep it that way). Speaking of, Catra's thoughts were then interrupted by Scorpia tapping her on the shoulder. Catra jumped and hissed:

"Argh! Don't sneak up on me like that! What do you want?" Scorpia gave a sheepish expression which made Catra feel guilty. This was the second time she had yelled at Scorpia in the last few hours. After an awkward silence, Scorpia pointed at Adora, saying:

"I…just wanted to see if you were okay, boss. I mean, it's great that Adora's…on our side…but…won't the water princess recognize her? She might…I don't know…try and tell her things Adora shouldn't…um…" Catra's eyes widened as she grabbed Scorpia's pincer, pulling her to the other side of the deck.

"What's the big idea? Are you *trying* to mess this up?!" Catra growled. She then took a deep breath, muttering:

"I know Adora might be seen. I didn't want her on this mission to begin with – it's Hordak's orders. What am I supposed to do?" Scorpia smiled, taking any ounce of acknowledgement Catra offered her.

Scorpia then looked over Catra's shoulder, seeing Adora in her usual red shirt with her now short blonde hair shining brightly in the moonlight.

"How about we put her in some Horde armour? That way she'll still be with us but Mermista won't know it's her!" Catra raised her eyebrow and grinned:

"Scorpia, that's…a really good idea. Go and find some armour – now!"

***

"Mom, you don't get it!"

“What don’t I get, Glimmer? You’re injured and can’t teleport anymore! Adora’s…gone…and Bow’s still a prisoner in the Fright Zone…the Princess Alliance failed once again! It was never a good idea to begin with! And that…witch…still has She-Ra’s sword…it’s over. We’ve lost.” Before Glimmer could disagree with her mother, she was once more overcome with electricity.

Crying out in pain, Glimmer slumped against the table. Queen Angella rushed to her daughter’s side and hugged her, despite being hurt by the electric current as she did so. The queen whispered:

“It’s alright – we’ll get through this. We always have. Let’s focus on rescuing Bow-”

“And Entrapta!” Netossa burst into the dining room with her wife close behind. She continued:

“We’ve just received word from the other princesses – they saw Entrapta get captured before they were forced to retreat! She’s in there too!”

***

“So, do you understand your assignment?” Entrapta’s eyes went wide at what Hordak was suggesting:

“You want me to take a look at your runestone? I WOULD LOVE TO-” Before she could continue, Bow pulled Entrapta away from the force field separating them from Hordak. He then covered her mouth and said:

“No - no she wouldn’t! We’ll never help you!” Hordak growled in annoyance and snapped his fingers. The force field disappeared and Lonnie and Rogelio entered. They grabbed Bow and pinned him to the wall. Entrapta, upset at the violence she was witnessing, cried:

“Hey, that’s not nice! Leave him alone!” Hordak replied menacingly:

“Only if you do what I ask. Do we have a deal?” Entrapta looked uncertainly at Bow, who tried and failed to shake his head under the force of Rogelio’s elbow. Entrapta, failing to get the message, mistook Bow’s silence for agreement and chirped:

“Deal!” Hordak smiled:

“Good.” He then turned to Lonnie, saying:

“Take them to the Black Garnet chamber!”

***

Mermista grunted in pain. It was all she could do to hold the Sea Gate up on her own. She needed help but, now the Princess Alliance was no more (and She-Ra was gone), there was nothing she could do.

Mermista could just make out Catra in the distance, ordering her soldiers to keep firing from the advancing Horde ship. It was only a matter of time before they broke through. After almost ten minutes, that is exactly what happened.

“The Sea Gate’s down!” Catra cried happily. She then turned to Scorpia:

“Salineas is ours! Launch the skiffs and take the city!” Scorpia gave an almost evil smile:

“You got it, boss.” As Scorpia ran off to follow her orders, Catra turned to look at Adora, now dressed like all the other soldiers around her. Catra smiled:

“Don’t worry, it’s nearly over.” What Catra did not know is Adora was not at all scared in that moment. The violence happening around her had done something, something not even Catra would suspect. Adora was smiling.

“No, it’s just beginning.”

***

“Please…I need help…come quickly!” Queen Angella replayed the message again.

It had been almost an hour since she had received Mermista’s call. Given how the Princess Alliance had disbanded, the queen had correctly surmised just how desperate the princess had been to have called her.

Unable to send Glimmer in her current state, the queen had sent Netossa and Spinerella on the flying horse who had brought Glimmer home. It was strangely beautiful that, even though Adora was gone, she had left the Rebellion a talking alicorn to help them in their fight. The queen knew they would need him.

As Queen Angella was about to play the message again, General Juliet entered the War Room.

“Your majesty, we just received word…Salineas has fallen.”

***

“How are you okay with this?” Entrapta turned to face Bow, lifted her face shield and said:

“It’s science, Bow! Imagine all the data we could get from this!” Bow could not believe the princess. He approached Entrapta, who was hovering over a whole mess of wires connected to the Black Garnet. Hordak and the squad had left them alone – for now.

“Entrapta, I know how fascinating this is for you, but we cannot help these guys! You heard Hordak – he wants us to find some way of using this runestone’s power to charge a weapon!” Entrapta cocked her head thoughtfully:

“Well, he didn’t say weapon per se…he said ‘device’. That could mean anything…and come on, Bow! This is my chance to prove my theory that runestones are, in fact, First Ones’ technology put on this planet to help control its environment! Imagine what we

could do if we could decipher the code imbedded in this thing!" Bow took a deep breath before saying, as calmly as he could:

"That's only if you're correct, Entrapta. And even if you're right, do you know who gets the data? The Horde! They want to hurt people! They're hurting Glimmer! Don't you get that?" That shut Entrapta up, causing her to lower herself back to the ground. She turned to look at Bow sheepishly:

"I don't want Glimmer to be hurt…" Bow smiled:

"Exactly! Now, how about we save our friend, get out of here, and maybe Glimmer will let you look at the moonstone when we're back in Brightmoon?" That made Entrapta smile once more:

"Okay!"

***

Catra stared at the remains of Mermista's palace. She was happy the Horde had won, but was also very concerned at how they had done so.

Catra flinched. What had Adora just said? She slowly turned around, saying:

"Excuse me?" Adora replied:

"You heard me – this is just the start! Once we've taken Salineas, we can move on to Plumeria, the Kingdom of Snows, Brightmoon…the Horde will control the seas and nothing will stand in our way!" Catra raised her eyebrow, saying:

"Sure…but let's focus on getting this kingdom first, shall we?" Expecting Adora to simply agree and shut up, Catra was astonished when her best friend wordlessly marched past her, shoved the soldier manning the cannon aside, and proceeded to start firing it herself.

Unlike the gunner who had been firing before her, Adora did not time her hits or even aim at specific targets. Instead, she fired wildly and aimlessly, destroying more than even Catra thought possible, given the limited range and power of the gun (as well as how far they still were from the shore).

Catra narrowed her eyes at Scorpia and her landing force in the distance, realizing too late that Adora was going to hit them. Without hesitation, Catra pounced on Adora right as she capsized Scorpia's skiff. Pinning Adora to the ground, Catra turned to the terrified gunner:

"Get back to your post! Keep firing and don't hit our ships!" As the gunner ran past her, Catra looked down at Adora. Her helmet had fallen off when Catra had pushed her, and now Catra could see a look of genuine horror on her face. Adora mumbled:

"What have I done…what have I done…"

"Boss?" Catra was pulled from her thoughts by Scorpia. Catra gave a big smile and ran to her, wrapping her in as big a hug as she could manage:

"Scorpia! Thank goodness you're okay!" Scorpia blushed, saying:

"Hey, it's no biggie! I'm a very good swimmer!" She then gave Catra a concerned look:

"I heard what happened with Adora…are you okay?" Catra shook her head:

"Something's wrong with her, Scorpia. Something's very wrong…"

***

General Juliet tried and failed to reach Netossa and Spinerella on their communicators. It had been over an hour since the news of Salineas' destruction had reached Brightmoon.

Queen Angella paced the floor of the War Room, with Glimmer sitting sadly in her seat. After another ten minutes, the general was about to try again when a majestic alicorn suddenly flew through the window, carrying one more princess than he set out with.

"Mermista!" cried Glimmer. She got up and ran over to her friend, giving her a hug the second she got off the back of the flying horse. Unfortunately, she had to pull away once electricity began to consume her yet again.

Mermista, who had not returned the hug, now looked at Glimmer with a distant look in her eyes:

"I see your day's been about as good as mine." The queen then rushed forward, helping the two other princesses off the alicorn.

"Netossa, Spinerella, are you both okay?" Netossa gave an almost drunken thumbs up before falling off the flying horse. Spinerella helped to catch her, explaining:

"She got badly hit in the head. I'm going to take her to the doctor to get looked at." Queen Angella nodded uncertainly. Before she could say anything else, she was pulled aside by her general:

"Your majesty, this is not good. We need a plan – fast!"

***

When Bow tapped on the door of the Black Garnet chamber, Kyle jumped. Despite growing up in the Fright Zone, he was still not used to sudden noises or people sneaking up on him.

Kyle turned to face the door, calling to the people inside:

"What do you want? My orders are to not let you out! If you have something to report, you need to call Hordak directly!" Bow's voice rang through the door:

"We tried that! The communicator isn't working! Can you take us to see him instead, please?" Kyle hummed uncertainly:

"Um…I don't think that's a good idea…" Bow replied:

"Come on, Kyle! We're friends, aren't we?" This was enough to convince him. Kyle opened the door, only to get knocked out by Bow holding one of the many large pieces of metal lying around the Black Garnet chamber.

As Bow and Entrapta left the room, the princess looked down at the now unconscious Kyle.

"I don't want to make you feel bad, Bow, but that was mean." Bow sighed:

"Yeah, you're right. Let's take him with us – I'm sure Kyle would love it in Brightmoon!"

***

Adora was shaken up. She was not sure what had happened to her.

When Catra had told her they were going to Salineas, she had asked where it was and why they were going there. Catra had said it was a few hours away by sea and that they needed to conquer it so they could take over the rest of Etheria. When Adora had asked what Etheria was and why they wanted to invade it, Catra had simply sighed and said:

"It's…just what the Horde does, okay?" Adora had not said anything when the ship left, nor when it arrived at Salineas. The whole place had seemed strangely familiar to her – as if she had seen it in a dream. And then the shooting started.

The firing of the cannon, the yelling of the orders, the launching of the skiffs - something happened to Adora and she blacked out. When she woke up, Catra was on top of her, ordering another soldier to rectify a mistake she had apparently made.

Adora was distraught as she sat on the stairs of the remains of Mermista's palace. That was the name of the water princess, or so Catra had told her when she asked half an hour ago.

It was clear Catra was upset with her, but it seemed she was also mad at herself. Adora wished that was not the case. None of this was Catra's fault.

***

"This is all my fault, Scorpia! Why did I leave Adora in that room? Why?!" Scorpia put both her pincers on Catra's shoulders and bent down to look her in the eyes:

"Hey, it's okay, Wildcat! It was just a crazy moment – people often go crazy in battle! There's loud noises, everyone's angry, scared, tired, sometimes hungry - it happens to all of us!" Catra got cross and shoved Scorpia's pincers away:

"Not to Adora." She then marched past Scorpia, stopping when she saw Adora sitting alone not too far away on the steps of the palace. Scorpia spoke quietly behind her:

"You should…go and talk to her…" Catra said nothing but decided to take Scorpia's advice.

Catra cleared her throat as she approached Adora, causing Adora to immediately turn and look at her. Her helmet had never gone back on since Catra had knocked it off, but it had not mattered. Mermista, along with anyone still left in the city, had fled as soon as the Sea Gate collapsed.

Catra sat down next to Adora and asked:

"So…what happened back there?" Adora teared up, turning away from Catra:

"I don't know! One minute I was watching you ordering Scorpia to start the land attack and the next…" Adora then started to actually cry.

This was almost too much for Catra. The amount of crying, whimpering, fearful hugging and handholding over the last few hours – it made Kyle look as unemotional as their trainer: Sergeant Cobalt.

Emotion is a sign of weakness in the Horde – it always had been. But Adora had clearly forgotten that, or was just incapable of controlling herself after Shadow Weaver messed with her mind. It was probably a combination of both.

Despite Catra's gut reaction to move away from Adora, to not be associated with this much weakness, the feline simply sighed and pulled Adora in for a hug.

Catra knew that Adora was not weak. She had a pretty good idea of what her friend had been through, and she was not going to hold it against her. Catra then said:

"It's okay, we'll get through this. It doesn't matter what they do to us. You look out for me and I look out for you. Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other."

Chapter End Notes

sniffles from all the torture I'm voluntarily putting my favourite characters through Thank you all so much for your kudos and comments - they mean the world to me! Hopefully you're having a better day than anyone in this fic is having! :)

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

> Wow, this is the longest chapter I've ever written! I hope you enjoy it! :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Bow and Entrapta ran down the corridors of the Fright Zone, doing their best to evade the many bots and patrols. They managed to make it as far as Hordak's sanctum until a bot finally spotted them.

The bot walked up to them menacingly, scanning them for the ID passes they did not have. Thankfully, it only took Entrapta five seconds to squeal excitedly, rush up to the bot, gain access to its controls and rewire it so it never sent a distress signal.

Bow was amazed. Once the bot started chirping happily in Entrapta's arms, he gasped:

"How did you do that?" Entrapta turned and grinned happily:

"It wasn't that hard! All the bots here are linked to the same channel – all I had to do was change the channel to mine!" Bow raised his eyebrow:

"You…have a channel?" Entrapta nodded:

"There's a giant antenna on top of my castle in Dryl. Did you not see it? It's pretty obvious…" Before she could finish her sentence, footsteps echoed down the corridor and Bow pushed both Entrapta and the bot behind a giant steel pipe.

The bot beeped angrily and Entrapta whispered to Bow:

"Emily says she'd appreciate it if you gave her some warning next time."

***

Catra sat silently next to Adora for a long time. Scorpia had taken command of the troops and was now securing Salineas. After almost forty-five minutes had passed, Catra's communicator suddenly rang. She jumped up with a start, quickly combed back her hair with her claws and answered the call.

"Catra, you were supposed to report in an hour ago. What happened?" Catra gulped. She had completely forgotten about Hordak. She replied:

"My apologies, Lord Hordak. I'm pleased to confirm that the Horde now controls the seas. Salineas is ours." Hordak's eyes widened in surprise - he had clearly been expecting bad news. He then gave a disconcerting smile:

"Perfect! Well done, Catra!" Catra, who was not used to being complimented by a figure of authority, stared at her boss in disbelief. Her mind went blank – was she supposed to thank him? She was only used to saying that word sarcastically…The feline's thoughts were interrupted when she suddenly heard Adora stand up next to her. Hordak then said:

"Is that Force Captain Adora?" Catra nodded:

"Y-Yes, Lord Hordak." Catra desperately hoped she would not be asked any probing questions about how the battle went – or more specifically how well Adora had performed during said battle. Hordak continued:

"I see she remained by your side…Impressive. How did she fare in the battle?" Catra felt like someone punched her. Doing her best to ignore the pain of the first statement, Catra took a deep breath and calmly answered:

"She…struggled with the stress of combat. However, she's proven herself to be loyal to our cause and, with some more training, I have no doubt she'll be an invaluable…addition…to our team." Catra had almost referred to her the same way Shadow Weaver

used to; as an ‘asset’. But Adora was more than that and Catra made sure to give Adora a reassuring smile while she said all this to Hordak.

Hordak grunted in acknowledgement before saying:

“Fine. Keep her with you during the next campaign. I imagine another chance to fight will be more than enough training for her.” Catra was about to argue about that when Adora surprised both her and Hordak by speaking up:

“Lord Hordak, what is our next campaign?” After an icy silence, Hordak turned to look at Catra, replying:

“Plumeria. I’m sending you more troops - they should be in Salineas by nightfall. As soon as they get there, I want you to cross the border and conquer the kingdom.” Catra nodded, saying:

“Yes, Lord Hordak.” As Hordak ended the call, Catra turned to glare at Adora. The short-haired blonde stammered:

“W-What’s wrong? Invading Plumeria makes sense!” Catra continued to glare, saying:

“You know, I don’t get you, Adora! One minute you’re a blubbering mess and the next you’re brave enough to interrupt a conversation I’m having with our boss? Get a grip!” With that, Catra stomped off.

Catra was not really sure why she was annoyed. Adora had simply asked the question she was about to ask anyway. There was just something about how she had done it, like Catra no longer existed and Hordak was simply a means to an end.

There was definitely something wrong but Catra still clung to the hope that, as long as Adora stayed with her, everything would be alright.

***

“Alright…” Queen Angella sighed and pinched her nose.

The War Room was fuller than it had ever been. The alicorn, whose name was Swift Wind, stood proudly behind her. Netossa and Spinerella sat in their usual seats with Glimmer and Mermista sitting in front of them. In between them was General Juliet and princesses Perfuma and Frosta. Angella had sent Swift Wind out to get them as a matter of urgency.

As they all waited expectantly for her to finish, Angella could not help but reminisce about the last time this room was so full. Her husband had been sitting next to her…

“Your majesty?” General Juliet bought the queen back to the present. Angella took a deep breath and continued:

“Now that Salineas has fallen, it’s only a matter of time before the Horde attacks either Plumeria or the Kingdom of Snows.” General Juliet cleared her throat, saying:

“It’s more likely to be Plumeria. Less equipment would be required. The Kingdom of Snows is much bigger with rougher terrain, requiring more soldiers and specialized equipment.” Perfuma went white. Seeing her friend in distress, Glimmer spoke up:

“Or maybe that won’t happen? Hordak isn’t exactly a tactical genius, he’ll probably take his time securing Salineas and the coastline rather than make any advancements…” Netossa interrupted the princess:

“You don’t give him enough credit.” Spinerella nodded and added:

“We may have only been teenagers when the last Princess Alliance fell, but we remember why it did.” Angella coughed, indicating this was not the right thing to talk about. Mermista then gave a long sigh:

“Look, I’ll tell you why Hordak won last time – Shadow Weaver! She’s always been his secret weapon and now she’s killed Adora,

giving Catra the opportunity she needed to destroy my kingdom!" Mermista then stood up and hit the table furiously:

"I don't care what you decide so long as I get to fight that mangy cat!"

***

Bow and Entrapta had been as quiet as possible but it had been no use. Lonnie and Rogelio trapped them before they could escape from their hiding place.

Seeing Kyle slung over Bow's shoulder, Rogelio roared angrily and almost hit the archer with his stun baton. Lonnie stopped him, however, saying:

"Don't! You might hit Kyle!" Lonnie then turned back to Bow and growled:

"Drop him! NOW!" Bow nodded, laying Kyle gently down on the floor. He then said:

"I'm sorry! I promise I wasn't going to hurt him – he's okay!" Rogelio dropped his stun baton and fell to his knees, cradling Kyle in his arms. Lonnie glared at Bow:

"Really? Because he looks pretty hurt to us!" Before Bow could explain, Entrapta suddenly grabbed Bow and literally dived into a vent that had been concealed behind them. When Lonnie tried to stop them, Emily got in the way.

"What the…get out of the way!" With that, Rogelio lay Kyle back down and proceeded to literally lift Emily up. Lonnie slid under the bot, crawling into the vent after the escaped prisoners.

As soon as Lonnie disappeared from sight, Rogelio threw Emily behind him and stuck his head into the vent he had no hope of fitting into. Lonnie, realizing Rogelio could not follow her, then yelled back at him:

“It’s okay, Rogelio! Get Kyle to the med bay! Don’t worry about me – I got this!”

***

The troops arrived sooner than expected and Catra was getting nervous. She watched as the significant number of reinforcements began to disembark and Scorpia ran down to meet them.

It was only just hitting Catra what it truly meant to be second-in-command of the Horde. All of these soldiers were waiting for her orders. They were her responsibility.

Catra had been acting like a Force Captain up until now, and even that had been a position she had not done any training for. Scorpia had already teased her several times about missing Force Captain Orientation…

Catra’s invasion of Salineas had been based on a plan already laid out by Shadow Weaver, and she had only had one ship and two squads under her command at the time. She could manage that, but two whole divisions? Catra was way out of her depth. On top of that, she had absolutely no idea how to go about invading Plumeria.

Catra figured she could have thought something up given more time, but she had been given less than 24 hours!

Catra sighed in exasperation. She needed Adora – she had always been the one who excelled at planning missions and leading squads into battle. Catra’s strategy, in so far as she had ever had one, was to just react to whatever Adora was doing. Unfortunately, that was no longer an option.

As Catra tried her best to think of any lesson she could remember about battle planning, she found herself flanked by the two newly arrived Force Captains who commanded the troops who had been sent to help her.

The first was Grizzlor, a notoriously unpleasant bear hybrid who had a lot of experience and had been the leader of the Plumerian base before She-Ra kicked him out. He spoke first, making it clear he had little to no respect for Catra and would let nothing stand in the way of him regaining his honour (as he put it).

The second was Octavia. She was an octopus hybrid who hated Catra's guts. She was also one of the Horde's rising stars, having never lost a battle and the youngest Horde admiral of all time. She was so determined to make a name for herself beyond the sea that she made a show of being exceptionally nice to Catra - the person who took her eye.

As Octavia defended Catra's lack of experience to a clearly disinterested Grizzlor, Catra pulled out the map of Plumeria that had been sitting idle under her belt for the past half hour. She now opened it out and shoved it in her colleagues' faces.

Catra had hoped that by doing this she could redirect the conversation to a better topic and hopefully get some actual advice for two more experienced and well-respected officers. Instead, she just made it worse.

"We need to do a full frontal assault! The Plumerians are cowardly and weak – they'll retreat as soon as they see us!" Octavia scoffed at Grizzlor:

"The Plumerians won't be alone! They'll have help from the other princesses – or did you forget how *you* lost Plumeria in the first place?" Grizzlor growled angrily:

"I can take She-Ra! I'm ready for her this time!" Octavia laughed:

"No you're not! After all, *Catra's* the only one who's ever faced her and won – which is why *she's* in charge and you aren't!" Grizzlor roared angrily, looking like he was about to swipe at Octavia, but the octopus hybrid ignored him and continued:

"*Catra* knows better than anyone that a stealth attack is needed! I'll take a team down this path-" Catra cut her off, yelling:

"Both of you, shut up!" Catra then took a deep breath and decided a compromise of two vaguely viable plans was better than no plan at all. She gave her orders:

"Octavia, you will take two squads and head for the old Horde base. Once you taken that resource back, Grizzlor will lead an attack on the…city?" Catra was honestly not sure what the map was showing her when it came to the so-called 'residential area'. Grizzlor sneered at the Force Commander he had little to no respect for:

"The Plumerians don't have a city - they live in tents. You're thinking way too hard about this – there'll be no resistance."

***

"We must resist the Horde! I say we all go to Plumeria and destroy anyone who tries to get in!" Glimmer grinned when she remembered her call to arms after Mermista's demand for revenge. Unfortunately, her mother had replied by saying that they should not do anything until they knew exactly what the Horde was planning. Perfuma had agreed with Angella, saying the Plumerians were a peaceful people and she would much prefer to evacuate them to Brightmoon instead of fighting another battle on their land. Glimmer had countered this by saying:

"What are you talking about? You helped us kick the Horde out of your kingdom only a few weeks ago!" Perfuma had sighed and said:

"That was when She-Ra was with us. She's…not with us anymore." Glimmer pushed a branch out of her way, almost breaking it in her frustration.

Glimmer frowned as she remembered telling Perfuma that they did not need She-Ra to win. She remembered Mermista say that Catra was merciless and that, whatever the state of the Rebellion, it was their duty to stop her before she reached Brightmoon. Glimmer raised her eyebrow a she remembered Frosta being

surprisingly mature, saying she wanted to make sure the Kingdom of Snows' defences were built up before she engaged in any fights with the Horde.

It was obvious that Princess Prom had badly affected her too.

Glimmer clenched her teeth when she remembered her anger at her mother's executive decision: everyone needed to focus on defences and wait for the Horde to make the first move. After that, Glimmer had called her mother a coward and stormed out of the room.

Several hours had passed since then, and Glimmer was now walking to Plumeria with Mermista and Perfuma leading the way. She was still unable to teleport and still became consumed with electricity at random moments.

Glimmer did not care, however. She was so set on avenging Adora and destroying the Horde that she was willing to risk it all. Perfuma, on the other hand, was really scared. She did not want to fight the Horde without Adora. After all, she had seen first-hand what would happen if she did.

Once the meeting had ended, Glimmer and Mermista had cornered Perfuma, saying that they were going back to Plumeria with her, whether she liked it or not. While somewhat intimidated by their tone, along with the fact they were both clearly going behind the queen's back, Perfuma let herself be comforted by the thought that at least there would be some help if it was needed.

As the princesses entered yet another clearing, Perfuma suddenly screamed. In front of her and Mermista was a group of Horde soldiers. Glimmer, who was trailing behind her friends, did not immediately see the danger and almost got hit by a laser. That was the only time she was caught off-guard, however.

The princess of Brightmoon lifted up the axe she had taken from her secret armoury, raising it high above her head and charged forward. As she did so, her body became consumed by electricity,

only, this time, Glimmer did not let it stop her. If anything, she used the pain to propel herself at the enemy, yelling:

"DIE, HORDE SCUM!"

***

Catra sat in one of the tanks with Adora and two guards. They were waiting for Octavia's signal, along with the rest of Grizzlor's troops, when Catra's communicator suddenly began to ring. Catra gulped. It was way too early for Octavia to be calling in. She quickly answered the call:

"Catra! We've been stopped by three princesses! They're too powerful – I'm down to one squad! We need help - NOW!" Catra could hear the laser fire in the background. She also heard the distinct sound of the princess of Brightmoon cursing out her soldiers.

Catra sighed and pinched her nose. Why did this have to be so difficult? She then decided to do the only thing she could think of:

"Okay, I'll order the main attack early. Try to hold them for as long as you can. Fall back to our position when it gets too much – don't bother with the base!" Octavia nodded and grunted her acknowledgement before hanging up.

Catra gave the tiniest of smiles. It must have killed the octopus hybrid to let her know she was losing. Catra then called Grizzlor, who took his sweet time answering. When he finally did, he rudely growled:

"What?" Catra hissed:

"Don't take that tone with me! Octavia's team has been apprehended by princesses. We need to attack now!" Grizzlor looked like he was about to say something along the lines of 'I told you so' or 'you don't deserve to be in charge', but then the ground began to shake. The battle was coming to them sooner than even Catra expected.

Fighting the urge to panic, Catra yelled at Grizzlor:

"I gave you an order! Get everyone ready to fight!" Somewhat surprised by the feline's show of authority, Grizzlor simply nodded and hung up.

As Catra leaned back in her seat, trying to stop herself from panicking, Adora suddenly spoke up:

"He shouldn't have spoken to you like that." Catra raised her eyebrow at her friend, giving her a wry smile and whispering:

"Gee Princess, what a nice thing to say…" Catra was unable to finish her sentence, or realize that she had just called Adora "Princess", because something suddenly hit the tank and forced the two guards/ drivers to perform an evasive manoeuvre.

After a few moments of being roughly thrown around the inside of the tank, it finally crashed into something and the engine died. The two guards immediately jumped out of the drivers' seats and opened the hatch to climb out. As soon as they did, however, a vine appeared and grabbed them both, throwing them some distance away.

Adora began to hyperventilate. Catra immediately climbed over all the upturned boxes of ammunition and supplies, biting back the pain from all her fresh bruises to get to her friend. Once she reached Adora, she used her claws to break her seat belt (Adora had been the only person actually strapped in). Catra then retracted them to give her a hug.

As the battle outside began to intensify, Catra forced herself to purr against Adora's chest, hoping it would calm her down once again. In that moment, she did not care about the war, the princesses or the Horde – all she cared about was her scared best friend.

***

Bow and Entrapta stood before Hordak in chains. Lonnie had managed to trap them both in the hot vents over the Forge – forcing them to either surrender or be badly burned.

Hordak growled menacingly at Entrapta, who cowered behind her sentient hair. He then glared at Bow, who stood tall and eyed him defiantly (despite never being so scared in his life). Lonnie then stepped forward to report:

"Lord Hordak, it would seem the two prisoners managed to knock out their guard and were about to escape the Fright Zone. I managed to recapture them." Hordak nodded:

"Good. Very good. You're promoted to Force Captain. Now leave us." Lonnie beamed with pride. She gave the most emphatic salute she could manage before happily marching out of the throne room. Hordak then turned to his two prisoners:

"It seems you lied to me, princess. I thought we had a deal." Entrapta went red from guilt. She moved her hair out of the way and muttered:

"You're right. I'm sorry." Bow turned to his friend in shock:

"No – no you're not sorry!" He then turned back to Hordak:

"We'll never work for you!" Hordak gave an evil grin:

"Really? I don't think you have a choice. You see, I have one of your friends in my custody. A friend who I'll not hesitate to hurt if you dare disobey me." Entrapta went white, exclaiming:

"No! You mustn't hurt people to make others do what you want! That's not right!" Bow added:

"Yeah! Leave Glimmer alone!" Hordak's eyes widened:

"Who said anything about the princess? I was talking about Adora."

***

"You bastards killed Adora…*and now you're gonna pay* !" All Glimmer saw was red. Ever since hitting the first Horde soldier, she had been unable to stop. She had not even noticed that the battle had changed location, or that there were now more than double the original number of Horde soldiers surrounding her. Each time the electricity consumed her, her anger increased and her screams became more deranged. She was angry and she did not care who she hurt.

Mermista, on the other hand, was growing increasingly concerned. She had only one goal in this fight, which was to find Catra. But she had yet to find her.

The water princess fought valiantly, drenching anyone and everyone with water, literally washing soldiers and tanks away, when she was attacked from behind by a furious bear hybrid. Mermista subdued him easily, however, and was soon dangling the Force Captain upside down in front of her. He roared angrily, thrashing at the water princess, before finally giving up.

Mermista then leaned forward, growling:

"Where's Catra?" Grizzlor did not hesitate to point to a tank behind him:

"If you want the Force Commander, she's probably hiding in there." Mermista effortlessly threw Grizzlor away and used her water to reach the tank in a matter of seconds. She then poured as much water as she could into it, making the tank break apart from the inside.

When it fell apart, Catra and a fully armoured Horde guard fell out. Ignoring the soldier, Mermista went straight for the soaking wet feline, grabbing her by the tail and dragging her off into the woods.

If the water princess had stayed and continued fighting, the battle may have ended differently. But she did not and that decision

would cost the princesses.

Once Mermista left, the guard who had been with her stood up and instantly ran after her. Perfuma, who was using her vines to try and corral the drenched and beaten soldiers, easily stopped them. However, the guard then did something totally unexpected. They grabbed an abandoned stun baton and charged straight at the princess.

At this point, all the guards were running away and no one was engaging any of the princesses directly. This guard's move caught Perfuma completely off-guard, and she was too slow to stop herself from being knocked out by their stun baton.

Glimmer, who was still swinging her axe wildly in a blind rage, did not even notice when the same seemingly suicidal guard challenged her directly with nothing but a single stun baton.

When she felt the steel of the baton hit her axe, Glimmer roared angrily, and swiped at her new opponent. The guard dodged and managed to catch the axe once more with their weapon. They held it long enough for Glimmer to have another one of her electrical episodes, at which point the guard did not hesitate to pull back and immobilize her with their weapon.

As soon as Glimmer was down, there was complete silence. At least, there was until a voice that sounded like Mermista's could be heard yelling:

"SAY YOU'RE SORRY!"

***

When the tank began to fill with water, Catra had grabbed Adora's helmet, jammed it on her head, and activated its underwater settings so she could breathe. Catra told herself that, in that moment, she was fully prepared to drown. The reality was that she would never in a million years deny Adora the only chance of survival either of them had.

The tank then filled to such an extent that it broke apart, giving Catra barely enough time to catch her breath before she felt herself get roughly dragged by the tail away from the battle. After a few minutes of this, the pain and humiliation of having her tail pulled angered Catra sufficiently for her to start fighting back.

Catra rolled over and kicked Mermista, causing her to let go of Catra, only to then pin her to the ground with her trident.

Catra did not move. She had never been so scared in her life. The grass of the forest was soaking wet, reminding her that the water princess could have killed her already if she had wanted to. Why did she not want to? Mermista then spoke breathlessly:

"You…took…*everything*…from me!" Catra nodded, deciding to play it cool. She had always been taught that hiding her fear was better than showing it:

"Yep. Guilty." This made Mermista even angrier. She pushed the trident so close to Catra's body that she could feel one of its points hit her ribs. Mermista then shouted:

"SAY YOU'RE SORRY!" Catra's eyes widened. She almost laughed:

"What? I…I don't think I heard you right…" Mermista then leaned closer, speaking through clenched teeth:

"I told you to *apologize*!" Catra genuinely could not believe this. The water princess, one of the most powerful princesses on the whole planet, and whose kingdom she had literally just conquered, had her at her mercy…and all she wanted was an apology? Catra scoffed before muttering:

"I'm sorry. There you go - happy?" Mermista narrowed her eyes:

"No." She then raised her trident, ready to strike the fatal blow, when she suddenly froze and collapsed.

Catra gasped at the Horde guard who had apparently snuck up behind the princess and knocked her out with a single stun baton.

The guard then pulled off their helmet, revealing Adora’s terrified face. She quickly stepped over Mermista and knelt in front of the Force Commander, stammering:

“Catra, are…are you okay?” Catra shook her head, her eyes filling with tears from the emotional toll of what just happened. Without thinking, she pulled Adora in for a hug and whispered:

“Thank you…Princess.”

Chapter End Notes

So, this chapter got pretty dark...would you believe the next chapter's worse?

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> Hey everyone! I hope you enjoy this next chapter! And thank you so much for your kudos and comments - I love them all! :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mermista, Perfuma and Glimmer lay chained up and highly sedated on the forest floor. Once the princesses had been singlehandedly subdued by Adora, the Horde had invaded Plumeria within a matter of hours.

Catra had put Grizzlor in charge of the advancing troops. While he seemed to have a newfound respect for the Force Commander after her victory, Catra was very aware of who had directed Mermista to her and she wanted the Force Captain as far from her as possible.

Meanwhile, Octavia had been badly hit by Glimmer's axe and had been sent back to Salineas with all the other casualties for medical attention. Scorpia had taken her place and was now personally guarding the unconscious princesses. Catra had noticed she kept hovering over Perfuma…

The feline's suspicions were interrupted by a call from Hordak. Catra answered with a tired sigh:

"Yes, Lord Hordak?"

"Catra! Where are you? Status update – now!" Catra fought the urge to roll her eyes. Instead, she smiled and said:

"I'm in the Kingdom of Plumeria. I'm pleased to report that the Horde was victorious in its conquest. Again." Hordak's eyes went wide with surprise. He then suddenly began to laugh. It was one of the worst sounds Catra had ever heard:

"This…this is incredible! Well done, Force Commander! I knew I was right to promote you!" Catra blushed from the compliment but quickly regained her composure:

"Thank you…I've actually got more good news for you! We captured three princesses during the battle!" Hordak gasped, causing Catra to swell up with pride. He then frowned, muttering:

"Show me." Catra quickly turned the screen so he could see the princesses lying on the grass in front of her. Scorpia, who had been brushing some hair out of Perfuma's face, quickly stood back up and gave both Catra and Hordak an awkward smile. Hordak ignored her and growled:

"I see. I'm impressed that you captured the water princess. She will be of much use to us. Bring her back to the Fright Zone." Catra raised her eyebrow. Hordak continued:

"The princess of Plumeria is also a very significant catch, though I feel it would be more beneficial to ransom her…You better bring her back too." Catra cleared her throat, finally asking:

"Lord Hordak, do you *want* me to come back to the Fright Zone?" Hordak ignored her question and continued with his assessment, chuckling evilly:

"You recaptured the princess of Brightmoon? I must say, she's turning into quite a liability for the Rebellion! Maybe we should just send her back to them?" Catra frowned, saying:

"I wouldn't be so sure of that…She did more damage than the other two. Octavia's seriously injured because of her." Hordak took a moment to process this information before asking:

"Force Captain Octavia's injured? Where is she now?" Catra turned the screen back to face her:

"I sent her back to Salineas, along with all the other casualties. We sustained heavy losses in the battle." Hordak frowned in concentration:

"I'll send more reinforcements tonight. Leave Force Captain Grizzlor in charge and return to the Fright Zone with all three of your prisoners. We have much to discuss." Catra wanted to argue with her boss – she had genuinely hoped that once she left the Fright Zone as an officer she would never have to return. But Catra never got what she wanted.

"Yes, Lord Hordak." As she ended the call, Adora walked up to her. After saving Catra, she had become oddly quiet, not moving from the embankment where the princesses were currently lying. Now she slowly approached the feline:

"Catra? Can I ask you something?" Catra raised her eyebrow once again before giving as reassuring a smile as she could manage:

"Yes, Adora?" Adora took a deep breath before finally asking:

"Why did you call me a princess?" Catra's eyes went wide. She had not even realized that she had done that. Not only that, but she could not understand why she had done that. "Princess" was never a term of endearment! She had always meant it as an insult, right?

***

The remaining princesses (except Frosta) were gathered in the War Room in Brightmoon. Queen Angella looked like she was about to cry.

Frosta had returned to her kingdom immediately after the previous meeting, with no guarantee as to if and when she would return.

That left Netossa, Spinerella and Swift Wind looking awkwardly across the table at the queen and her general. The alicorn thought he would break the tension by asking:

"So…um…can I get a chair? I mean, everyone else has a chair and-" He was cut off by Queen Angella suddenly bursting into tears. General Juliet immediately stepped forward, saying:

"This meeting is adjourned. We'll meet back up in-"

"I'm fine, Juliet. Just…update everyone." The general took a deep breath, trying to ignore the queen wiping her eyes in a surprisingly undignified manner:

"Mermista and Glimmer left last night with Perfuma. They reached Plumeria early this morning. A few hours later, the Horde… reached the border of the kingdom of Brightmoon. We have reason to believe that they have taken over Plumeria and that all three princesses are captured, injured or…worse." As General Juliet paused to give the queen a chance to recover from hearing the news a second time, Netossa stood up and protested:

"There is no way Catra pulled that off by herself! There's got to be someone else – Hordak himself maybe? We need to go down there and figure out what happened! If they're going to attack Brightmoon, we need to know what we're dealing with!" Spinerella put a hand on her wife's shoulder:

"Dear, you're still recovering from a concussion. And there's only… two of us…" Queen Angella felt a pang of guilt when she realized that Spinerella had automatically assumed she would not offer to join them. Swift Wind then spoke up:

"I'll go with you! I'll help you escape if anything goes wrong!" Netossa nodded and turned back to her wife:

"See? It's not just you and me. We've got a talking horse too. What could possibly go wrong?"

***

"Catra?" Catra was pulled out of her momentary panic by Scorpia suddenly running up to her. Grateful for the intervention, the Force Commander immediately turned to her:

"Yes, what is it?" Scorpia looked a bit worried.

"Um…what were Hordak's orders? What's…um…going to happen to…um…" Catra raised her eyebrow and gave a mischievous grin before finishing Scorpia's question:

"Princess Perfuma? I've seen how you've been looking at her…" Scorpia went bright red and looked away in embarrassment.

Catra laughed. She could have been nicer but she was desperately hoping that this would distract Adora enough that she would forget her question. Catra should have been more careful what she wished for…

"You like her? That's ridiculous! She's a princess - you should be ashamed!" Catra stopped laughing and stared at Adora. Scorpia looked up in shock. Catra took a deep breath and said:

"I was joking, Adora. Scorpia doesn't like Perfuma! She just-" Catra was suddenly interrupted by Scorpia sobbing. The Force Captain blurted out:

"No, Adora's right! During the battle, she picked me up and was about to throw me - but then she stopped! She recognized me from Princess Prom and wanted to talk to me!" Catra looked at Adora and coughed nervously:

"Yeah…she probably wanted to yell at you for destroying the palace, right?" Scorpia wiped her eyes and sniffled:

"She did say it wasn't very nice…but she also said she knew I was just following orders! And that she liked my dress! No one else said anything nice about my dress!" Scorpia then began crying again and Catra could see Adora getting angrier. The feline quickly rushed over and wrapped the Force Captain in a hug:

"Hey, hey! Scorpia, your dress was very pretty! Remember how I smiled when I saw it? I liked it – I really did!" Adora then erupted:

"Are you serious right now? Catra, she's admitting to being sympathetic to a princess! She should be punished!" Catra frowned and turned back to face Adora, almost yelling:

“Okay, Adora, that’s enough! No one is punishing anyone! Scorpia is sorry – let’s leave it at that!” Adora then pulled out her stun baton menacingly. Her eyes were distant once more and an almost evil smile crawled across her face:

“I’ve got a better idea! Let’s kill Princess Perfuma – that’ll teach her!” Scorpia looked like she was about to faint. Catra quickly got even more assertive:

“Are you even listening to yourself? We can’t do that – we have orders! And even without them, we're soldiers NOT executioners! Now go and...um…help Grizzlor.” Adora gave a look of mild surprise:

“I thought I was supposed to stay with you...” Catra finally yelled:

“I’ll call you back when we start moving out! Now move!” Adora, who now looked a bit shaken by Catra’s sudden change in attitude, took a deep breath, saluted and started to walk away. As soon as she was out of earshot, Catra grabbed Scorpia’s shoulder, pulling her close. She then whispered urgently:

“We need to talk. NOW.”

***

Bow gasped in fear. Entrapta had just proven just how accurate her theory was about runestones controlling the planet’s environment. A dark cloud had started to form over the Fright Zone, rumbling with thunder and lit up with red lightning. Or so Hordak said.

“Well done, Entrapta! You are clearly…a force to be reckoned with...” Entrapta gave a big smile at the compliment. Bow then rushed forward, fell to his knees in front of Hordak and begged:

“Please, please don’t do this!” He then looked up at Entrapta, pleading:

“Entrapta, please turn it off! Do you have any idea how many people are gonna get hurt because of this?” Hordak laughed at the archer, saying:

“Your ‘friends’ have abandoned you. And if you try to sabotage this operation, I will not hesitate to have Adora killed!” Hordak then turned to Entrapta and asked:

“Now then, princess, I have a question for you. What do you know about portals?” Entrapta’s eyes lit up the way they always did when someone asked her about anything scientific.

“Not a lot, but I would LOVE to do some research!” Bow, who was still kneeling on the ground, put his head in his hands.

This was more than a nightmare. There was genuinely nothing Bow could do to fix this. For the first time in his life, he had no hope at all.

***

“But…I can’t just leave! I'm part of the Horde – I’ve always been! My family made that deal, remember? If I go, I’d be breaking it!” Catra pinched her nose and spoke slowly:

“Look, you saw that, right? Adora’s unstable! It’s obvious Shadow Weaver did more to her than just wipe her mind! And she’s – she’s She-Ra! She’s going to kill someone and she’s got it in for you and that princess!” The Force Captain blushed:

“Aww, that’s so sweet of you to be worried about me! Don’t worry, Wildcat - I can take She-Ra on!” Catra yelled:

“Not an unstable She-Ra! I don’t even think I could take her on! Look, the only reason nothing terrible has happened yet is because she doesn’t have her sword and I’m here – but I can’t always be here and who knows how long it’ll be until someone mentions She-Ra to her! That’ll probably be all it takes to make her attack you!” Scorpia looked down at the ground. Catra

realized she had shouted again. She took a deep breath and explained:

"All of this is my fault, Scorpia. I should have never left her in the Black Garnet chamber. This is my responsibility, my mess to clean up. If she kills anyone…I won't be able to forgive myself. And the Rebellion took Adora in. Why wouldn't they do the same for you?" Scorpia shrugged:

"I…ruined Princess Prom?" Catra sighed:

"Aside from that! Look, you're a princess - just like them. Plus you'll be taking a princess back with you! They'll have to trust you after that!" Scorpia still looked unsure, so Catra continued:

"Okay, how about this? I'm asking you to go on a special mission to Brightmoon. Your mission, should you choose to accept it, is to gain the trust of the princesses, learn their plans and tell me using your badge." That was all Scorpia needed to hear. She immediately wrapped Catra in a bear hug, ignoring the feline's protests. When she finally put Catra down, she said:

"I'm so honoured that you thought of me for this mission! I won't let you down, Wildcat!" Catra caught her breath and nodded:

"Sure, whatever. Just make sure you and Perfuma are out of Plumeria before Adora comes back! Also, you better take one of the blankets with you. It's getting really cold."

***

Glimmer shuddered from the freezing cold wind that was sweeping through the Whispering Woods. For some reason, the electrical convulsions had stopped as soon as she had woken up from her induced coma. She still could not teleport though.

Mermista was slung over Scorpia's shoulder, still passed out from the drugs. Perfuma was leaning against Scorpia's other shoulder, with her arm around her neck.

Perfuma had woken up after Glimmer had slapped her and was still pretty out of it. The princess of Brightmoon did not trust the Force Captain but, given the circumstances, she did not have much choice.

The four princesses slipped past the Horde's patrols and made it out of Plumeria. That was when it started snowing. Glimmer turned to Perfuma:

"It's snowing! Has this ever happened before, Perfuma?" The princess shook her head, moaning in pain from having to think at all. Scorpia immediately dumped Mermista on the ground and picked Perfuma up bridal style.

"Perfuma! Are you okay? Do you need anything?" Perfuma gave Scorpia a sweet smile before passing out again. Scorpia blushed uncontrollably. Glimmer then yelled:

"Hey! It's fine - I've got Mermista! Let's move!"

***

Catra rubbed some snow on the fresh bruise on her forehead. She figured now was as good a time as any to inform Hordak of the news. As she started calling him on her communicator, she looked up to see Adora in the distance. She was returning with Grizzlor.

Catra groaned in frustration. She had only requested Adora's return, not Grizzlor's. Her annoyance was interrupted by Hordak answering the call:

"Yes, Catra?" Catra immediately changed her expression to one of fake vulnerability. She gulped and stammered:

"S-Scorpia betrayed us! She knocked me out and freed the princesses! They've already left the kingdom." Hordak gave an angry roar before turning around, grabbing a piece of machinery and throwing it to the ground.

“That traitor! I should’ve known no good would come from keeping her alive!” Catra nodded uncertainly, purposefully ignoring Hordak’s admission of murder and eyeing Adora as she got close enough to see the carnage of the fight. The blonde looked torn between concern and fury. Hordak then said:

“Alright – new orders! You march on Brightmoon immediately! No prisoners – kill them all! You understand me, Force Commander?” Catra nodded, muttering:

“Yes, Lord Hordak.” Without another word, the leader of the Horde hung up on her. Catra pinched her nose. Why had Glimmer had to wake up at the exact moment Scorpia freed Perfuma? Shadow Weaver’s magic must have made her more resistant to the sedation than expected…

“Catra?” Catra turned to look at Adora. Grizzlor was standing to attention next to her. The Force Captain roughly hit Adora’s arm, growling:

“She’s the Force Commander! Salute her!” Adora immediately raised her hand in salute, standing to attention when she did so. Catra gave a small smile at the newfound respect from Grizzlor. She then muttered:

“At ease.” The feline then approached the bear hybrid:

“I don’t recall ordering your return from the frontline?” Grizzlor’s face hardened.

“My outpost was attacked by two princesses. I believe they called each other Netossa and Spinerella? I’d never encountered them before. They were accompanied by this crazy flying horse that could talk. Anyway, Force Captain Adora successfully drove them away!” Grizzlor patted Adora on the shoulder. Catra went white:

“What…happened? Adora, did you keep your helmet on?” Adora nodded and Grizzlor smiled:

“She charged at them and didn’t even wait for my orders! She reminded me of myself when I was her age! She-” Catra cut him off:

“Did she hurt anyone?” Grizzlor raised an eyebrow and nodded:

“Yes. I’m happy to report that she took both of the princesses down - but that wretched horse swooped in and flew them away!” Catra gave a sigh of relief that she pretended was a sigh of frustration. She then looked away and muttered:

“Well…Scorpia betrayed us. The…the princesses are gone.” Adora went white and was about to yell at Catra when Grizzlor stopped her by tightening the grip on her shoulder. He then stepped forward and said:

“It’s alright. We all make mistakes. The important thing is what we do next. What are Hordak’s orders?” Catra took a deep breath and looked at Adora:

“As soon as the new reinforcements arrive we’re…going to Brightmoon.” Adora’s face changed from one of anger to one of deranged happiness. Even Grizzlor raised an eyebrow at her sudden change of expression. Adora then asked:

“So…we’ll get to kill Perfuma after all?” Catra nodded uneasily, before adding:

“I’ll kill the princesses. You focus on capturing them and bringing them to me.” It was finally dawning on Catra that Adora might never go back to the way she was. However, if there was even a chance she could be saved from whatever Shadow Weaver had done to her, Catra was going to do everything in her power to make sure she did nothing she would regret when she finally woke up – namely killing any of her princess friends.

Catra would do that instead. She would be the villain that Adora hated. That was even who she had been before Adora’s mind was wiped, right? How could she have ever hoped for anything different? Catra never got what she wanted.

***

As Scorpia hesitantly walked up to Perfuma to pick her up, Glimmer began to stir. She turned and stared at Scorpia unchaining Perfuma. She then yelled:

"Hey bitch! Let me go!" Scorpia looked at her as if she had seen a ghost. She then pointed a pincer at herself and stammered:

"D-Do you mean me?" Refusing to let Scorpia take that insult, Catra pounced on the Force Captain, making her fall backwards. She then hissed:

"No, she was talking to me! Now surrender yourself, traitor!" Scorpia threw Catra off her and stood back up.

Glimmer then got up, freeing herself from her chains which had been accidentally cut apart by Catra's claws when she had jumped on Scorpia. The princess then went over to Mermista and began unchaining her too. Catra yelled:

"You won't get away with this!" She then charged at Scorpia and swiped at her. Little did Glimmer know that Catra had chosen this attack specifically because she knew it would be easy for Scorpia to disarm her. The Force Captain grabbed Catra's hands with her pincers, picking her off the ground. She then readied her tail to paralyze the feline. She whispered:

"I'm sorry, Wildcat…" Catra gave Scorpia the tiniest nod, whispering:

"Do what you gotta do."

When Scorpia stung her, Catra felt Scorpia gently lie her on the ground. Then everything went black.

When Catra woke up, she was covered in snow and surrounded by guards. She angrily got up and shooed them all away. She then turned to where the princesses had been, and saw nothing but empty chains.

Catra hoped Scorpia was long gone. She hoped the princesses would reward her 'betrayal' just as they had with Adora. She also hoped that Adora would wake up one day and realize that Catra had done all of this for her. Because…well…Catra had always liked Adora, right?

Chapter End Notes

Next stop: Brightmoon! You guys are not going to believe what's coming next...

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

> Hey everyone! Sorry it took me a little longer to update than expected - I dared to go on holiday for a few days XD
> Anyway, I'm back now and I'm pleased to report that this chapter has all the angst you wanted and more. Enjoy! :))

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Well? What happened?" Netossa squirmed as the doctor set her broken leg. Spinerella held her wife's hand and whispered:

"It's okay, it's okay…" When it became obvious neither of the princesses were going to answer the queen's question, Swift Wind stepped forward:

"There was this one Horde soldier – they were crazy! They just ran forward and tackled Netossa, forcing her to ground! Spinerella blew them away but Netossa's leg was broken! That's when I swooped in the save the day, but the soldier leapt up super high and tazed me with their stun baton! I fell to the ground and don't know what happened after that…" Spinerella sighed, finishing the story:

"Netossa saved Swift Wind by wrapping him in a net and dragging him over to us. Meanwhile, I did my best to hold the soldier off… but they were incredibly strong! And while this fight was happening, an entire troop of Horde soldiers just stood still *watching* us – like the whole thing was some awful experiment!" Netossa, who was now recovering from the doctor's treatment, squeezed her wife's hand reassuringly and said:

"The Horde has changed tactics. They're not leading with bots anymore. They're leading with soldiers – more specifically this one. We need to be ready for them. If we work together, we can-" Juliet, who had been doing her best to keep her cool, finally lost it:

"What? Defeat one soldier?! What about the other one hundred? We've just received confirmation that the Horde is marching on Brightmoon – they'll be here in a few hours!" Angella put her head in her hands. No one had spoken about it yet, but a terrible storm was blowing outside the palace. It was unnatural, defined by its deafening thunder and bright red lightning, and it was originating from the Fright Zone. Not only that but there was an awful snow storm in the Whispering Woods, and the moving landscape had frozen in place. If it had not been for Swift Wind's quick recovery, there was no way he and the two princesses would have escaped. Angella then whispered:

"I'll activate the distress beacon. Maybe Princess Frosta will come…she's all we have left…" Juliet then turned the queen and almost yelled:

"With all due respect, Your Majesty, that's a terrible plan! We need to leave – we can't stay here! We need to go to Princess Frosta, not wait for her to come to us! I hate to state the obvious but we're all that's left of the Rebellion! Mermista, Perfuma, Entrapta… your daughter…they've all been captured or worse! Adora is… dead…and Princess Frosta has made it very clear that she does not want to be involved in this fight! The best we can hope from her is sanctuary – nothing else! We don't even have Bow or Mermista's friend - whatever his name was! It's hopeless. It's completely hopeless…"

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Entrapta laughed giddily as the Black Garnet glowed even redder from all the energy it was consuming. Bow was handcuffed to a pipe in the corner of the room, watching helplessly as the princess literally hacked the planet.

Hordak had dropped by at least three times since this whole operation began. He was clearly quite taken with the princess and her incredible skillset. Bow was amazed by it too, but he could not help but feel really hurt by what Entrapta was doing.

Bow understood the princess better than most people (being a bit of a science geek himself). He knew how exciting it was to explore, discover, design and create, but Entrapta did not seem to have a moral compass to guide her scientific endeavours. Not only that but she seemed to actually enjoy working with Hordak, as well as causing untold damage outside the Fright Zone.

Bow tried to yell at Entrapta again, but it was no use. The rag he was gagged with was tied so tightly he could not even move his mouth. Bow slumped back down to the ground in despair. He thought of Adora, all alone in a cell in the deepest darkest depths of the Fright Zone.

Bow shed a tear. She-Ra was defeated and he still had no idea whether Glimmer was even alive. It was hopeless. Completely hopeless…

***

Glimmer groaned in frustration. While she now seemed to be cured of her electrical spasms, the snow storm had gotten so bad that she and Scorpia had had to stop and shelter themselves in a cave somewhere in the Whispering Woods. The former Force Captain had spent the last ten minutes trying to revive Perfuma with no success. Glimmer had been doing the same with Mermista, also with little to no effect.

The princess finally turned to the Force Captain, yelling:

"Okay, seriously, what was in those drugs?!" Scorpia shrugged her shoulders sadly:

"Shadow Weaver made them…I have no idea…" Glimmer growled angrily:

"Great! Just great! Not only did that bitch kill Adora and take my powers, but she's also poisoned the only two people left who could've actually stopped you – I mean, the Horde!" Scorpia lowered her eyes, mumbling:

“What about Princess Frosta? We-I mean, the Horde, doesn’t have her…”

“No! You’ve just got everyone else! I mean, come on! Aren’t you satisfied? Haven’t you got what you wanted?! Etheria’s on its knees!” Scorpia curled up in a ball, hugging herself with her pincers. Realizing that she had disregarded the Force Captain’s decision to leave the Horde, Glimmer blushed in embarrassment:

“Sorry, sorry! I didn’t mean to yell at you like that! If Bow was here, he’d be really mad I did that...” Glimmer teared up thinking about her missing friend. Scorpia looked up at the princess:

“Did you say ‘Bow’?” Glimmer nodded slowly. Scorpia tried to give a reassuring smile:

“He’s okay. At least, I think he is. He was still in his cell when we left for Salineas, so…” Scorpia stopped talking when Glimmer suddenly started to sob:

“It’s hopeless! It’s completely hopeless!”

***

Catra sat in the back of yet another tank with Adora once again seated in front of her. Unlike last time, however, Adora was not nervous. She was oddly confident, cleaning her trusty stun baton and grinning malevolently whenever it buzzed with electricity. Catra tried not to stare at her but she could not help it.

Everything finally made sense now. Shadow Weaver had not only wiped her mind but left something behind – something evil and uncontrollable. It had taken a while to fully develop, but, just like Hordak had said, all Adora had needed was some actual fighting to get her head in the game. The feline’s thoughts were interrupted by her communicator ringing. It was Grizzlor:

“Force Commander! I’m calling to confirm that my troops have surrounded Brightmoon. Shall I give the order to attack?” Catra sighed, saying:

“No, let me call the queen first. A surrender would be better for our troops.” With that, Catra hung up. Feeling Adora’s judging eyes glaring at her, Catra looked up at her friend:

“We don’t have that many reinforcements. Now put your helmet on.” Catra then began ringing the channel Hordak had used to initially contact the queen after Princess Prom. She received an answer almost immediately:

“What do you want?” The person who had answered was a woman with dark hair and pointy ears, dressed in full armour. Catra was a little taken aback. This is not what she thought the Queen of Brightmoon looked like. She quickly regained her composure and said:

“I’m the Force Commander of the Horde. My troops have you surrounded. You are outnumbered and outgunned. Do yourselves a favour and surrender.” The woman frowned angrily, almost yelling:

“I know who you are, Catra! Why don’t you do Etheria a favour and-”

“That’s enough, Juliet!” A regal figure with large wings emerged behind the woman in armour. Catra’s eyes went wide. She had not been talking to the Queen of Brightmoon after all... Angella pushed past Juliet and looked sadly at the screen:

“If we surrender, do I have your word no one will be harmed?” Catra was about to lie and nod, but Adora suddenly grabbed her communicator and growled menacingly through her helmet:

“You’re gonna die no matter what! Your reign of tyranny is over!” Catra tackled Adora and took the communicator back, fighting the urge to yell Adora’s name. She then glanced at the screen, observing both Angella and Juliet’s pale faces. Pinching her nose, Catra turned back to Adora:

“Force Captain, go outside *now*!” Adora slowly got up, opened the hatch and climbed out of the tank. Catra then turned back to the

leaders of the Rebellion:

"As I was saying, your people will be safe. As will your soldiers. I… I can't guarantee what'll happen to you…" Catra did not know why she felt so bad. Was it because she did not recognize Adora anymore? Or was it because she did not believe in what she was fighting for?

Catra had never bought into the Horde's mission. She despised Hordak and hated Shadow Weaver more than she could say. She would have left in a heartbeat if it had not been for Adora. And now, once again, Adora was the main reason the feline was still here.

Collecting herself once more, Catra continued:

"Surrender is still your best option. I'm a soldier, a commander, and I know how many of our men and women will die before this battle is over. Hand yourselves over and none of them get hurt." Juliet's expression changed from one of pure hatred to one of surprise. Angella then took a deep breath and nodded:

"Alright. We surrender."

***

The rain had finally started. It was pelting down outside the palace and Catra honestly did not want to have to do this outside. However, the surrender had to be public and this was the most effective way for it to be done.

The Brightmoon guards had already marched outside and dropped their weapons in the water. The Horde's soldiers, under Grizzlor's command, had moved in closer so they were visibly surrounding both the town and the palace (the town was empty, presumably evacuated long before the Horde arrived).

The doors of the palace opened once more and the queen and her general slowly began to walk across the bridge to where Catra's tank was waiting. When the drivers told the Force Commander the

queen was coming, Catra turned to Adora who was now back in the tank and sulking.

"I'm going to go outside and deal with this. You are going to stay in here, no matter what happens. *That's an order*!" As Catra braced herself for the cold rain that would definitely fall directly in her face the second she opened the hatch, Adora growled:

"Hordak gave orders too. Have you forgotten them, *Force Commander*?" Catra stared at her friend in disbelief. Flexing her claws aggressively, Catra snarled:

"You're a *Force Captain*, Adora. I *outrank* you – *don't* forget that!" With that, Catra clambered out of the vehicle, immediately getting drenched in water. She could barely see more than halfway across the bridge, only making out the outline of Angella's wings as she approached.

Catra grimaced when she thought of what she would have to do to the queen. The feline had always been ambivalent about the idea of killing someone. She figured she would if she had to, but she would need a very compelling reason. Meanwhile, Adora (before Shadow Weaver scrambled her brains) had been completely against it. It was one of the very few things she had argued with Shadow Weaver about.

Adora had always believed that true power came from giving life – not taking it. She had probably been right. And now no one wanted to kill more than Adora…

The second Catra jumped to the ground, her badge beeped. The feline gasped: it was Scorpia.

"Scorpia? Is that you?"

"Hey Wildcat! Yes, it's me! I'm sorry I missed your call earlier! I've only just got away from Glimmer and the others. Is everything alright?" Catra felt like she was going to cry. There was something about Scorpia's cheerful voice that really offset the feline's depression.

"No…it's not. Are you in Brightmoon yet?" Catra could hear Scorpia move her head and then realize that the Force Commander could not see whether she was nodding or shaking it.

"No, no we haven't got there yet. We're stuck in a cave the Whispering Woods. I just stepped outside to talk to you and…it's… really cold…" Ignoring Scorpia's obvious suffering, Catra quickly said:

"That's fine. Look, you can't come to Brightmoon! I'm here now and I'm about to accept Queen Angella's surrender. Hordak has said he doesn't want any prisoners and Adora's on the warpath! You and the princesses need to stay away!" With that, Catra hung up. The queen and her general had got close enough to hear her last sentence. Juliet sneered:

"Are you calling your soldiers 'princesses'? I didn't realize you respected us so much." Catra scowled:

"They're an elite fighting team of utterly repulsive insect hybrids. They're also about to eat your soldiers alive unless we get this over with." Catra genuinely had no idea where that lie had come from, but she had always been good at thinking on her feet. Angella then sighed and shouted so everyone could hear her:

"I, Queen Angella of Brightmoon, hereby surrender my kingdom to the Horde!" Juliet then offered a large decorative staff to Catra, muttering:

"This belonged to King Micah. Don't drop it." Catra frowned at the general, accepted the staff and held it high above her head, yelling:

"I, Catra, Force Commander of the Horde, accept your surrender!" A particularly large crash of thunder, followed by a nasty flash of red lightning, served to emphasize Catra's words. The feline then began to examine the staff in her hands, muttering:

"So, does it do anything? Or is it literally just a stick?" Juliet scoffed and Angella gave a sad smile:

"It's designed for magic wielders. It fires magical blasts." Catra raised her eyebrow and mumbled to herself:

"Well, I better keep it away from Shadow Weaver then." The feline then looked up at the queen and her general, both of whom were so soaking wet and defeated that it made Catra pity them.

The Force Commander turned to Juliet, pointed to where the entirety of her army was sitting despondently on the grass outside the palace, and said:

"Go over there. Lead your soldiers north to where my Force Captain is waiting. He'll let you and your army go." Juliet looked shocked:

"You're…you're not going to imprison us?" Catra rolled her eyes:

"I told you nothing would happen to you. Just drop your sword in the water and go." Juliet nodded slowly. She then turned to Angella and gave one final salute before marching down to her troops. When the army saw her coming, they all slowly stood up and started to follow her towards the forest.

Catra and Angella watched awkwardly as the last occupants of Brightmoon walked away. After a few moments of silence, the feline turned back to the queen:

"I assume the palace is empty? The staff, flying horses, extra princesses…they're all gone?" Angella nodded. Catra took a deep breath. She then looked back down at King Micah's staff.

"Do you want this back?" The queen looked confused:

"It's…it's the royal sceptre…it's yours-"

"Just take it! I'm not killing an unarmed woman!" Angella's face went white as she gasped:

"So…you are going to try and kill me?" Catra threw the staff at the queen, unsheathing her claws as she did so. The queen caught it

somewhat clumsily.

"It's nothing personal – Hordak's orders." The queen looked at Catra with a look of absolute despair. She then took a deep breath of her own and dropped the staff on the ground, muttering:

"I'm not fighting you. The Horde took my husband and my daughter…what do I care if it takes me too?" Catra's eyes went wide. She began to panic. Never had she not wanted to kill someone so badly.

The feline began to debate wildly with herself: what if she called Hordak and begged? Surely there was some way she could spin this to make the queen's survival necessary? Or maybe there was some way she could get the queen angry enough to fight her? That would not be too difficult – Catra was great at getting people angry…

Before Catra could decide on what to do, the hatch of the tank behind her opened and a crazed Force Captain jumped out. Their helmet was on and their war cry was loud:

"Die, Rebel Scum!"

***

Adora had sat still inside the tank for over ten minutes. She had thought that would be more than enough time for Catra to accept the queen's surrender and then kill her. However, as more time passed, and the drivers informed her that Catra had just returned the queen's weapon to her, Adora knew the Force Commander was too weak to finish the job.

The Force Captain decided it was time to take matters into her own hands. In one swift motion, she opened the hatch and climbed out, seeing Catra frozen in front of the defeated leader of the Rebellion.

Adora's heart filled with hate and she started to see red. This woman was the tyrant Hordak had been fighting for so long – no

one deserved to die more than she did! With that, Adora cried:

"Die, Rebel Scum!" She then activated her stun baton and ran forward, leaping off the tank and landing right in front of the Queen of Brightmoon.

Angella simply stared at her in mild surprise, not really caring whether or not the Force Captain was going to kill her.

Adora faltered for a second. While she had no qualms about killing this woman, it was rather unsatisfying that she was not pleading for mercy. That second's hesitation turned out to be a mistake, as Catra grabbed Adora from behind, pushing her to the ground.

"Adora! Stop!" Adora looked up at her friend and kicked her hard, pinning her down once she fell:

"Stop? Why did *you* stop? You have the Queen of Brightmoon on her knees! She has to die!"

"Adora?" Both Catra and Adora turned to look at Angella, who now looked like she had seen a ghost. There was something wrong with the way the queen had said her name…as if she knew her… The Force Captain stood back up and pointed her stun baton at Angella's face:

"How do you know my name?" Catra gave a gasp of exasperation:

"Because I just said your name *like the idiot I am*!" With that, Catra jumped back up and onto Adora's back, forcing her to the ground once more. Then three things happened at once:

The moonstone, which had been slowly turning dark every time it was hit by the horrid red lightning, finally turned off for good.

Angella, who had previously not shown any interest in fighting, suddenly raised her staff and hit Adora's helmet with an astonishing amount of strength, causing it to fall apart.

And Catra's badge began to beep, followed by Scorpia's voice yelling:

"Catra! Mermista woke up and she's on her way! She's got Glimmer with her! Catra? Catra?!"

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Angella could not believe it. The soldier was Adora. Her hair was short and her eyes were angry and distant…but it was her…

In an impressive show of strength, Adora pushed Catra off her and charged at the queen. Angella flew out of her reach, hovering as the blonde began madly swiping at the air with her stun baton. The Force Captain then threw her weapon at the queen and would have hit her…had it not been for Catra. The feline jumped in the way, getting tazed instead.

Seeing Catra's unconscious body fall back down to the ground, drenched in rain and bruised from the fight, made Adora stop for a second. She looked at her friend and then at the queen, who looked just as surprised as Adora did at what the feline had just done.

Finally finding her voice, Angella muttered:

"It's so good to see you again, Adora. Look after Catra…she's not as bad as you think..." With that, the queen flew away. Once she was high enough, she saw a giant tidal wave making its way to Brightmoon. She flew down to it.

There was no sense in freeing Brightmoon now – the best the Rebellion could do now was fall back and regroup.

As the queen stopped her flight in front of the advancing wall of water, the wave suddenly stopped to reveal Mermista. The water princess then said, in her signature monotone voice:

"Your Majesty, you're alive. How thrilling." Then a face Angella never thought she would see again emerged from behind

Mermista: her daughter.

“Glimmer!”

***

Grizzlor ran up to the bridge, having been called there by Force Captain Adora. The rain had died down but was still falling lightly. The storm itself seemed to be passing...

Once Grizzor got there, he found the Force Commander lying unconscious in Adora’s arms. The blonde was holding Catra’s badge in one of her hands, staring at it intensely. Grizzlor growled:

“What happened? Where’s the queen?” Adora turned to face him, revealing the tears streaming down her cheeks. She spluttered:

“She-she escaped! Catra helped her! I had to knock her out – I had to!” Adora then began to cry into Catra’s mane. Grizzlor, visibly uncomfortable with this show of weakness, walked up to the Force Captain and slapped her hard on the cheek:

“Pull yourself together! You’re supposed to be an officer! I don’t know whether or not you had any right to do what you did, but it’s not for me to decide! Protocol states that Hordak himself handles every officer dispute – which includes this. I’ll take over here. Both of you are going back to the Fright Zone!” Adora nodded slowly, wiping her eyes and getting back up. She then lifted Catra bridal style and headed back to the tank.

Adora was scared. She knew that what Catra had done was punishable by death. She did not want Catra to die… no matter how much she deserved it… Maybe Hordak would be merciful and simply punish her? Or maybe Adora could try and protect her? Honestly, it was hopeless… completely hopeless…

Chapter End Notes

Well, that was fun! Next stop: the Fright Zone (and Hordak...) I'm afraid it'll be a few weeks before the next update because I need to write my thesis on historical bias in French media. Once I'm done though, I'll be coming back to torture our favourite lesbians some more! ;)

Thank you for all your lovely kudos and comments! They mean the world to me! :))

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

> Hey everyone! The angst is back and even more intense than before! Catra has a really bad time in this chapter but I gave you some free Scorfuma content to make up for it! Anyway, I hope you enjoy and THANK YOU SOOO MUCH for all the comments and kudos! I love them all! :))

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora breathed heavily as she steered the skiff through the Whispering Woods. The forest has been almost entirely destroyed by the snow and, while the storm had stopped and moonlight was starting to shine through the clouds, it was clear it would be months before the forest fully recovered.

The Force Captain bit her lip nervously when the Fright Zone came into view. She then glanced down at her unconscious passenger, now lying perfectly still on the floor of the skiff: Catra.

Adora could not help but admire how beautiful she looked. But then she would remember what the feline had done, causing her to frown in anger and frustration.

Catra deserved to die for betraying Hordak. She needed to be punished for her cowardice and insubordination. Adora had even heard Scorpia talking to the Force Commander – the feline had been working with a traitor! Despite all this, however, some part of Adora refused to accept it. She needed Catra. Adora was not sure how and why, but she did.

When they arrived, Adora parked the skiff and gently lifted Catra up, carrying her to the Throne Room.

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When Catra woke up, she found herself in a dark room. Her hands were cuffed and her head hurt terribly. Just when the feline's senses told her she was back in the Fright Zone, her suspicions were confirmed by the lights suddenly turning on, revealing she was in the Throne Room. Hordak stood on the stairs leading up to his seat of power – his red eyes glaring down at her.

Catra tried and failed to get up. She was too dizzy to move and too scared to speak. How had she even made it to the Fright Zone so fast? Who had taken control after she was tazed? Was it Adora? Just then, Catra's senses identified the Force Captain standing behind her.

The feline spun her head around, looking for her friend. She saw Adora looking down at her with a dark expression. Catra could not tell if she was angry or sad.

"Force Commander?" Catra gulped. This was it – she was certain of it. Hordak was finally going to kill her.

Catra looked up at the Horde's leader, replying as indifferently as possible:

"Yes, Lord Hordak?" Hordak narrowed his eyes and growled:

"Force Captain Adora says you helped the Queen of Brightmoon escape and that you let her entire army go. She also says you are working with a traitor: Force Captain Scorpia. Is this true?" Catra turned back to look at Adora. The Force Captain looked away sadly.

Realizing that going against Adora's testimony would get her friend in trouble, Catra decided to make the ultimate sacrifice: admit the truth. Yes, Adora was not like she was before Shadow Weaver changed her…but she was still Adora and Catra loved her in spite of everything.

"Yes, it's true."

***

"I hope Hordak gets back soon! I cannot wait to show him the progress I've made on his new project!" Bow made a half-hearted attempt to reply to Entrapta but the gag still prevented him from communicating. He had been tied up for a couple of hours now, watching helplessly as Entrapta worked to fix Hordak's portal machine.

It had been three hours since Hordak had come down to the Black Garnet chamber to announce that his forces had taken Brightmoon and the war was all but over. He had then ordered Entrapta to stop tampering with the Back Garnet and to go with him to his sanctum. He had a new project for her. Bow had been temporarily untied and dragged to the new location as well.

Entrapta did not seem to have noticed Bow's suffering nor his many attempts at getting her attention. At this point, Bow had all but given up hope of escape; but he was still clinging to the possibility that Entrapta would listen to him if he could just get his gag removed.

As Bow was about to try biting through the rag for the twentieth time, Lonnie suddenly burst into the sanctum. Entrapta, who was engrossed in her work, barely acknowledged her presence. The new Force Captain headed straight for Bow and roughly pulled off his gag.

"Okay, Rebel Scum, you have ten seconds to tell me whether or not Catra is secretly working for the Rebellion!"

***

"Catra *helped* the Rebellion? Are you serious?!"

"Absolutely! She told me to take Glimmer, Mermista and Perfuma back to Brightmoon! She gave me a secret mission to tell her what you were up to once we got there but…after what Queen Angella said, I'm not so sure she was using that information to hurt you…" Glimmer scoffed at Scorpia's words:

"You're lying! You have to be lying! I saw you fighting Catra – you stung her!" Scorpia visibly grimaced at the memory, mumbling:

"She told me to. It had to look real…" Mermista groaned in frustration, but was soon soothed by Sea Hawk massaging her shoulders.

The pirate had rushed to the aid of the princesses by picking them up in his ship after Mermista had got them all to the sea. He had taken them to the Kingdom of Snows, and they were now installed in Princess Frosta's palace, Queen Angella had finally told everyone about how Catra had sacrificed herself to save her. She had also related how the feline had let Juliet and the whole army go. The queen had not yet mentioned Adora.

The story of Catra's heroism had led to doubt and confusion from the princesses that Scorpia had felt compelled to explain. That explanation had now turned into a full confession.

Netossa, who had asked the initial question, finally resumed her interrogation:

"Okay, Scorpia. Assuming you're telling the truth, and Catra really is *helping* us, why is she? What are you not telling us?"

Scorpia, who was currently tied in Perfuma's vines while standing before Frosta's throne, looked at the woman who literally held her life in her hands and said:

"One of the Force Captains threatened to kill Perfuma and the others. She wanted to hurt me too. Catra was trying to save our lives." An awkward silence descended over the Great Hall. After nearly a moment had passed, Frosta asked:

"And who is this Force Captain?" Queen Angella then spoke up for the first time since Scorpia's initial confession:

"It was Adora. She's alive."

***

"Well, Adora, I must congratulate you. It seems you have uncovered one of the greatest traitors the Horde has ever known." Adora barely heard what Hordak was saying. She could not take her eyes off Catra.

Since the feline's confession, she had remained sitting on the floor of the Throne Room, not trying to get up or even look up at anything at all. Catra seemed resigned to her fate and Adora could not understand why she was not trying to offer up some justification for her actions. Hordak continued:

"Bring her to my sanctum. I have a machine that's well-suited for dealing with animals like her." As Hordak marched past the two women, heading for his sanctum, Adora looked desperately at Catra.

The Force Captain knew Hordak was going to hurt the feline…he might even kill her! The blonde pulled the former Force Commander off the ground and whispered urgently in her ear:

"I know you're not a traitor – I know it! If you just explain why you did it, I'm sure Hordak'll listen to you!" Catra looked at Adora with an expression of mild surprise before giving her a small smile:

"Nice to know you care, Princess…"

***

When Catra was brought into Hordak's sanctum, the first thing that caught her eye was the giant machine at the end of the room. The next thing she saw was Entrapta attaching something to the device with her sentient hair.

As Catra began to scan the room properly, she was surprised to see Bow being interrogated by Lonnie, who now had a Force Captain's badge. They both stopped talking when they saw her. Hordak then ordered Adora to bring Catra into the darkest corner of the room.

Adora gently pushed Catra to the ground, allowing her to kneel on the floor instead of falling face first. When Catra looked back up, her eyes met Hordak's. The leader of the Horde motioned for Adora to move back before leaning forward and snarling:

"I didn't want to do this, Catra, but you leave me no choice. This is what happens to traitors." With that, Hordak pulled a lever and all the air seemed to suddenly disappear, leaving Catra in a vacuum.

At first, the feline panicked and tried to move. She quickly found, however, that she was also unable to stand up due to an artificially increased gravitational pull.

As Catra collapsed to the ground, convulsing from lack of air and gradually losing control of her senses, the feline used all her remaining strength to turn her head to look at Adora. Catra wanted the last thing she saw to be the one good thing in her life. However, by the time she had managed to focus on her friend, the blonde had charged forward, leaping over Catra and attacking Hordak.

Catra gave a tiny smile before passing out yet again. She was right: Adora was still in there, protecting her until the end.

***

"ADORA! ADORA!" Bow kept screaming his friend's name, desperate for her to acknowledge him and explain what was happening. After Lonnie's initial question about Catra's loyalty, Bow had denied knowing anything about anything, pleading with the Force Captain to let him go and calling out to Entrapta with no success. Lonnie had been about to reapply Bow's gag when Hordak had suddenly walked in, followed by a handcuffed Catra and Adora in a full suit of Horde armour.

Both Bow and Lonnie had gasped in astonishment. Adora's hair was cut short and her expression was dark and distant. She did

not look over at them, instead pushing Catra to the ground in a corner of Hordak's sanctum.

Bow had called over to Adora but had received no response. He had then watched in horror as Hordak activated the machine and Catra collapsed. At this moment, Lonnie had audibly gasped, covering her mouth with her hands. Even Entrapta had stopped what she was doing and made her way over and see what was happening. It was at this moment that Adora had attacked.

The blonde had leapt over Catra's limp body, landing on Hordak and forcing him to the ground. Adora had then turned off the machine, which had led to Hordak roaring in anger, firing his weapon directly at the blonde's face. He had narrowly missed her, but his laser had left a long cut down the left-side of her face. Adora had screamed in pain, pulled out her trusty stun baton, and hit Hordak so violently that he passed out.

After a moment of terrifying silence, Bow started screaming:

"Adora? ADORA!"

***

"Adora is dead. I saw Shadow Weaver kill her…" Glimmer's face was pale as she recalled the memory. Queen Angella shook her head and approached her daughter, pulling her in for a hug. She whispered:

"She's alive. She's not herself…but it's her." Swift Wind whinnied, exclaiming:

"That explains it! I've been feeling like I still had a connection with She-Ra! I just wasn't sure how it was possible!" Mermista hit the buffet table angrily:

"*Hello*? Are we forgetting that it was *Adora* who attacked us?! She's working with Catra and is clearly no longer on our side! She even tried to kill the queen! We have to treat her like the enemy she is!" Netossa sighed, propping herself up on her crutches:

"Unfortunately, Mermista's right. Adora's not in her right mind and she's dangerous. It's great that she's alive, but we've got to accept that she's now a member of the Horde." Frosta rolled her eyes:

"So, the honorary princess who ruined Princess Prom also betrayed you and joined the enemy? That's not very surprising." This got Glimmer mad, causing her to yell:

"Hey, watch it! Adora was…*is* our friend! She was distracted at Princess Prom just like the rest of us! And it wasn't her who ruined your party – it was Catra!" Frosta scoffed:

"Oh, please! The second Catra walked in, Adora was all over her. I may be only eleven but I know a homoerotic dance when I see one. They were working together!" Several of the princesses blushed, remembering Catra dipping Adora. Angella then frowned:

"Princess Frosta, regardless of whatever romantic affiliation you claim to have witnessed, it does not change the fact that Adora is She-Ra and she pledged her allegiance to the Rebellion. She helped us save the kingdoms of almost everyone in this room, fighting the Horde and Catra on numerous occasions! I am certain something has been done to her to make her act this way!" Mermista hummed loudly:

"I don't know…the emotionless child has a point. She never actually killed any of the Horde's soldiers, did she?" Glimmer crossed her arms angrily:

"Should she have?" Ignoring her, Mermista continued:

"And what about Catra? Did she ever hurt her?" Scorpia nodded slowly, murmuring:

"They hurt each other. A lot."

***

Adora finally turned to face the dark-skinned boy in the crop top. He was tied to the pipes behind her, and the Force Captain standing next to him pulled out her stun baton. Before Adora could do anything, however, a woman with long sentient purple hair suddenly appeared in front of her. She looked right past the blonde, staring at Hordak's fallen body and shouting in alarm:

"Hordak!" Adora grabbed the woman's shirt and pulled her towards her while growling:

"Who are you?" The princess gave a hesitant smile before chirping nervously:

"Hey Adora! I'm Entrapta! Nice to meet you again!" Adora glared at Entrapta, snarling:

"You're a princess…Hordak was working with a princess?" The other Force Captain, who was still standing by the tied up boy, activated her stun baton. The boy then yelled:

"Adora! What's happening? Is Catra okay? Are you okay? Please say something!" Adora raised an eyebrow at the boy:

"And who are you supposed to be?" The Force Captain responded for him:

"I'm Force Captain Lonnie and this is Bow. He works for the Rebellion and I was interrogating him." Adora nodded slowly, muttering:

"In Hordak's sanctum? He must be an important member of the Rebellion to be held here…" Adora then let Entrapta go, pushing her to the ground. The princess fell down with a thud and Adora turned around, rushing to where Catra lay motionless on the floor.

As the blonde cradled Catra in her arms, Lonnie slowly walked towards them both. As she did, she spoke slowly and deliberately:

"Okay, Adora, we can do this the easy way or the hard way…put Catra down and surrender!" Adora looked up at Lonnie. Her eyes

were filled with pain as she stood up and silently showed Lonnie Catra's Force Commander badge. Pinning it on her armour, Adora then announced:

"*I'm* now the leader of the Horde. Both Hordak and Catra worked with princesses, meaning they have betrayed the very mandate of this army. You now work for me." Lonnie raised her eyebrow, considering her options.

If Kyle and Rogelio had been there, she would have ignored Adora and the three of them would have taken her down. They were not there, however, and the only people who could have helped her were either tied up or knocked out. So Lonnie made the only logical choice she could:

"Alright. Whatever you say, Adora."

"*Lord* Adora. You'll address me as Lord Adora." Lonnie nodded nervously. Bow gasped in disbelief while Entrapta got back up and ran back towards the machine she had been working on. Adora continued:

"Now then, I want you to take Hordak to the cells. I'll deal with Catra." Lonnie nodded once more, awkwardly saluting as she did so. She then threw her former employer over her shoulder and walked out of the room. As Adora turned back to Catra, Bow yelled:

"Adora, please! You don't mean that – you can't! You're She-Ra! You're our friend! You-" Adora interrupted him:

"She-Ra? Who's She-Ra?" Before Bow could answer, Catra stirred. Adora ignored him and fell to her knees next to her friend.

***

When Catra woke up, the person she saw was Adora. She still had her short hair and they were both still in Hordak's sanctum. Adora looked concerned, whispering:

"It's okay, it's just me. Are you alright?" Catra nodded slowly, trying to get up and realizing her hands were still cuffed. She murmured:

"Well, I'm not dead. That's got to count for something." The feline then looked back at Adora, noticing a long red cut down the left side of her face. It cut Adora's eyebrow in two and Catra realized it was bleeding.

The Force Commander immediately forced herself up, summoning all her strength to raise her cuffed hands and hold Adora's face in her hands, saying:

"Adora, you're bleeding! What happened? Are *you* alright?" Adora gave a small smile, blushed and nodded, clearly enjoying Catra's touch way too much. The sweet moment was interrupted by Bow, who Catra had forgotten was in the room.

"Catra, are you okay? What's going on over there?" Adora growled angrily, standing up and walking over to Bow:

"Did I give you permission to be speak, prisoner? Shut up!" Bow's face went pale as he pleaded:

"Adora, please! You're scaring me!" Adora's expression changed as she crossed the room. Gone was the earnest love and concern she had for Catra. Now she was the ruthless leader of the Horde, and she was going to teach this Rebel Scum a lesson.

As Adora pulled out her stun baton again, activating it and raising it above her head, Catra yelled:

"NOOO! Adora, stop!" Adora lowered her weapon and turned back to face the feline. Catra sighed, saying:

"You're not thinking clearly. You haven't been thinking clearly for a long time. A while ago, Shadow Weaver messed with your head. Do you remember that?" Adora furrowed her brow, nodding uncertainly. Catra continued:

"She made you forget a lot of things. She made you forget that you used to be a member of the Rebellion and all the princesses were your friends. You used to fight me and everyone else here. You don't want to hurt Bow, Adora. He's your friend." Adora's face was blank.

Two long minutes passed where no one said anything. Entrapta, who was still hiding behind her machine, poked her head out and began whispering excitedly into her recorder. Ignoring her, Adora finally spoke. She looked at Catra, her heart clearly broken:

"You…you lied to me…" Catra started to tear up. Overwhelmed by emotion, Adora turned back to Bow and yelled angrily:

"You said I was She-Ra! Who is She-Ra? Tell me now!"

***

Bow was panicking. Catra's explanation of what had happened to his friend was so incredible it made sense. He knew he could not tell Adora about the awesome power she wielded as a princess – not when she was in this state. The archer slowly shook his head. This angered Adora, who wrapped her hands around his neck, threatening to strangle him. She screamed in Bow's face:

"WHO IS SHE-RA?! ANSWER ME!" Bow closed his eyes, certain he was going to die. His life quickly flashed before his eyes – Glimmer was in most of it. Just then, he heard Entrapta yell:

"Adora! Stop it!" This made the blonde pause and loosen her grip on Bow. Bow opened his eyes to see Adora staring at Entrapta in confusion. The princess had left the safety of her machine, and was now right next to both of them. She was not hovering above them, however. Instead, she stood on the floor, looking up at Adora with pleading eyes.

Adora narrowed her eyes, let go of Bow, and slapped Entrapta across her face, causing her to fall down. She then turned back to Bow and punched him hard in his stomach, literally taking his

breath away for a short period of time. She then turned around and walked menacingly towards Catra.

It was at this point that Bow finally passed out from the stress. The last thing he saw was Entrapta quickly getting her feet, calling his name in concern.

***

When an awkward silence filled the room, Perfuma finally spoke up:

"Okay, guys? I think this has been enough interrogation for one day. Let's just take a pause, maybe do some meditation-" Mermista groaned:

"NO! Listen, I don't care what Scorpia says! Catra's still the one who took my kingdom from me! She's not innocent and she's definitely not on our side! As soon as we go back out there, she's mine!" The water princess stomped off, followed closely by Sea Hawk and a concerned Spinerella. Netossa then addressed the room:

"Okay, maybe Perfuma's right – let's take a breather! Glimmer, do you mind keeping an eye on Scorpia?" Before Glimmer could speak, Perfuma replied:

"I'll do it! I don't mind…she's wrapped in my vines anyway…" Netossa raised an eyebrow before nodding and leaving the Great Hall, followed by Glimmer and Princess Frosta. Queen Angella watched sadly as they left. Swift Wind then trotted up to her, asking:

"Do you think they believed you when you said Adora was always on our side?" Angella shook her head, sighing:

"I wouldn't have believed me. Why should they?" After the queen and alicorn left the room, Perfuma and Scorpia awkwardly sat down at the foot of Frosta's throne. Scorpia broke the silence by saying:

“So…um…are you doing okay?” Perfuma gave Scorpia a sad smile:

“Not really but thank you for asking. How about you?” Scorpia sighed:

“Not great. I mean, I was spying on you guys and I don’t think anyone believed me when I said Catra wasn’t as bad as you thought…” Perfuma smiled comfortingly:

“I believed you! And…I’m sure you’re not that bad either…” Scorpia blushed, looking away from Perfuma in embarrassment:

“Oh, um, thanks!” Perfuma, now starting to blush as well, continued:

“Whatever the truth is, thank you for saving me and my friends! It means a lot…” Scorpia turned back to face Perfuma and gave her the biggest smile she could manage:

“You’re welcome.”

Chapter End Notes

> Well, wasn't that fun? I'm currently debating whether I should go straight into the portal in the next chapter, or whether Lord Adora and the princesses should have a fight...what do you think?
>
> Anyway, it turns out writing a Masters' thesis takes longer than a few weeks so the next update will be sometime next week instead of in the next few days. I hope you don't mind! Thanks again for reading and for all the love you've given this fic! It's greatly appreciated! :))

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

> Hey everyone! Sorry I was a bit late posting this chapter - my Masters is still keeping me busy :) Anyway, I now know what'll happen next in this story, and it starts with our two leading ladies getting their hearts broken even more. I hope you enjoy! ;)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It had been two days since Adora had displaced Hordak as Lord of the Horde. As was expected, there had been some opposition. While Adora was arguably the most obvious candidate to take over, Grizzlor, in particular had made his feelings pretty clear by threatening to withdraw his troops and march on the Fright Zone. Adora had seemingly settled this by sending Lonnie to Brightmoon to calm him down.

Lonnie had now become Adora’s second-in-command, assisting the blonde with every decision she made. Lonnie had been the one who had thrown Catra in a cell after the feline had been thoroughly beaten up by Adora. She had been the one to help Adora interrogate Entrapta about the machine she was building - finding out about Horde Prime and the need to get a message to him.

While not interested in Horde Prime, Adora was strangely fascinated with the idea of communicating with the universe outside of Etheria, and had ordered Entrapta to continue her work.

Bow had been in the medical bay ever since he had passed out in Hordak’s sanctum. The stress of everything that had happened to him had raised his blood pressure to dangerously high levels, not to mention he had suffered a major panic attack when he first woke up. If it had not been for Kyle’s quick response, Bow might

have actually had a heart attack. The short blonde guard, while not trusting Bow after what he had done to him, had appreciated the fact that the archer had cared enough to try and get him out of the Fright Zone.

Adora had also reached out the princesses, announcing that she was now in charge and there would be no surrender this time. The defeated party would be executed, as justice demanded. She also warned them that, as soon as her forces were properly reinforced in Brightmoon, the Horde would march on the Kingdom of Snows – effectively declaring war on Princess Frosta. No one had answered her call, but Adora was confident they would receive the message.

As the new leader of the Horde sat on her throne, reviewing the battle plans for the attack on Frosta's castle, Lonnie entered and announced that Entrapta had reached a dead end with her work. Apparently the princess needed a power source: a First Ones' artifact.

Adora raised her eyebrow. While she had successfully established herself as the new leader of the Horde, there was one matter she had still not resolved: She-Ra.

Bow had not been well enough to interrogate and neither Catra nor Hordak had told her anything. Adora had wondered about asking Shadow Weaver but, given everything Catra *had* told her, she figured that would be a bad idea. The only person who had offered her any explanation was Entrapta, who had said she was an ancient princess who carried a portable runestone in her sword; a sword which was First Ones' tech. Apparently, She-Ra was Adora and Adora was her.

This had thoroughly confused the blonde and she had dismissed it as yet more indecipherable gibberish coming out of the princess' mouth. That being said, Adora had not worked very hard to investigate it further – deciding she had more important matters to attend to. Now was her chance.

"Fine, let's go see Entrapta. Lead the way, Force Captain."

***

Catra had barely moved in the two days since she had been locked up. She was chained to the wall and her hands had finally gone numb from the cuffs several hours ago - but she did not care. Her memory played what Adora had done to her on repeat – the angry screams, the pain of being repeatedly hit with the stun baton, the agony of having her left ear sliced with its laser…

After Adora had finally learned the extent of Catra's betrayal, it was like every ounce of her previous self completely disappeared. The blonde had lost control and had seriously injured Catra with the brutality of her attack. If Lonnie had not returned as quickly as she did, distracting Adora from her assault, the feline would have definitely passed out from the pain alone. Now she lay on her side facing the wall, having already cried every tear she had but wanting to cry more. Not because she hated Adora but because she hated herself.

As far as Catra was concerned, she deserved this. She had always deserved this. And the fact that Adora had taken her anger out on her (instead of her idiotic archer friend) was a small victory. The feline had no idea what had happened to him since then. For all she knew, Adora had killed both him and Entrapta, along with every other member of the Princess Alliance. All of her efforts had been for nothing – the girl she loved was completely gone and, if she ever did come back, she would never forgive herself, yet alone Catra.

Just as the feline began to whimper once more, her cell door opened. Catra turned over, glancing sorrowfully at the newcomer. She expected to see some unidentified guard carrying food. Instead, she saw Adora. The blonde was now wearing a tailored version of Hordak's outfit, with a cape and dark eye liner. Catra would have laughed in her face had she not been so scared.

Adora walked up to her, knelt down and cupped the feline's chin in her hands:

"Wow, you look pathetic." Catra reverted to who she was when Shadow Weaver would insult and demean her – an angry kitten who would put on a brave face while doing everything she could not to throw up. Annoyed at Catra's silence, Adora pushed her roughly against the wall before standing back up, looking down at her menacingly.

"You'll no doubt be pleased to know that your rebel allies are still alive – for the moment. Entrapta has informed me that a certain item is required to finish the job Hordak started – an item that *you* may know the location of." Catra gulped. Adora bent down and spoke in an almost silky voice:

"She-Ra's sword, Catra. Where is it?" Catra went white. She was not actually sure where it was. The feline knew Scorpia had hidden it in her room, but it was also possible the former Force Captain had put it somewhere else entirely. After all, Scorpia's room had been cleared out a few days ago and no one had found anything…

"Catra?!" The feline's eyes went wide as Adora picked her up by her uniform, holding her up against the wall. The blonde growled:

"I'm losing patience! Tell me where the sword is or I'll not be responsible for my actions!" Catra whimpered in pain. Her head was hurting from being whacked against the wall, which was reminding her of her scarred and largely untreated ear. The scar running down Adora's face was hauntingly reflected by the dim light of the cell and it was all Catra could do to mutter:

"S-Shadow Weaver…she was the last one who had your sword…" With that, Adora dropped Catra on the floor, causing the feline to wince in pain. Catra had not been eating and was very weak. The blonde then turned and marched back towards the door, pausing on her way out.

"Didn't you say Shadow Weaver was the one to make me forget everything?" Catra nodded. Adora looked down at the floor, deep in thought.

"I don't want to talk to her, but I will if I have to. Are you *sure* there's nothing more you can tell me?" Catra was about to turn back to the wall as a feeble demonstration of her disgust, but something stopped her from doing so. Adora had said everyone was still alive. The second she talked to Shadow Weaver that would no longer be the case. And who knew whether or not Adora using her sword again would have disastrous consequences? Maybe it would not work for her anymore, or it might even heal her!

Catra knew she was grasping at straws but the idea of Adora interacting with Shadow Weaver seemed far worse than anything else she could have possibly imagined in that moment. The feline sighed and said:

"I might know something…but you need to unchain me!"

***

Catra had not expected Adora to actually unchain her and take her with her to Scorpia's old room. It turned out that the former Force Captain had not hidden the sword that well at all: it was in the vent.

When Adora picked up the sword, she collapsed almost immediately. Catra had immediately knelt down and held up her former best friend, unsure of how or even if she could help. After a minute or so, Adora woke up again, declaring they had to go to the Whispering Woods immediately. She had seen something and had to go and investigate. Catra had said nothing when Adora suddenly grabbed her hand and dragged her to the nearest skiff hangar bay.

No one stopped Adora as she climbed into a skiff and pulled Catra in it with her. No one said anything as the two of them left the

Fright Zone and headed deep into the forest. The feline guessed Adora had had another of those weird visions she had had when she first touched the sword; and she had no idea whether or not that was a good thing.

After what felt like hours (but was only a matter of minutes), a giant burst of blue light shone through the forest, partially blinding both of the women. Adora remained unfazed and continued to head straight for it. Catra was getting increasingly worried, however.

The former Force Commander did not remember Adora being so confident and/ or in tune with She-Ra part of her. Something had changed. Maybe Shadow Weaver's messing with her mind had enabled her to think more clearly?

After a few more minutes in the air, Adora landed the skiff in a clearing. The light dimmed to reveal an ancient ruin that looked mostly intact. It was giant and was shooting its light straight up into the sky.

Catra gulped as Adora leapt off the skiff and walked towards it. Uncertain of what to do, the feline decided to follow the blonde as she effortlessly opened an entrance into the structure.

Catra knew she would regret this later – she just knew it.

***

Catra was regretting a lot as she ran after Adora down countless corridors while being chased by giant robot spiders. She was regretting not staying in the skiff. She regretted not eating anything in the last two days. She regretted touching the crystal while Adora was conversing with the hologram…and that was only the superficial stuff. She also regretted effectively betraying Adora and breaking their promise over and over… she regretted leaving Adora in a room alone with Shadow Weaver while knowing exactly what the witch was capable of…

Adora suddenly stopped running and Catra's feet automatically sped to a halt behind her. Despite everything that had just happened, Adora had still said nothing to Catra since telling her they were going to the Whispering Woods. She still said nothing as she suddenly raised her arm cannon and fired at the ceiling behind them, causing it to cave in.

Catra breathed a sigh of relief upon realizing that the building's crazy security system was now prevented from reaching them. Adora then scowled:

"You're not supposed to be in here, Catra. Those things see you as an invader and, as long as I'm protecting you, they'll see me as a threat too." Catra gasped in anger:

"What? You're protecting me now?! Look at my ear, Adora! You did that!" Adora narrowed her eyes:

"Oh yeah? Well, look at my face! I got this scar protecting you – not that you deserve it!" Catra hissed at Adora, who then began to wave her sword threateningly at the feline. This made Catra stop and simply look away in contempt. Adora pinched her nose and put away her sword, muttering:

"Look, it doesn't matter. We're here now and I need to find Light Hope. I saw this place in my vision and she was the one telling me to come here." Catra smirked:

"So why didn't you come alone? Why didn't you send me back to my cell, *Lord* Adora? Why am I here?!" Adora went red, but Catra realized it was not from anger; it was from embarrassment. The blonde looked away and mumbled:

"I…I wanted to give you the chance to escape. You co-operated, you got me my sword…I didn't want to send you back to your cell. You know what'll happen to you if you stay there. You'll be sent to Beast Island or worse!" Catra's eyes went wide. Adora continued:

"I thought…I thought you could go and find your rebel friends. Or, even better, you could forget about them and go and make a life

for yourself somewhere in the forest. I promise you that, if I ever found you, I wouldn't have arrested you. You'd be free. By taking you with me and leaving you out there, I was freeing you. But you came after me instead! Why?" Adora had now turned back around and was looking at Catra with tear-stained cheeks. Catra was in awe. Her former best friend still cared about her, and she was getting emotional thinking about what would happen to her…

Unable to process Adora's words, Catra briefly reverted back to her former self and wrapped her tail around the blonde's hand:

"Don't worry, it's not because I like you."

***

Catra groaned in pain as she was once again pushed against the wall by Adora. The pair of them had wandered into a dark room, only to have a weird light temporarily blind them and seemingly send them back to the Fright Zone. This had angered Adora and she had taken her frustration out on Catra. After immobilizing the feline, the blonde had yelled:

"What's going on? What did you do?!" Catra forced herself to speak against the arm pressed to her neck:

"I don't know! Adora, there's no way we can be in the Fright Zone!" This just made the blonde angrier. Adora leaned in closer and screamed:

"What about Shadow Weaver?! Is this another of her sick mind games?!" Realizing that Adora was about to suffer another panic attack, Catra forced her hands onto the blonde's shoulders, saying:

"No, Adora! She's locked up, remember? Her connection to the Black Garnet has been severed - I severed it! You know this, you were there!" Adora, who had started to hyperventilate, now regained control of her breathing. After another moment of trying to catch her breath, the blonde let go of the feline, turning to lean on a pipe. Adora then murmured:

"Sorry…you're right…I do remember that…" Catra's attention was drawn by a guard walking over. Without hesitation, she called out to him. Adora needed help and the feline was not sure she was the best person to give it. The guard ignored her, however, and proceeded to walk right through her. Adora, who had had her head in her hands, turned to look when Catra squealed:

"Adora, it's not real! We're not really in the Fright Zone – it's an illusion!" As soon as the feline finished talking, a younger version of her ran through the blonde, yelling:

"Adora! ADORA!" Both women watched their shared memory play out with the same incredulous expressions. Adora because she had no recollection of ever calling Force Captain Octavia a "dumb-face", and Catra because she could see for herself the literal second she fell in love with Adora.

When the memory ended, Catra and Adora found themselves in a different corridor. Catra leaned against the wall, trying and failing to process what happened. Adora, who looked thoroughly shaken by the whole thing, suddenly asked:

"Was…that…us?" Catra nodded. Adora scratched her head:

"I…I don't remember that…we were so happy…you were my friend…" Unable to listen to anymore of Adora's revelations, Catra pushed herself off the wall and rushed down the corridor. She came across a giant room with a collapsed floor. Catra quickly climbing onto the fallen stone beam which provided passage to the other side of the chamber, while doing her best to ignore the hurried footsteps behind her.

No one spoke as both Catra and Adora successfully crossed the room and made it to the other side. Then, as Adora jumped off the beam, she slipped and started falling through the giant hole in the floor. The blonde desperately screamed:

"Catra!" Without thinking, the feline whipped around and ran to save her falling friend. It was all she could do to grab onto her

arm and pull her back up. The added weight of her sword and armour, along with Catra's lack of nourishment, made the whole exercise almost impossible. Thankfully, Adora was able to take advantage of Catra's assistance to pull herself back up relatively quickly.

"Thank you" Adora muttered. Catra gave an uncertain nod before continuing to head out of the room. She did not look where she was going, however, and found herself falling headfirst into another memory.

***

Adora was not sure of anything anymore. A lot had happened since she had picked up She-Ra's sword, not least the revelation that her relationship with Catra went much deeper than that of two soldiers assigned to work together. They had been friends… close friends… Catra cared about her enough to follow her into untold danger in spite of everything Adora had done to her, not to mention turning down the option to escape and accepting a fate worse than death… And now Catra had saved her life.

Adora watched in awe as the feline walked away, only to watch her walk straight into a pillar, causing the whole room to change again.

Adora raised her eyebrow as she saw her younger self fight Catra in the training room, being evaluated by a blue hybrid who she recognized as Sergeant Cobalt. She watched as a younger version of Lonnie came to her rescue, causing her to smirk as Catra was summarily defeated.

Once the fight ended, and Catra walked away, Adora stayed to watch her younger self conversing with Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle. Lonnie laughed at her, saying that her crush on Catra could prevent her from passing her final evaluation. Younger Adora pushed Lonnie playfully, telling her to mind her own business. The room was then filled with Catra's screams and the memory paused.

Without thinking, Adora ran towards the noise, finding Catra about to be dragged away by a giant robot spider. The blonde cried out as she ran to help the feline:

"Catra! CATRA!" Catra, who had her mouth gagged with the robot's artificial webbing, cried out in response, but was dragged away before Adora could figure out what she was saying.

As the door locked behind ahead of her, the blonde began to panic. The way to her friend may be blocked, but she was not going to let that stop her. Adora raised her sword and cut through the thin sheet of metal, jumping through the hole and dealing the death blow to the robot that Catra had already disarmed.

The feline glared at her in the same way she had in the training room. Adora figured it as competitiveness, remarking:

"Oh, don't worry! I'm sure you had it covered!" Catra muttered:

"I did." As the feline stalked off once more, Adora, realizing she may have misread Catra, ran after her and grabbed her hand:

"Wait, Catra, I'm sorry…" Catra scoffed:

"For what? Your list of offences is getting pretty high, Adora." Pulling her hand away, Catra started climbing some boulders to the next floor. Adora sighed in frustration. As far as she was concerned, she had done nothing wrong. Not only that, but she was thoroughly confused: Adora did not have a crush on the feline and yet Lonnie seemed to think she did… was that why she cared so much about Catra? A crush?

The room suddenly changed again, showing the halls of the Fright Zone once more. Another memory was starting. Catra crossed her arms and sighed:

"Let's just get this over with."

***

Catra screwed her eyes shut as she heard one of her worst memories playing before her eyes – the very first time Shadow Weaver had ever electrocuted her. She could not bring herself to look, not even at Adora, who was almost certainly becoming more traumatized with every second.

When Catra left the room, Adora followed her. The blonde's demeanour had changed since the beginning of this expedition. She was like she was all those days ago, when her mind had just been wiped and she was depending on Catra to help her.

Finally, unable to take anymore, Catra stopped walking and spun around to face Adora. The leader of the Horde almost tripped on her cape as she forced herself to abruptly stop as well. The feline hissed:

"Well? Say something! I know you want to!" Adora looked down and hugged herself the way Catra often did. Her scar no longer made her look menacing – it made her look pathetic.

"I…I'm sorry, Catra…" Before Adora could finish, the light of the room started to dim and several large robot spiders appeared. Adora spun around and began blasting them with her arm cannon. Catra, on the other hand, was too emotionally overwhelmed to respond - so she ran.

The feline ran for what felt like days, but was only really a few minutes. Different memories materialized and disappeared as she ran through them. Eventually, Catra ran out of breath and collapsed on the floor. That was when a memory she had not seen yet caught her attention – a memory that meant a lot to her:

"Catra, it's okay. It's just me."

***

Without Catra's help, Adora had been overpowered by the robot spiders and was now dangling from a ledge; her sword still on the edge of the concrete cliff. As the spiders moved to finish her off,

Adora was relieved to hear the sound of Catra diverting their attention and single-handedly taking them down.

When the noises stopped, Adora called out:

“Catra?” The feline then emerged with She-Ra’s sword:

“Hey Adora.” After a moment of awkward silence, the blonde asked:

“Could you help me? Please?” Catra narrowed her eyes:

“You know, I would normally say yes… but this is not normal.” With that, the feline threw She-Ra’s sword down the cavern, leaned down and unsheathed her claws. Adora gasped:

“Catra, what are you doing?!” Catra growled:

“Don’t think this is easy for me! Trust me, Adora, I don’t want to do this but you leave me no choice! Yes, I betrayed you, but you betrayed me first! And you’ll keep hurting me and the rest of Etheria unless I stop you right now!” Catra began to choke up when she said the last bit. Adora began to hyperventilate:

“Catra, what are you doing?! STOP!” Using her claws, Catra cut through the webbing holding Adora’s right arm up, causing it to fall by her side. The feline sniffled as she said:

“I’m so sorry, Adora. I really am going to miss you…but you’re too far gone for me to save… for anyone to save…”

“CATRA!” With that, Catra cut the remaining webs, causing Adora to fall and desperately grab onto a rock on the way to her supposedly guaranteed demise. As Catra walked away, the blonde screamed:

“YOU’LL PAY FOR THIS, CATRA! YOU HEAR ME?! YOU’LL PAY FOR THIS!”

***

As the moon lit up the forest once more, and the shining beam of blue light no longer lit up the sky, the Whispering Woods became eerily silent as nature itself became aware of a noise which was foreign to its environment. That noise was a magicat crying her heart out in a skiff parked in a clearing in front of an old ruin. A magicat who had just lost everything – and was about to lose even more…

Chapter End Notes

> Well, wasn't that fun? The next update will hopefully be some time next week. Thank you guys for your continued support - your comments and kudos mean the world to me! Until next time! :))

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

> Hey everyone! I'm sorry this has taken me so long to update - I was finishing my Masters! And, great news, I finished it! So you can look forward to this fic getting finished pretty soon! I hope you enjoy the next instalment - things are really escalating now! :))

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Lonnie sighed in exasperation while both Kyle and Rogelio looked on in concern. She had just hung up on Grizzlor, unable to take any more of him yelling at her to give him authorization to attack Frosta's castle.

It turned out that the Horde's forces had made excellent progress since leaving Brightmoon. Not only had they crossed into the Kingdom of Snows but they had also surrounded Frosta's castle in the two days that Adora had been in charge. And now Adora was gone. She and Catra had left for an undisclosed location for an undetermined amount of time - and Lonnie was picking up the slack.

She had told Grizzlor all she could: "Adora's gone out. I'll get her to call you when she comes back." But had that been enough for the Force Captain? No! The follow-up questions had been relentless:

"When will she come back?"

"Will she come back? I knew we couldn't trust Adora!"

"How could you let her leave?"

"Why didn't you stand up to her? A real officer would –" That was when Lonnie had hung up, and when her friends had walked in.

The new second-in-command had summoned them because there was no one else she trusted to help her right now.

"I think something's wrong. Adora left the Fright Zone hours ago. She didn't say where she was going nor how long she'd be out. She left no orders and we *need* orders. And until she comes back, I'm in charge. What should I do?" Rogelio tentatively walked over to Lonnie and wrapped her in a hug.

They were currently standing in the empty throne room and the noise of Rogelio's movement echoed comfortingly. Kyle then broke the silence:

"Well… um… what do *you* wanna do?" Lonnie looked over at him in total surprise:

"M-Me?! What do *I* want to do? That doesn't matter!" Rogelio then growled in a language only Lonnie could understand:

"Yes it does, Lonnie. We love you and we're proud of you for getting this far! You deserve to call the shots - and we'll stand with you no matter what!" Lonnie sniffled a little and hugged Rogelio tighter. Kyle smiled awkwardly:

"Yeah… what he said!" After a minute of silence, Lonnie wiped her eyes, let go of Rogelio, and clenched her fists purposefully:

"Alright – let's do this!"

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Catra could not stop crying. It amazed her that she even had this much liquid in her body. She was even more amazed that she was still conscious which, considering her lack of sleep and nourishment, seemed next to impossible. Then again, she had been put through worse by Shadow Weaver.

The magicat desperately wiped away her tears, determined not to crash the skiff as it sped back through the Whispering Woods.

Catra had spent some time figuring out what to do next, processing the fact that Adora was dead and all Adora's friends, old and new, were about to suffer in a battle of her own making. In the end, Catra had decided to do the right thing; she was heading back to the Fright Zone to stop the war. It was what Adora, the *real* Adora, would have wanted - and Catra refused to let her sacrifice be in vain.

As the skiff finally left the woods, and the Fright Zone came into view, Catra accelerated as fast as she could.

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When the recorded transmission ended, all of the princesses went white; some with fear, some with fury and others with total despair. Adora was now in charge of the Horde and she was coming to kill them.

She had sent her message to Brightmoon, meaning that it had taken a while for it to relay automatically to Frosta's castle. Now that it was here, however, it was too late for the princesses to even consider a response.

The Horde had closed in yesterday with the castle now completely surrounded by the full might of its army. There were simply too many soldiers for the princesses to even hope to fight, yet alone defeat. Only She-Ra could save them now - and she was not coming. The best they could look forward to was a good battle and most of the princesses were up for it. Most of them. Perfuma whispered:

"She didn't mean that… right?" Mermista groaned:

"Yes she did! She meant every word of that and we need to take her seriously!" Frosta moaned:

"We *are*! But Adora's *She-Ra*! Any victory we win will be for nothing unless we take her down! And… I don't know how to do that. Anyone know how to do that?" Angella began to shake:

“Are we sure she won’t negotiate? I mean, I know she said she wouldn’t but… it’s…”

“It’s not Adora, mom. Not anymore. We have no choice but to fight. We might not win… but we’ll definitely make them hurt!” Glimmer hit the table as she said the last bit. Immediately, there was an uproar of voices. Only Netossa succeeded in silencing them:

“ENOUGH! We’re missing the obvious solution here! We have Swift Wind – he can just fly us out of here!” Spinerella nodded, adding:

“OR Glimmer could teleport us out of here! See? We’ve not lost yet! We can still survive this!” It was at this point that Sea Hawk finally spoke:

“Forgive me, ladies, but… where would we go? The Horde kind of… controls… everything…” There was an awkward silence before Scorpia finally spoke:

“The Fright Zone. We need to stop Adora and there is only one person who can do that: Catra. We need Catra.”

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“Catra?! What the hell are you doing?”

“Surrendering myself – what does it look like? Also, can I please have some water?” Lonnie was too stunned to refuse. As Kyle ran off to get some water, Rogelio uncuffed Catra and dismissed the guards who had arrested her at the entrance of the Fright Zone.

After a minute of awkward silence, Kyle returned and gave Catra a water bottle, standing next to her as she drank it. The feline finished drinking and almost threw the empty container at Kyle’s head out of habit - but decided against it. After all, she had really appreciated the water. Lonnie noticed this as well and could not believe it. What had happened out there?

“Catra! Time to talk! Why are you back here? Where’s Adora? Explain yourself!” Catra would have laughed at Lonnie acting like she was now the boss but, given that Adora was gone, she technically was. Too tired to argue about it, Catra spluttered:

“Adora’s dead. I killed her. And I know she was about to have all her former friends killed… If that happens, the Horde will win and all of Etheria will suffer! It has to stop, Lonnie! That’s why I came back - this all has to stop!”

***

Catra could feel the tears pouring down her cheeks as she admitted what she had done. She could hear the suddenly elevated heartrates of her former teammates and listened to Rogelio’s angry growls, Kyle’s pleading cries, and Lonnie’s disbelieving gasps. But, after a few minutes of silence from Catra, everyone knew she was telling the truth. When the feline finally spoke again, she sighed:

“Lonnie, I know you’re in charge now. That’s fine – you can have the job! I don’t want it! But we need to stop this! Send the princesses a message – say we’re willing to negotiate so no one dies! They’ll accept our terms, I know they will!” Lonnie, who was still too stunned to speak, shook her head and mouthed:

“No, Catra. Adora told Grizzlor he could kill the princesses and neither you nor I can stop him.” Catra frowned in annoyance:

“Grizzlor? *Grizzlor*?! We can take that guy! Heck, the princesses could take him! He’s not who I’m worried about – tell the other Force Captains to stand down!” Lonnie, who was now pinching her nose in exasperation, finally yelled:

“Okay, what is wrong with you?! This is the Horde’s whole mission! The princesses are evil and you took over two thirds of Etheria – not me! Why the sudden change of heart? Don’t tell me Adora got to you in the end?” Catra shook her head, involuntarily tearing up at hearing Adora’s name:

"No! She didn't get to me – that's the point! Shadow Weaver turned her into what the Horde always wanted her to be: a monster! So much so that I had to kill her! I left the love of my life dead at the bottom of a cliff in an ancient ruin in the Whispering Woods! And now the events that she set in motion are about to happen and only you can stop it!" Lonnie, too shocked by Catra's further confession to respond, simply gasped. Catra, equally shocked by her confession, covered her mouth and sunk to the floor in tears.

After what felt like a lifetime, Kyle suddenly stepped forward:

"Lonnie… it's what Adora would want…" Rogelio nodded in support of his boyfriend. Lonnie quickly wiped away her own tears, which had formed at the mental image of Adora's dead body:

"Fine – FINE! I'll call off the attack! But don't think you're getting away with this, Catra! You'll be in a cell for a long, long time!"

***

After a brief discussion, the princesses had decided to split up. Frosta, Mermista, Glimmer and Sea Hawk were going to stay and fight. Frosta because she felt obligated to defend her kingdom. Mermista because she refused to run anymore and Sea Hawk because he would never abandon Mermista. And Glimmer so she could get them all out if necessary.

The others (Angella, Netossa, Spinerella, Swift Wind, Perfuma and Scorpia) were going to make their way to the Fright Zone as fast as they could. Using Scorpia's insider knowledge, they would break into the prison and free Catra. Then, once they had her on their side (Scorpia had said her help was not guaranteed and they would probably have to beg), they would go to the throne room to face Adora.

As the team heading to the Fright Zone organized themselves (Angella would have to carry Perfuma – something Scorpia was very jealous about), Angella pulled her daughter over for a talk.

She knew she was putting a lot on Glimmer's shoulders and she was even more aware of just how heartbroken her daughter was from losing both Bow and Adora in such terrible ways.

Once they were far enough from everyone, standing on a balcony overlooking the huge Horde army, Angella turned to face her daughter, blocking their view of the enemy with her wings. Glimmer gave a hesitant smile. She knew what her mother was trying to do. Angella reached her hands up and gently cupped Glimmer's cheeks, smiling:

"I'm so proud of you, Glimmer. You're father would've been proud of you too." Glimmer began to tear up. She always got like that when Micah was mentioned. Angella then produced a staff from thin air, handing it to Glimmer:

"Speaking of your father, he would want you to have this. It was his… and now it's yours." Glimmer gasped and took the staff, holding it close. Angella then put her hands down to her daughter's shoulders, gripping them tightly:

"Your survival is paramount. You must get everyone out the *second* things get out of hand – do you understand?" Glimmer nodded aggressively, embarrassed that she was getting so emotional over a stick. Angella continued in as soothing a voice as she could manage:

"I don't know what's going to happen to us in the Fright Zone but, if anything happens to me-"

"Nothing will happen to you! Nothing *can* happen to you – you're immortal!" Angella gave a sad smile, unable to look at her daughter for a second:

"Yes, you're right. I can't die… you've got nothing to worry about." With that, the queen slowly leaned forward and kissed Glimmer on the forehead. The sparkly princess uncharacteristically reached up and wrapped her mother in as big a hug as she could.

The other princesses were ready to go but no one dared disturb the two of them. After all, mother-daughter hugs were rare and deserved to be cherished - especially when the mother was Angella and the daughter was Glimmer.

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"You want me to *WHAT*?!" Lonnie bit her lip nervously. She knew Grizzlor would never agree to this:

"I said that you have new orders: cease and desist! Adora has changed her mind and is now negotiating with the princesses." Grizzlor went from dumbfounded silence to a furious roar:

"WHAT?! How dare she? She's such a hypocrite! Put her on right now!" Lonnie began sweating. Adora was not there and she had never given those orders. But saying this was all Adora's idea was easier than admitting that Adora was dead and now Lonnie was in charge and had already been emotionally blackmailed into doing the impossible.

As Lonnie remained silent in response to Grizzlor's angry cries, Catra sat on the steps leading up to the throne, eating a grey ration bar. Kyle sat next to her, holding a tray full of them. Rogelio had gone to get some and the two of them had forced Catra to have three. Now they were both sitting on either side of her, munching away at them. And Lonnie was standing at the bottom of the steps, looking like she was about to blow a fuse. Grizzlor was still yelling:

"This is a joke, you hear? A joke! You're all so weak! Hordak was the only one who ever had any guts! I refuse to go along with this farce – I'm ordering an attack immediately!" Lonnie went white and shouted:

"No! Don't do that! Don't-" It was no use. Grizzlor hung up. Lonnie groaned in frustration, covering her face in her hands. Catra finished her mouthful:

“Lonnie… what about the other Force Captains?” Lonnie removed her hands and turned to look at her friends sadly:

“They all said they would follow my orders – but Grizzlor is fearsome on the ground! He’ll make them follow him! I told you we should have been more worried about him!” Catra swallowed and sighed:

“Yeah… you’re right…” Just then, an alarm went off. There had been a breach. Without a moment’s delay, Lonnie ran up the stairs to the throne, sitting in it and activating the computer screens. Within seconds, images of death and destruction littered the security camera footage in front of her.

Catra grimaced. The violence of what she was seeing was too extreme for the princesses, or so she had thought. Honestly, she would not have blamed the sparkly princess if she had finally lost it. Rogelio then roared:

“Quickly! We have to barricade the door! Whatever’s causing this is heading this way!” Kyle stood up, screaming:

“What he said! WHAT HE SAID!” Lonnie then screamed in terror. Catra, who had been momentarily distracted by Rogelio and Kyle trying to block the door with Hordak’s old desk, looked back up and gasped.

It was not the princesses. It was a single princess: an eight-foot tall woman with long blonde hair and a glowing yellow sword now covered in red. And she was standing right outside the door.

***

When Adora had finally lost her grip on the cliff-face, she had accepted her fate. While her taunting of Catra may have seemed like a refusal to give up, the reality was that the feline had won. Adora had let her guard down and paid the price for it.

As Adora had fallen, flashes of a life she could not remember played before her eyes. Catra and Shadow Weaver were the main

characters. Adora had frowned angrily and closed her eyes, only to find herself already lying on the ground. She was alright – and she was not alone.

Adora had turned to see the individual she now recognized as Light Hope, who then explained what was happening. Adora was She-Ra and she needed to balance the planet. Adora, who had been sceptical since the first time she remembered hearing her alter ego's name, had asked for more information. Surprisingly, Light Hope had obliged, explaining more than just the nature of the princesses and their runestones.

As Light Hope described the Heart of Etheria, Adora's mind wandered: maybe Shadow Weaver's mind control had altered her mind for the better… after all, it was clear that she had struggled a lot more with She-Ra beforehand…

When Light Hope had finished explaining the need to connect Scorpia with the Black Garnet, the hologram had told Adora about the need to open a portal. The blonde had nodded, saying that Entrapta was working on it. Light Hope had made no comment, simply saying that the opening of the portal and Scorpia forging a connection with her runestone were two parts of the same event, the balancing of the planet, and both needed to happen as soon as possible.

Supposedly believing Adora to be ready to go about her mission without any training, Light Hope had woken her up, causing the blonde to almost hurt herself falling off the stone slab she was inexplicably sleeping on.

Adora had transformed into She-Ra and fought her way out of the ruin and, without a moment's hesitation, proceeded to run straight for the Fright Zone.

Adora now had new objectives. She could see now that the Horde itself was a dysfunctional organization which was far from perfect – both it and the princesses needed to be eradicated. She needed to capture Scorpia, open Entrapta's portal, and find and kill Catra.

Now, Adora stood outside her throne room and, as she had suspected, Lonnie had taken her place after her only being gone for a few hours. No matter. She would make Lonnie pay too.

Adora sliced through the metal doors like tissue paper, only to find the room completely deserted. The blonde frowned and looked up at the screens which were still playing before an empty throne. She could clearly see the squad sneaking through the secret passage to Hordak's sanctum with… *Catra*?!

Adora gasped and any rational thought left in her mind abruptly ran away. She no longer cared about her mission. She had long since stopped caring about the Horde's mission. Right now, she was going to find Catra and tear her apart.

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The princesses desperately searched the cells, not finding anything but dead Horde soldiers. Perfuma began to hyperventilate:

"Um… guys? Maybe we shouldn't be here? There's… there's something evil here…" Angella nodded:

"That there is." The queen used her wings to point in the direction of two large cells at the centre of the prison; one held Hordak while the other held Shadow Weaver. Scorpia grimaced:

"Yeah… I'd leave them there if I were you…" Perfuma nodded aggressively:

"Yes! And let's leave!"

"No!" cried Netossa, who had found a cell with claw marks in it. She continued:

"Catra was here – she's gone. Do you think she's somewhere else in the Fright Zone?" Scorpia went white and everyone turned to look at her. After a moment of stony silence, where the only

sound was the blaring alarm, Scorpia clasped her pincers together and said:

"If Catra's not here, then… she's not anywhere. She's been sent to Beast Island or worse." Spinerella gasped and Swift Wind whinnied:

"Um, guys? I'm detecting Adora close by! The connection is pretty messed up though, like something's blocking me!" Angella nodded:

"Yes, magic. It has to be. This is all that witch's fault." Angella had pointed to Shadow Weaver when she had said that. Netossa raised her fists angrily:

"Then let's make her pay!" Spinerella stopped her wife:

"No! No, we cannot waste time on her. Something is happening here, something bad, and Bow and Entrapta are in the middle of it. If we can't stop Adora, the least we can do is save them." Angella nodded:

"Agreed. Scorpia, where were they being held?" The former Force Captain sighed and pointed upwards:

"They were in Hordak's sanctum."

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Entrapta was getting impatient. She had sent Adora out to bring her First One's tech to activate her portal machine literal hours ago. And then the guard who had been keeping her company, the lizard guy, had gone and left her all alone.

She had debated using the opportunity to escape through the pipes but had decided against it. She was too curious – she wanted to see what the portal machine would do! She wanted to gather and examine the data! She wanted to see what else she could do with this technology – the possibilities were endless! Then, all of a sudden, a hidden door in the wall opened and two

guards, a Force Captain and Catra ran into the room. Entrapta chirped:

"Hey guys! Where did you come from?" Catra immediately turned to face the princess before abruptly turning again and addressing Lonnie:

"What's she still doing here?" Before Lonnie could catch her breath and explain that she had completely forgotten about Entrapta, the hidden door was blasted from its hinges by a blinding light, and everyone turned to watch in horror as She-Ra entered the room.

The eight-foot tall warrior princess did not wait long to move, immediately charging at Catra. The feline leapt out of the way, narrowly avoiding the giant sword. Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle did as they had been trained. They grabbed Entrapta and moved to a safer position behind the portal machine, waiting for a chance to take down the victor of the fight.

Just as Catra narrowly avoided another swing from She-Ra's sword, the door of Hordak's sanctum opened and several princesses, including Scorpia, walked in. Catra, distracted by their entrance, was caught off-guard by Adora, who cut her ear once more, re-opening the wound she had caused only a few days before. Catra howled and rolled towards the princesses.

She knew She-Ra would try to kill them and that they used to be her friends, but it seemed obvious that Adora was never going to recover from what Shadow Weaver had done to her – plus it was high-time one of them helped Catra.

As the feline predicted, all the princesses (and flying horse?) charged forward and started using every power at their disposal to disarm She-Ra. As they were doing so, someone helped Catra to sit up against the doorframe, gently stroking her cheek and looking attentively at her ear:

“Are you okay, Catra? Besides the ear?” Catra’s eyes went wide at the queen’s compassion. Her ears then went down as she averted her gaze:

“Yeah… I’m fine.” Angella gave as warm a smile as she could manage and pulled Catra in for a small hug:

“Good. I wanted to thank you for saving my life and keeping Adora under control until we got here.” Catra went red, pushing Angella away and muttering:

“W-What are you doing? Stop it! I’m the enemy!” Angella continued to smile and pointed at Scorpia, who had just successfully pulled She-Ra’s sword from her hand:

“So was she. Scorpia told us all about how you helped her and the other princesses escape.” Catra frowned:

“I was using her to… to spy on you.” Angella gave a forced laugh and winked:

“Of course you were.” With that, the queen stood up and turned to face the fight which was now over. The princesses had She-Ra pinned firmly to the ground, with her sword lying discarded by the portal machine.

As Angella walked over the group, trying her best to communicate with the princesses over Adora’s cries, Entrapta slipped away from the squad who were too distracted to notice, picked the sword off the ground and hooked it up to the portal machine. This turned it on and silenced everyone in the room. Entrapta began to laugh loudly:

“It works! Told ya!” Angella pushed past her friends and reached Entrapta, putting her hand on the scientist’s shoulder:

“Well done, Entrapta. I’m glad you’re okay. Let’s turn this off now, okay?” From her position on the ground, Adora suddenly yelled:

“No, Entrapta! Don’t do it! Pull the lever – *pull the lever*!” Catra, who had now stood back up, stared at the scene before her in utter disbelief. To make matters worse, Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle chose this moment to reveal themselves and wave their stun batons menacingly at the princesses:

“Get out of the Fright Zone! All of you!” This was the distraction She-Ra needed. As the princesses holding her down lightened their grip to fight the squad, the warrior princess pushed them all off her and ran to the lever. When she reached it, Catra screamed:

“NO! ADORA, PLEASE DON’T!” She-Ra looked back at Catra with a look of pure evil that would undoubtedly haunt her for the rest of her life. Then she pulled the lever and everything went white.

Chapter End Notes

> And... it's time for the portal! I have a lot of ideas for the next chapter and can't wait for you guys to read it! As always, your kudos and comments mean the world to me! Thank you for all the love you've already shown this fic - it's been such an encouragement for me! :))

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

> Hey everyone! Welcome to the Portal Part 1! I should warn you that quite a few people "die" by being disintegrated in the portal (like in canon) but I can promise that everyone who disappears in this chapter will reappear safe and sound later on in this fic. I might not be able to say the same in the next chapter... Have fun! :))

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra woke up to a blaring alarm. She was in her bed in her Force Captain quarters and her ear no longer hurt. As the feline sat up, trying to get her bearings, the door opened to reveal Adora. She was dressed in her Horde Lord armour with the same short haircut; looking every bit as terrifying as she had been when she had had first given herself that title. On reflex, Catra got on all fours and unsheathed her claws. Adora simply laughed:

"Oh very funny! We both know you could never take me hand-to-hand!" Catra's eyes widened. Why was Adora laughing? Come to think of it, why was she scared of her? This was Adora! They were friends, Catra was her second-in-command and they ruled Etheria together… right?

Catra relaxed and scratched her head, saying:

"Maybe… but I *am* faster than you." Adora smirked:

"Wanna bet?" Catra gave her signature mischievous grin and leapt off her bed. She landed on Adora, forcing her to ground. The blonde tried and failed to get up due to her heavy armour and impromptu laughing fit:

"Okay, fine! You win!" Catra gave a wry grin:

"Yeah, I do! I already told you this armour's impractical. What was wrong with your previous look?" Catra got off Adora as she spoke and the blonde quickly stood up, brushing herself down:

"It was not worthy of my rank, Catra. You know that." The feline shrugged her shoulders and ran back into her room to get her mask. She had only just realized she was not wearing it and found it odd that Adora had not commented on it. Before she could bring it up, however, Adora suddenly called to her:

"Come on! We have to hurry! The drill starts in 5 minutes and you don't wanna be here when it does!" Catra turned back to face her friend but she was already gone. That was when she became aware once more of the blaring alarm and that she had to get out of the building before the sprinklers activated.

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Once Catra made it to the assembly point (the biggest hangar bay that constituted the main entrance and exit of the Fright Zone), the number of questions she already had tripled.

There were not nearly as many soldiers as she was expecting – barely two battalions. There were no other Force Captains and the alarm seemed to suddenly change from the standard fire drill that had woken her up to a full-on intruder alert.

Searching frantically for Adora, Catra saw her standing on a platform she did not remember ever being there. After sighing in frustration, the feline accepted she had had a bad night and was feeling more out of it than usual. That must be why she was feeling weird and her memories were all messed up.

Catra ran to the front of her troops and fell in line alongside Sergeant Cobalt and another officer she did not recognize. As soon as she was in position, Adora began to speak:

"As you know, one of the princesses escaped from her cell half an hour ago. We've prevented her from leaving our prison but we can assume she has killed all the guards and is currently releasing all

the other prisoners. We must stop this rebellion before it's too late!" Upon hearing the word 'rebellion', Catra's head started to hurt and flashes of images she honestly could not describe filled her mind. The common denominator in all of them seemed to be the colour purple.

"Force Commander Catra!" Catra blinked and saw Adora standing right in front of her. She squealed and jumped, suddenly feeling scared of her friend once more. The blonde simply raised her eyebrow at the feline:

"Catra? Are you alright?" Catra nodded hesitantly. Adora leaned forward and gave a surprisingly soft smile:

"Don't worry, I won't let her hurt you." Catra gave another hesitant nod before asking:

"Okay… um… who are we talking about?" Adora face-palmed herself:

"The sea princess, Catra! I just explained that she escaped!" Catra quickly processed this information:

"Right… right, because we have her and all the other princesses in custody…" Adora suddenly looked concerned and put her hand on Catra's shoulder:

"Catra, are you sure you're okay? Do you… need to sit this one out?" Catra shook her head vehemently. There was nothing more insulting than being asked whether you were ill – Catra was *not* ill!

"Yes! I'm fine, Adora! Just… a bit tired, I guess." The blonde nodded:

"Alright. Just… stay in the back, okay? No need for you to go hand-to-hand with her again." Catra, who was still processing Adora's sudden appearance right in front of her, scratched her head in confusion:

"But… surely I'll have to? We have barely two battalions! That's not nearly enough to take out one, yet alone *all* of the princesses!" Adora's eyes widened and then she burst out laughing:

"What are you talking about? We have eight battalions plus another in reserve. We have more than enough to deal with this!" Catra's face went white. How tired was she to have not seen thousands of her own soldiers saluting her as she walked in…?

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Catra was not really sure what had happened since her talk with Adora in the hangar. The next thing she knew, she had been drowning in a very familiar prison cell, and had passed out when she could not escape. The feline had then woken up to the Horde Lord herself resuscitating her, which had made her jump up in a fit of terror (and mild gay panic).

Adora immediately grabbed Catra's arms and held her down, stopping the feline from scratching her across the face. For a split second, Catra could have sworn she saw a set of scars on Adora's cheek… claw marks…

"Catra! It's okay! It's just me!" The feline took a deep breath and composed herself. When Adora let her go, Catra sat back up. Upon examining her surroundings, the feline realized they were now in the infirmary. Catra stuttered:

"H-How did we get here?" Adora gave a knowing chuckle:

"Short answer? You fought Mermista even after I told you not to. Long answer? You have been acting weird all day and I needed an excuse to get you looked at." Catra put on a grumpy face but she was secretly relieved. The memory loss, random headaches and strange visions were starting to worry her too.

"Wow, *thanks* Adora!" Catra replied sarcastically. Right before she was about to ask what the doctor had said, a happy voice called out from the ward's entrance:

“Hey Catra! Hey Lord Adora! I’m so glad you guys made it – that was a rough fight back there! Did you need me to get something?” Adora looked at the newcomer and raised an eyebrow:

“I’m sorry, who are you?” Catra spun around to see Force Captain Scorpia. Now she knew something was not right; her head ached and her mind showed her flashes of the princess standing in front of them. This person was not a Force Captain:

“What are you doing here?” Both Scorpia and Adora looked at Catra in confusion. When neither of them answered her, the feline began gesturing wildly at the scorpion hybrid:

“She… she’s a princess! She should be with the others!” Catra felt a horrible pang of guilt as she said that. Adora’s eyes widened and she turned to look at Scorpia, asking:

“Force Captain? Is this true?” Scorpia looked terrified as she raised her claws defensively, pleading:

“Well, yes, but I haven’t got any powers! Not cool ones anyway. And Hordak said-”

“Hordak’s no longer in charge! I am! And I’ll not tolerate princesses in my ranks! You shall die where you stand for your treachery!” Catra gasped, her heart feeling inexplicably torn by Adora’s words. The blonde raised an eyebrow at the feline’s change of expression before giving her an evil grin:

“You do it, Catra! You identified her. It’s only fair you should be the one to kill her!” The feline froze:

“Adora… is this really necessary?” The blonde narrowed her eyes and growled:

“I gave you an order, Force Commander! The doctor already said there was nothing wrong you – you have no excuse!” Catra, finally accepting there was a bigger problem here, shook her head bravely:

"No Adora! Look, you know the way I've been acting? It's because there's something going on - something big! I don't know what it is but Scorpia's the key! I know she is! We need her alive!" Adora's eyes widened before her face went red with rage:

"How *dare* you disobey me? I don't tolerate insubordination, Catra! Do as you're told and end this!" The feline, who was now feeling justifiably afraid of the tall blonde woman leaning over her, began to move backwards towards the wall, replying as calmly as she could:

"You're not listening, Adora! Time and space aren't working right! I know it sounds crazy but-"

"Shut up!" Adora lunged at Catra with a stun baton that the feline had not even noticed she was carrying. Catra dodged it and rolled towards the door. Scorpia was still there and she quickly helped Catra to her feet. Just as the feline was standing up, Adora struck again but had her blow blocked by Scorpia. As the two woman pushed against the other, Catra grabbed a glass bottle of sterilizing liquid and leapt over the fight, smashing it over Adora's head. The Horde Lord fell to the ground, knocked out and smelling of alcohol. Scorpia gasped:

"We are *so* fired!"

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Catra and Scorpia ran down the halls of the Fright Zone. As they went, doors, hallways and pipes that the two of them had grown up with inexplicably disappeared before their eyes. Every now and again, the hallway would look like it was being broken apart by some monstrous external force and then everything would revert to normal. Neither of the women could explain it.

When they arrived at the prison complex, Scorpia tried and failed to enter the access code. The Force Captain gasped:

"Oh no! Adora must've woken up – she's deactivated our badges!" Catra simply grunted in response, using her claws to make a hole

in the door. As soon as she did, the guards from inside started firing at them. Without hesitation, Scorpia used her raw strength to tear the door from its hinges and throw it at their attackers. They were all knocked out in one go.

"Wow…" Catra breathed in astonishment. When the scorpion hybrid did not respond, the feline turned to see that her friend was now gone.

"Scorpia?!"

"She's not there, Catra." The feline's hair stood on end as she recognized the voice. Shadow Weaver. Slowly, Catra turned and faced the cell closest to the door, located at the centre of the prison. She snarled:

"Shut up, Shadow Weaver." Then Catra walked into the complex and ran up the ramp to the next level. She was not sure who or what she was looking for and her former mentor knew this. Shadow Weaver called up to Catra:

"I know what's happening, Catra! Let me out of here – I can help!" The feline turned and hissed at Shadow Weaver:

"I said shut up!"

"Catra?" The feline spun around and immediately recognized the sentient hair of Entrapta pressed against her cell door. Catra's headache returned, along with an image of Entrapta next to something extremely bright…

An alarm blared and Catra was pulled from her thoughts. She almost screamed when she saw part of the prison suddenly get engulfed in a terrifying void. Shadow Weaver suddenly screamed:

"Get out! Get out, Catra! Leave the Fright Zone NOW!" Unable to process this sudden show of compassion, Catra growled in frustration and punched the controls of Entrapta's prison cell. This caused the door to malfunction and deactivate with mere seconds to spare. Without hesitation, the feline grabbed Entrapta's hand

and dragged her up to the next level of the prison, running away from the approaching monstrosity as fast as she could.

As they ran higher and higher up the floors of the prison, they passed several different princesses and every single one of them brought up a specific image in Catra's brain – one that did not match with her reality.

Once they reached the highest level, Catra was unable to find the door and began to panic. This was when Entrapta, who had been oddly quiet and compliant this whole time, had simply tapped Catra on the shoulder and pointed upwards.

The feline sighed. Of course they would have to use the vents.

***

Catra was not sure whether it was by luck or destiny that she and Entrapta had been able to make it to a skiff hangar bay using the vents, but she was not going to count her blessings just yet.

As Catra drove the skiff she had stolen out of the Fright Zone, racing against the advancing void of death, the princess accompanying her silently tinkered with its engine to make it go faster than it ever had before.

Just as they entered the Whispering Woods, Catra suddenly realized they had no destination - not to mention she still had no answers to any of her questions. As if she had read her mind, the princess spoke up and said:

"Head for Dryl! I'll use my lab to figure out what's going on!"
Catra nodded slowly. Dryl – it was supposed to be under the Horde's control but she had never been there before.

With no idea what to expect, nor any way of knowing whether or not it was a trap, Catra decided to just do what she was told. After all, as Scorpia would have said:

“This doesn’t make sense but I’m gonna follow you because I don’t see a lot of other options.”

***

When Adora woke up, she became immediately aware of a throbbing pain in her head. She groaned angrily – Catra had betrayed her and she was going to make her pay!

As the blonde tried to get up, her headache increased and she suddenly saw flashes of images she could not describe; images of princesses, Catra, a hologram…

“Mara, dearie!” Adora looked up, ready to attack whoever had just spoken. But there was no one there.

Slowly, the blonde got to her feet and checked her injury in a mirror. As she rubbed her head, she thought she saw a set of scars on her cheek that had not been there before…

“Lord Adora! Are you okay?” Adora spun around to see Force Captain Lonnie. The blonde barked:

“Catra’s a traitor and so is the Force Captain who was just in here! Trace their badges and deactivate their access codes! We need to stop them!” Lonnie nodded, saluted and ran off to follow Adora’s orders. Within minutes, the Horde Lord found out where they were.

As she ran to the prison, however, Adora suddenly became aware of an old lady walking past her. She had butterflies flying around her.

“Hey! You! Stop!” When Adora turned to confront her, the old lady had disappeared. The blonde pouted – had Catra been right? Everything had been perfect until she had opened her big mouth…

“Boss! You coming?” Adora quickly shook the doubts from her mind and ran after Lonnie. When they made it to the prison, however, something was very wrong. There were no guards or

prisoners – in fact, there was no prison at all. Adora began to panic and turned to Lonnie:

"Force Captain, what's going on…?" As she did so, however, it became clear that Lonnie had disappeared too. That was when Adora saw it for the first time: the empty void consuming reality.

Screaming in terror, Adora ran down several corridors, barely making it to the nearest skiff hangar bay. She proceeded to jump into one of the vehicles and drive it away at maximum speed. She was too late, however. The void surrounded her just as she reached the Whispering Woods.

Adora screamed even louder as she felt half of her body cease to exist, but her unbridled hatred for Catra, as well as her undying determination to punish her for her betrayal, made the Horde Lord do the impossible; Adora leapt out of the skiff, successfully grabbing the literal edge of the Whispering Woods. She then painfully pulled herself up, eventually collapsing on the cool grass of the forest floor.

It was impossible to say how long she lay there, halfway between life and death. The right half of her body felt like it was on fire but Adora was all out of screams. The left side of her body tingled and sweated, reacting to the pain and anticipating its own disappearance.

Once Adora got her breath back, she growled ferociously and, summoning all her strength, hoisted herself up, refusing to look at her broken form and biting her tongue to prevent any more painful cries. It was right when she was about to get to her feet that she perceived the old woman from earlier standing over her.

She looked very old. And purple. Adora's mind was so scrambled that those were the only two bits of information she registered. Then the old lady gasped and spoke:

"Oh Adora… what have they done to you?" The blonde growled unintelligibly – still barely stopping herself from wailing in pain.

The woman slowly approached her, bent down and touched her unhurt shoulder:

"You don't know me, do you dearie? That's alright. My name is Razz and I'm here to help you." As soon as Razz touched her shoulder, Adora's pain subsided. Not only did her physical pain disappear entirely, but the constant yelling in her mind also paused - giving way to peace. It was as if the darkness was suddenly gone and Adora's mind was free. Sadly, there wasn't much left to be free with.

Adora's mind was completely empty except for a few scraps of different memories; some fake and some real with it being impossible to differentiate. However, one thing was for certain: Adora no longer wanted to kill and destroy. She did not want to pursue an objective nor did she want to stand for something. She just wanted to rest… Adora involuntarily sighed in relief and a tear rolled down her cheek. Razz smiled:

"Well now, am I talking to the real Adora or is the monster still there?" The blonde shook her head weakly before whispering:

"How… how are you doing this?" Razz chuckled:

"My magic is much stronger than that of whoever did this to you. But, sadly, I can't stay with you very long." As if to enunciate her words, a chunk of the forest loudly disappeared into the void. Adora's eyes widened:

"Razz… what's happening? What do I do?" Razz grinned as she explained:

"Your sword, dearie. You need to find your sword. That's how Mara opened a portal last time. And how she closed it." Adora shook her head in confusion, a small flashback of Light Hope lecturing her on the former She-Ra playing in her broken head:

"A portal? Wait… I thought… I thought Mara went crazy and almost destroyed Etheria…" Razz laughed:

"No, you nincompoop! Mara didn't destroy us! She *saved* us! And now you'll do the same! You just need some help!" This did not assure Adora, who began to panic:

"Help? From who?! I… I'm not sure where I've come from or what just happened, but I do know that I'm Lord of the Horde and that all my allies are gone; princess or otherwise…" Razz, completely unfazed by Adora's despair, simply winked at her:

"Not all of them." Adora raised her eyebrow at the old woman, who now stood back up while maintaining her hold on the blonde's shoulder:

"The one you seek is alive. Find her and go back to the beginning together." Adora stuttered:

"B-Back to the beginning…?" Just then, Razz removed her hand and it was as if a red mist descended upon Adora, taking over her mind once more. The blonde closed her eyes and fought it, determined to keep her peace. She heard Razz walk past her, whispering in her ear as she went to face her fate in the void:

"All that witch did was mess with your memories. Stop letting yourself be led by them, stop letting them shape your identity! And, most important of all, never lose sight of who you really are! You are *not* Lord of the Horde *nor* are you She-Ra! Those are just titles. You are Adora - and the only person who can truly control your mind is *you*."

***

When Adora finally opened her eyes, she was no longer in the Whispering Woods. She was now sitting opposite Entrapta's castle in Dryl and another alarm was blaring.

Everything still hurt and Adora still felt a wave of unsurmountable rage. However, this time, there was another voice that spoke above the rest in her head. It was a quiet one with enough authority to make itself heard:

“Catra’s here. Catra can help you. Go and find Catra.”

Chapter End Notes

Okay, I know there are A LOT of different HCs and theories about the portal and how it works (all of them are super cool - I don't have a preferred one) - so I opted for the vaguest possible explanation based off what ND Stevenson said when asked: In the show, the portal is Catra's perfect world which is heavily influenced by Adora herself. So, in this fic, the portal is Horde Adora's perfect world while is heavily influenced by Catra. A good example of Catra's influence is Scorpia (she would normally have been locked up with the other princesses but, because of Catra, she was not). I hope that helps to clarify everything. If you have any other questions, feel free to ask! :))

As for whether or not Razz just healed Adora from her mind control, yeah she kinda did. Adora is able to think clearly now but, like I tried to explain, her mind's so wrecked that it doesn't mean much. She's just a little less murdery and more willing to listen to Catra. As for whether or not this will continue to be the case after the portal, I guess you'll have to wait and see! ;))

And yes, I freely admit I got a bit lazy writing Razz and made her much more intelligible than she is in canon (and also gave her magic abilities which were only ever implied at most), but I was just feeling really sorry for Adora, okay? I had just 'portal-Catra'd' her. No one deserves that (except maybe Prime and Shadow Weaver). I felt it was high-time I gave her a break and Razz thought so too.

Part 2 will be uploaded soon - I can't wait for you to read it! Thank you guys for all the love you've given this fic - your comments and kudos make my day! I hope you all have a fantastic 24 hours! Thanks for reading!!!

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

> Hey everyone! Sorry it's taken me so long to update - a lot has happened! I've got my Masters (I received a commendation!) and a new job! So, to celebrate, here are another 3000 words of Catra and Adora being put through untold agony. Enjoy! :))

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Angella woke up and immediately smiled. She was in her bed in Brightmoon and the moon had risen, shining its glorious light across her chambers. It reflected beautifully on the crystalline walls and, more importantly, on the soft pale skin of her sleeping husband.

The queen was so happy to have her king next to her. She could not quite explain how but it was as if he had been gone for years and had only just got back. Of course, these were unsubstantiated feelings… right?

Angella's thoughts were interrupted when Micah began to stir. He opened his eyes and smiled lovingly at his wife:

"Good morning" he murmured sleepily. Angella smiled even wider:

"Good morning, my love."

Two hours later, when they had got dressed, eaten and started walking towards the throne room, Angella glanced at one of the many murals adorning the hallway. For a split second, she thought she saw the image of someone resembling both Micah and her: a girl - their daughter… This observation gave the queen such a violent headache that she collapsed on the floor, moaning in pain. Without waiting a second, Micah fell to his knees next to her, calling her name. Angella quickly regained her composure:

“It’s okay, I’m alright! I thought I saw something…”

“What was it?” The queen looked up and gazed far off into the distance. In the furthest recesses of her brain, she could hear a child laughing:

“Nothing. It was nothing.”

The morning passed with no further incidents. The fact that it seemed to pass in a matter of minutes did not worry Angella.

After the cook announced lunch, the monarchs descended from their thrones and headed towards the dining hall. While Micah attempted to make idle conversation about the morning’s activities, the queen remained silent:

“…so many of them were convinced someone had attacked their villages - too many! But I don’t recall hearing anything about a horde of soldiers-” At the mention of the word ‘horde’, Angella’s head screamed in pain and she fell to the floor once again, clutching her head in her hands:

“Argh! Make it stop!” Micah quickly knelt down and did a healing spell, temporarily relieving the queen and giving her enough time to reach up and grab him by his shirt:

“Something’s wrong, Micah. Something’s very wrong.” It was right at this point that Angella saw her first glimpse of reality falling apart. She then felt Micah’s hands leave hers and turned to see that he had inexplicably disappeared.

After a brief search (and several more terrifying visions of the portal engulfing Brightmoon), the queen fled. She remembered that she had had a daughter - and that she no longer had a husband. She also knew that the mysterious horde of attackers was not fake and that she had to fly to Dryl immediately.

If anyone could figure out what was happening, it was Entrapta.

***

“Hello! Do I know you?” Catra whipped round to try and make out who Entrapta was talking to. She was not sure how long the two of them had been holed up in the princess’ dimly lit and rather creepy lab, but it had been long enough for her to start getting jittery. Catra’s growing fear was not helped by how uncharacteristically quiet Entrapta was being. This was science – why was she not rambling into her tape recorder? Did she even have her tape recorder?

“N-No…” Catra’s eyes went wide as she was bought back to the present by the voice emerging from the darkness. She could not see who had just materialized in the furthest corner of the lab, only that it was someone tall and broad-shouldered. But she would recognize that voice anywhere…

“Adora, stay back!” Catra unsheathed her claws and prepared to pounce. No way was Adora here to help – she was here to fight. She had to be.

Right as the Horde Lord was about to step into the light, Entrapta suddenly rushed forward, cutting off Catra’s attack and levitating herself off the ground with her hair:

“This is fascinating! I never have non-robots visit me! ” Catra leapt onto the princess’ back in a desperate attempt to get her out of the way:

“Entrapta! Get down, you crazy-”

“Argh!” Both the princess and the Force Commander stopped wrestling and looked down at their visitor. Neither of them had gotten a good look at her yet but, now that they had, they could not help but mutually gasp in horror.

Adora was breaking apart. Literally. Half of her had ceased to exist and the rest of her was threatening to go. She was in so much pain that she had collapsed to the floor, crying out from the impact.

All fear and common sense disintegrating, Catra immediately disengaged herself from Entrapta and ran towards Adora. Once she reached her, she gently lifted her up, resting her head on her lap.

Adora whimpered and shook her head in visible discomfort – she was remembering.

Catra pulled her closer, enveloping her in an embrace that she hoped would make her feel better. Then she did what she had always done to calm Adora down – she purred. It worked.

Adora stopped shifting and, for nearly a full minute, there was peace. But only for a minute.

"C-Catra…" The feline looked down at the broken face of her love, trying very hard to hold it together. She whispered:

"… Yes?" Adora, shaking in pain, closed her eyes and whispered:

"H-Help me…"

***

Horde Prime stared at his screen in mild interest. A portal had opened into a previously lost dimension – a portal which had been created by something within it.

It was familiar and Prime grinned as reports of First Ones and magic appeared before him.

There *was* yet another world for him to destroy and remake… good. He had been bored.

Without uttering a word, the galactic emperor snapped his fingers and his nearest ship sent a probe straight into the portal. It was imperative that he learn as much as possible about this new world before it closed. He then telepathically ordered his armada to converge on the portal's co-ordinates; it was time to bring peace to this world seeking to destroy itself.

***

Adora had fallen unconscious in Catra's arms and the feline was hugging her so tight her muscles ached. She was on the verge of crying and the only thing stopping her was Entrapta, who was still standing where Catra had left her, awkwardly shuffling her feet and rubbing her arms.

"What?" Catra hissed threateningly. In all honesty, she did not want to scare Entrapta nor yell at her – the feline was just in so much pain and it was all getting too much to bear. Thankfully, the princess seemed to understand this:

"Your friend seems to have fallen into the unstable portal slowly consuming and warping our reality. I… I don't know if she'll be okay." Catra forced herself to keep purring. If Adora was going to die, this was how it would be – in the arms of the only person who ever truly loved her despite everything she had done and was made to be. Entrapta kept talking:

"An unstable portal is the only thing that would account for all the anomalies I've been picking up in my research. The portal exists somewhere in our world and, as long as it's still open, it's gonna keep destabilizing reality, making things disappear faster and faster, until… there's nothing left..." Catra finally looked up at the princess, eyes wet with pain. She yelled angrily:

"*How do we stop it?*" Entrapta shuffled some more, as if she wanted to speak but could not. Finally, she gave in and used her hair to carry her back to her screens. She then turned on a very helpful video that provided visual aids to her speech:

"Portals are gateways, wormholes that connect one area of space to another. The only way to turn it off is from the inside. But… whoever shuts the portal down can't leave. They'll be trapped between realities, possibly forever." Catra's eyes went wide. She repeated Entrapta's statement:

"… Forever?" The princess nodded. The feline finally gave up all hope and started crying. They were ugly tears mixed with loud mangled cries. The noise woke up Adora, who was now even weaker than she was before:

"C-Catra?" The feline turned to face the blonde, not bothering to hide her tears. Adora mustered all her strength to give her own sad speech, accompanied by an even sadder smile:

"I… I'm so sorry… for everything… I… I love you… S-See you… back at… the… beginning…" Catra screamed:

"*No! Adora*!" But it was too late. The blonde vanished and the back of Entrapta's lab disappeared into the void. The princess called out to Catra as everything started to break apart:

"It's the sword! The portal is powered by She-Ra's sword! You need to remove it from the inside! As soon as it's gone, everything will be right again! It was nice being friends with you!" Catra screamed again:

"Entrapta!" But, like last time, it was no use. Entrapta and the whole of Dryl were gone, and Catra was falling, watching as her body began to disappear too… and not caring if it did…

***

Angella groaned in fear and frustration. The portal had eaten up everything below and around her. It was a miracle she had managed to stay above it all.

She was now flying over what had been Dryl, gasping as she watched it get destroyed. The queen only stopped her gasp when she observed a familiar figure falling through the air – though the reason for her still being alive remained a mystery to her.

Angella flew down and grabbed the survivor under her arms, calling her name as she did so:

“Catra!” The feline jerked her head up, tears streaming down her face. Angella went white – she had never seen Catra like this before. Then again, how else would she be in this situation? The Force Commander began to twist and turn in her grasp, screaming:

“*Let me go! Let me die! Just let me go-*”

“No!” The queen retorted angrily. Her response shut Catra up and allowed Angella to continue:

“We can still stop this! We have to! Please tell me there’s a reason you’re still alive?” Catra did not respond. Instead she whimpered and wailed like a literal lost kitten. Angella sighed sadly:

“Fine… that’s okay. I’ll figure this out…” After a moment of painful silence, Catra finally resigned herself to living a little longer and recovered long enough to say:

“The sword.” The queen’s eyes went wide at Catra’s sudden interruption. The feline’s voice was so broken that the words were hard to make out:

“The sword… She-Ra’s sword… we have to find She-Ra’s sword!” Angella nodded silently, quickly scanning the missing horizon for anything at all. That was when Catra’s keen eyesight picked something up in the far distance. She pointed, whispering:

“T-There...” Angella silently obeyed, flying as fast as she could towards what she hoped would be their salvation.

***

While it only took a few minutes for Angella to reach the floating patch of grass under the portal’s mouth, it felt like an eternity for Catra. All she could see was Adora’s broken face, tear-stained and writhing in pain, looking up at her as if she really was the only person who could help her – even though she could not. Had not.

Adora's weak voice whispered her apologies, love and another empty promise. Catra remembered everything now. She knew what happened to Adora, what *she* had let happen to Adora. She knew that while the blonde may have deserved her fate, she, Catra, deserved it so much more.

How could she have been party to so much pain? How could she have inflicted so much on the people of Etheria?

Entrapta had said that the only way to fix all this was to remove the sword, and that the person who did that would be trapped in this hell forever. As far as Catra could tell, she and the queen were the only ones left.

It would have to be one of them – and it was not going to be Sparkles' mom.

As Angella landed on the grass, dropping Catra gently on the ground as she did so, she paused to catch her breath. Catra let her. The queen then turned to look at her and asked:

"So… what now?" The feline sighed and pointed up at the sword:

"You fly me up there and I'll remove the sword." Angella raised an eyebrow in confusion:

"Wouldn't it be simpler if I just flew up and removed the sword? Why do you have to do it?" Catra did not miss a beat as she replied almost robotically:

"Because the person who removes it remains trapped in the portal forever… between dimensions…" Angella gasped and the feline continued, this time with a little more feeling as she turned back to address the queen:

"I know you're a good person. I know you don't deserve this fate. I do. I'm the villain – this is *all my fault*! Please let me make it right? Let me fix this for you, for your daughter, for… for…" Angella gave a sad smile before finishing the sentence:

"… For Adora?" Catra's eyes went wide and another tear escaped. The queen sighed and said:

"It's not your fault, Catra. You don't deserve this anymore than I do." Catra shook her head solemnly before countering:

"Okay, fine. But I am not more valuable than you. You lead the Rebellion and, now that you and your princesses are in the Fright Zone, the Horde doesn't stand a chance. Take it! End the war!" Angella gasped:

"I beg your pardon?" Catra growled:

"You heard me! End it! End all of it! You'll definitely do a better job than me!" Angella shook her head in shock. She genuinely could not believe the words coming out of Catra's mouth:

"So… you don't want to win?" Catra scowled and looked away in shame:

"No. I want… I don't know what I want. Redemption, maybe?" Angella smiled and silently walked over to Catra, putting her arms around her and giving her the best hug she could manage. The feline, normally so strong and stoic, completely broke down in sobs at the first hint of motherly affection that she had ever received.

The two stood there hugging for a long time.

Finally, Catra pushed herself away from the queen and straightened her uniform. She then pulled off her iconic face guard and threw it into the dirt below her. Angella broadened her smile:

"I'll tell them, Catra. About this. You'll be forgiven." The feline wiped her eyes and looked back up at the sword:

"I don't care. Just look after Adora and end this war." The queen nodded and moved behind Catra, ready to pick her up.

“Are you ready?”

“Let's go! Now!”

***

Catra could not describe the feeling she felt as she pulled out the sword, watching it disappear from her hands the second she did so. It was almost like peace, fulfilment, happiness… but it was not. In fact, it was the greatest heartbreak she never imagined could exist – and it was so great that the sheer intensity of emotion was tricking her into believing everything was alright.

As the feline finally allowed herself to close her eyes and let out the most feral scream she could manage, her sensitive ears heard something nearby – a mechanical beep.

Catra opened her eyes and was shocked to see what looked like a larger and sleeker version of one of the Horde’s bots. It was right in front of her and immediately proceeded to knock her out with a built-in tazer before grabbing her and flying away at top speed.

***

The first person to wake up was She-Ra. She was lying on the floor of Hordak’s sanctum, surrounded by unconscious guards and princesses. Her head ached horribly and her ears were ringing.

The red mist was back even stronger than before but Adora stubbornly refused to let it control her. Instead, she de-transformed and began scanning the room for Catra. Catra, the one she had always loved…

She was not there.

That was when everyone else began to wake up, all simultaneously moving backwards towards to walls, pointing their weapons and magic hands at Adora, ready to fire without hesitation.

But Adora did not care. Where was Catra? Surely she was-

"Adora?" The blonde turned to face the queen of Brightmoon. The angel slowly approached her, holding a piece of metal Adora never imagined she would see in someone else's hands – Catra's face guard.

"Catra's… not here, Adora." With that, the blonde tentatively took the mask into her own hands, cradling it in her arms before losing it completely and keeling over, screaming in agony at the loss of her love. Everyone else simply stared, stunned and utterly confused.

***

When Catra came to, she was lying on a smooth cold floor. It was dark and smelt as if she was back in the infirmary. Her mind began to wonder whether she had never left and this whole thing had been some insane hallucination. Ha! Now that was funny! What would Adora say?

Catra's heart ached at the thought of Adora and, as she sat up and looked around, the former Force Commander quickly ascertained that she was definitely *not* in the infirmary.

Then, as if on cue, the lights all turned on and Catra gasped when she realized that she was on the bridge of the biggest spaceship she had ever seen. How did she know it was a spaceship? It was honestly all that made sense at the moment.

Speaking of the moment, Catra's feline senses alerted her to the presence of others on the bridge. She whipped around to see three Hordaks, two of whom were wearing different outfits while the other not only wore a different outfit but had three eyes. Completely disgusted and afraid, it did not take long for Catra to figure out who this was:

"… Prime…" The three-eyed monster laughed menacingly, holding up her Force Commander badge in his right hand:

“Welcome, Little Sister.”

Chapter End Notes

Well... wasn't that something? I'm now gonna run out the back before you all kill me! XD Your comments and kudos mean the world to me! Thank you so much for all the love you've already shown the fic! Have an awesome day/ night!!! :))

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

> Hey everybody! Sorry this took so long to post - life's been very busy! I got yet another job and am back to doing classes again! Anyway, I hope you enjoy the next traumatic instalment of this increasingly tragic saga! :))

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Darkness… eternal and infinite darkness… that was all Catra had known since Horde Prime had thrown her in the water. To be honest, that was her only real memory of her life before becoming trapped in her own head. Every now and again there would be an unexplained flash of light - but then it would go and the darkness would return.

Catra's days (or what she assumed were days) were spent floating around in her personal void of nothingness trying hard to remember. She knew she had been someone before all this – that she had done something. And whatever it was had warranted the punishment of Horde Prime. He was the only person she remembered – the horrible voice that still echoed in her head. She had long since forgotten what his words were though. The only word she could remember (besides her own name) was "Adora."

A word and a feeling – that was all it was. But whatever it was, it always confused Catra. In retrospect, this was the biggest mystery – the key to all of this and the real thing she was trying to remember: Adora.

She had yelled that when she had been thrown in the pool – her last word. And she had no idea what it meant. Was it a name? A slogan? A slur? A combination of all three? Catra truly had no idea.

Anything linked to the word was always blocked by the memory of the pool – the awful green electrical water that burned her inside

and out. For a long time she had been convinced it had killed her and that her current life was actually death. But it could not be true – not really. The random flashes and continued echoes of Horde Prime's voice proved that.

She was trapped in her own mind – she had to be. It was all that made sense.

***

300 days before Prime's defeat

It had been five months since the portal incident. Adora had surrendered without a fight to the princesses that day in the Fright Zone.

At the same time, there had been a mighty battle in the Kingdom of Snows between the remnants of the Horde and the princesses, with the princesses winning as Adora's surrender was announced across all of Etheria.

Since then, the Princess Alliance had worked hard to end the war. Queen Angella had pardoned all the soldiers and Force Captains, only putting Shadow Weaver and Hordak on trial. Both of them had been declared guilty and were now imprisoned for life in the heart of the Fright Zone.

No one had known what to do with Adora. Most of the princesses (and people of Etheria) had wanted her put on trial too. The problem was, however, that Adora had not been fit to stand trial. She had fallen into a deep depression and had said nothing since the day she surrendered. Not only that but Shadow Weaver had unashamedly admitted that she had cast a spell on Adora that had turned her into Despara and that, because of this, they would never see She-Ra again. So Adora remained in the spare room, guarded by Juliet and not saying a word.

Interestingly, Hordak had also said nothing. He did not offer a word of defence during his whole trial and had just let the

princesses condemn him; only reacting negatively when Catra was brought up.

Catra was a subject no one wanted to bring up. All the princesses (and most of the people of Etheria) had accepted that she had saved them and that she was the person who had initially defeated Hordak and Shadow Weaver. However, her title of "Force Commander", as well as her association with Despara, did not make her popular.

Anyway, the trials and grand proclamations had been dealt with weeks ago. After that, the princesses had had a new problem: fixing the damage caused by the war. So many Horde battalions had been sceptical of their leader's order to surrender and it had taken the princesses longer than they would have liked to reclaim their kingdoms. However, now that five months had passed, everything was back to normal (or as normal as it could be) and repairs had finally started in all the kingdoms and the Fright Zone.

Scorpia had been given charge of the Fright Zone (as it was technically her kingdom) on the condition that she was supervised by Perfuma (who had happily volunteered for the job). The two had become quite close and no one was quite sure how to process it. Glimmer and Bow had also become close, regularly visiting Adora in the hopes she would remember them.

She did but kept pretending otherwise. It was easier that way.

As Bow and Glimmer left the spare room for what felt like the hundredth time, Glimmer sighed louder than usual. Today, the Princess Alliance would have their first monthly meeting and they only had one item on the agenda: to decide what to do with Adora. Bow put his hand on her shoulder, pulling her in her a hug.

"It's okay. It'll be okay." Glimmer tried and failed to smile:

"Easy for you to say. You don't have to vote." Bow pulled back and looked Glimmer in the eye:

“You and I have seen Adora more than anyone else these last few months. We know that her hair is growing back, that our visits are all she wakes up for, and that she has definitely found a way to fight the spell – no matter how much she pretends she hasn’t.” Glimmer raised her eyebrow:

“What are you saying?” Bow sighed:

“She’s fit to stand trial, Glimmer. She has been for a while now.” Glimmer gasped in horror:

“But Bow, you know how that will end!” Bow shook his head:

“No I don’t and neither do you. Adora has a real chance at being acquitted – more than anyone else in the Horde.” Glimmer looked down at the ground as Bow continued:

“Adora needs a change, Glimmer. I get that it was too soon five months ago but she needs to be given a purpose, to be shown she can be forgiven and that she can move on. After all, we never liked her for being She-Ra. We liked her for being her… and I miss her.” With that, Glimmer pulled Bow back in for a hug, nodding into his shoulder:

“I know… me too.”

***

Catra could not quite explain it. One minute she was floating in her void, still aimlessly wondering what “Adora” meant when, all of a sudden, there was a flash of blinding light and a distinct female voice could be heard distantly yelling:

“Catra!” Then, as usual, the darkness returned and Catra was left with more questions. Only this time, she felt she had an answer: Adora was a name – the name of a girl who was important to Catra…

The feline fought to try and remember anything else besides the only knowledge she had been given: a name and… maybe a

voice? Had that been Adora's voice?

Catra was so frustrated she wanted to cry, but she could not cry in this world. All she could do was think. Think and listen.

***

286 days before Prime's defeat

Adora refused to look anyone in the eye as she was led out for her trial. Another couple of weeks had passed and she had still not said a word.

The blonde was sat down on a chair in the centre of the throne room of Brightmoon (she would normally have been forced to kneel but she was so weak that Angella had insisted on a chair). The queen stood up and raised her sceptre, officially starting the trial. And it started.

Each princess stepped forward and presented all the evidence against Adora. All of her crimes and the damage she had caused. However, they also each said something positive about Adora, like how she had been a great asset to the Rebellion before Princess Prom. How she was the main reason the Princess Alliance was reformed and how they all missed her.

The confusing contradictory evidence proved too much for Adora and she ended up startling everyone by suddenly breaking down and crying her eyes out, raising her chained hands to cover up her show of emotion. A couple of guards were about to rush forward but Bow stopped them, running forward himself with Glimmer in tow. Together, they knelt down and gave Adora the best hug they could manage.

For a long time, they stayed like that. And both Bow and Glimmer could swear they heard a broken whisper in their ears:

'I-I'm s-sorry…"

***

Without any more explanation than the previous time, the flash of blinding light had returned and Catra had seen something. It was brief – barely more than a glimpse – but it was enough.

Adora was a blonde! And an attractive blonde at that. But why had she looked so scared? Catra really had only got the tiniest glance before her world had returned to darkness, but she had been paying so much attention that she had observed blue eyes staring straight into hers, lips quivering in fear and sweat practically dripping from the most comically large forehead she could ever imagine.

There had been a sickly green light behind the girl, kind of like the light behind Horde Prime when he had thrown Catra in the water.

The feline growled noiselessly. Was this a memory? How was she only able to remember this now? Had that really been Adora? What was wrong with her? Something was definitely wrong!

Would she ever know the truth? Could she ever know the truth?

***

194 days before Prime's defeat

Three months had passed and Adora's health had been improving. Her hair had almost grown back to its normal length and she had started eating and drinking again.

As Bow had predicted, Adora had been acquitted on the condition she remain under the supervision of Bow and Glimmer. She also had to commit to getting better, which meant therapy sessions with Perfuma and medical check-ups with Castaspella. The latter had been convinced she could heal Adora permanently, completely removing the power of the spell. Unfortunately, she had yet to succeed. As Castaspella had explained, there had only ever been one other magic user who could equal Shadow Weaver - and that had been her brother and Glimmer's father: Micah.

Anyway, Adora was now on her way to Mystacor for her weekly check-up and Bow was teasing her about how nice her hair looked now:

"I have to say, I prefer you like this! You look more like you!" Adora gave a small smile. It was forced and all she could manage after everything that had happened, but her friends always got so excited when she did so that she wanted to do it as much as she could.

As expected, Bow gave a giant smile and ran on ahead to find Glimmer, no doubt to let her know that Adora had smiled again.

As soon as he ran off, however, Adora's facial expression changed. Her eyes watered, her lip quivered and it was all she could do to not raise her hand to her cheek where scars had healed, scars that she directly associated with her once short hair, scars given to her by someone who was no longer there… and who would never come back.

***

Catra could not explain it but her non-existent physical body had suddenly decided to announce its existence – she felt sick.

For the first time in her living memory, the feline felt like she would physically throw up. The blinding lights kept returning and disappearing, new noises and old echoes rattled her brain… and then it all ended.

For what felt like the first time in her life, Catra opened her eyes – properly. And then she actually did throw up.

Adora (the blonde from earlier) was lying on the floor, bleeding out from a stab wound. And Catra was holding the knife.

***

143 days before Prime's defeat

Adora sighed sadly. Another couple of months had passed and, while significant progress had been made, she was still not fully healed from her curse.

A week before, Entrapta had suggested they investigate some stories she had heard while imprisoned by the Horde - namely the myth of Beast Island. What if it was real? What if it had the cure for Adora and the answer to all of the First Ones' mysteries?

Adora cared less about the science and more about getting rid of the eternal red mist that never left and always threatened to break out and hurt her friends.

Speaking of them, the blonde was now even closer to Bow and Glimmer. With their help, she had made a couple of public appearances where she had officially apologized to the people of Etheria and her former soldiers. It had been an awful but important step in her healing process and she could not have done it without the help of the Best Friend Squad.

Adora had also built up enough courage to share some of her memories with her friends – memories of when she was Despara and had little to no control over what she was doing. Both Bow and Glimmer had been understanding and forgiving, and now both they and Entrapta were accompanying her on a boat heading to Beast Island.

Adora genuinely wondered what she would have done without her friends. Now that Catra was gone, they really were all she had left to live for.

***

There was so much information to process all at once. In front of Catra lay the blonde she had glimpsed earlier, unconscious and bleeding through her red jacket on the cold white floor. The room she was in was not a mere room but a grand throne room within a gigantic edifice that Catra recognized as Horde Prime's ship.

As if on reflex, Catra turned around, searching for the man responsible for her imprisonment. She could not see him, however. There was no one else on the bridge except her and… Adora. Upon realizing this, Catra looked down.

She was still holding the bloody knife and was dressed in a white outfit that she did not recognize. She saw her tail and unsheathed claws but felt as though they were not hers. It was as though they had not been hers for a long time…

That was when Catra finally became conscious of the physical pain she was feeling. Aside from feeling nauseous, her back felt like it had been repeatedly stabbed. The feline dropped the knife and quickly ran her hands down it, surprised to find not blood but metal. There seemed to be five or six metal ports implanted into her back. And they were all unplugged.

As the feline cautiously checked her surroundings for the connecting wires, she saw the screens behind the throne flashing and her hearing suddenly returned. A siren blared and Horde Prime's voice screamed:

"Horde Prime has been disconnected! Horde Prime has been disconnected! Horde Prime-"

"C-Catra?" The feline turned back to face Adora. Somehow the blonde had managed to wake up and sit up. She was still bleeding and looked worryingly pale - but she was smiling. It was a beautiful smile…

Catra breathed hoarsely:

"H-Hey Adora…"

***

142 days before Prime's defeat

Saving Micah had been such an incredible experience. Adora had finally felt like she had done something good after all this time.

Not only that but she had finally been She-Ra again.

Unsurprisingly, Adora had not been allowed near her sword until a couple of months ago; and even then she had not wanted to touch it. She blamed the sword for killing Catra and it remained a painful reminder of what had happened in the beacon.

However, on her friends' insistence, Adora had brought the sword with her to Beast Island. While there, she had managed to overcome the island's vines and save her friends by reconnecting with her weapon and finally accepting everything that had led her to that moment.

As she leaned against the railing of the boat taking them all back to Brightmoon, Entrapta suddenly tapped her shoulder with her sentient hair:

"Hey! Guess what? I just learned something super important from those data crystals I found! You ever hear about the Heart of Etheria?"

***

Catra cautiously moved forward, reminding herself how to move her own body as she did so.

As her sense of touch continued to slowly return to her, the feline realized her left eye felt really weird. Almost as if it had been changed… Catra reached up to touch it with her left hand. Before she reached it, however, Adora began to violently shake her head:

"N-No Catra! Don't-" It was too late. Catra had felt the extra eye slits above and below her left eye. She screamed and fell to the ground. Everything made so much sense so quickly.

Horde Prime had not simply turned her into another clone. She had become his new body. She had been altered… she had been Horde Prime…

A hand touched hers – preventing her from breaking down completely. The feline looked up to see Adora looking down at her lovingly. The effort of grabbing her hand had taken more strength than the blonde had, however, and a tear fell from her cheek as she painfully whispered her final words:

"It's… okay… Catra… I… still… love… you…"

***

112 days before Prime's defeat

Adora screamed furiously. Not only was she furious but she was in extreme physical pain.

It had been a month since Micah had been rescued and Adora had finally been successfully cured of her curse. Entrapta had shared her findings with the other princesses and, after much debate, it had been decided that they should try and free the magic at the Heart of Etheria. They had not known how to do that, however, and had decided to first try activating the Heart of Etheria.

This was how Adora came to find herself keeling over in the throne room in Brightmoon as all the princesses fainted around her. She heard Light Hope's voice echoing in her brain, telling her to give in, raise her sword and destroy her people's enemies.

The blonde gasped in shock and wonder as she saw her world had been teleported out of the dimension of Despondos. Groaning in agony, it was all Adora could do to bring her raised sword crashing down to the ground.

As the sword shattered, so did She-Ra. And when Adora finally woke from her momentary coma, it was clear the rest of Etheria was about to suffer as much as she had.

All the princesses looked on in horror as spaceships flew above the palace and giant robotic antennas landed in the Whispering Woods.

Adora scrambled to her feet and joined her friends on the main balcony. Just as she did so, a holographic image was projected from the spires – a face that made Adora nearly faint again: Catra.

The feline did not look like how anyone remembered her. Her hair was cut short and groomed back. Her left eye had extra eye slits above and below it. Her outfit was white and grey with the Horde symbol emblazoned proudly on her chest.

Honestly, Adora would have been inclined to believe it was not the real Catra, had it not been for her disfigured ear… the same ear Despara had cut all those months ago…

Catra smiled eerily and raised her arms, speaking in a robotic voice that sent chills down the spines of all who heard her:

"Rejoice Etheria, for Prime has come to you!"

***

"N-No, no, no, no, no!" Catra's pleas turned to screams as Adora's body turned cold in her arms. Her senses were all finally returning and the sensory overload was too much.

Her sensitive ears told her an untold number of clones were trying to break into the room, presumably in response to the alert.

Her body was cramping and aching as it got used to being used by its original owner once again, and all the foreign body parts began to hurt the more Catra acknowledged their existence.

Trying desperately to ignore all of this, and still failing to remember exactly who Adora was or who she herself really was, Catra focused on what she did have some control over. She ripped off the cloak she had apparently been wearing and put it over Adora's bleeding chest, pressing hard on her injury. That was when she found she had the ability to purr.

Catra was not sure how she was able to, and it honestly hurt to continue once she started, but Adora stirred in response to it. This made the feline concentrate hard and, as she focused on purring, one solitary yet key memory resurfaced. It was enough.

The feline pulled Adora as close to her as she could, leaned down so she could whisper in her ear, and said:

"Adora, I love you too. I always have. Please, just this once, stay…"

Chapter End Notes

So... um... I genuinely don't know whether either of our leading ladies will survive the final chapter but I'll do my best! As always, your comments and kudos mean the world to me! Thank you for reading! :))

P.S. Just to clarify, Catra's POV is the present and Adora's POV is the countdown to that same moment. It'll all end in the next chapter! Stay tuned for more! ;))

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

> Well, it finally happened! I sat down and finished writing this thing - it's over!!! I really hope you enjoy this final instalment as much as I enjoyed writing it. And you know what? For once, I don't have any warnings to give you! Just sit back, relax and enjoy! :))

See the end of the chapter for more notes

82 days before Prime's defeat

Adora sighed in frustration as the princesses continued to argue about what to do. The meeting had been going on for far too long and the blonde started to reflect on their predicament. It had been a month since Prime's invasion and everything had gone so wrong so quickly.

There were now more than a hundred of those horrid spires planted on the planet's surface and thousands of bots and clones scoured the kingdoms, destroying anyone who dared to resist them.

The princesses had fought back as best they could but there were simply too many invaders. That and She-Ra was no longer with them. It was a miracle that they had all made it this far without getting captured or worse.

No one had seen Catra since the holographic projection and Entrapta had theorized that she was broadcasting from one of the spaceships above them. As it was seemingly impossible to identify which one, yet alone go up there to find her, the idea of directly confronting her had been abandoned.

That was until Adora's old squadron had sent a message to the Rebellion.

The squadron, along with the vast majority of the Horde, had moved to the Crimson Waste after the war. It was from there that Lonnie had sent a picture of what Entrapta claimed to be an old First Ones' spaceship.

As far as Adora was concerned, this was the answer to their problems. They just had to go and get this ship, fix it up, and save Catra. However, no one else seemed to see it this way… Adora was suddenly brought back to the present by Glimmer yelling:

"Adora! Are you listening? What do you think?" Adora stuttered:

"Uh… um…" Mermista, who was being more salty than usual, chimed in:

"Oh leave her alone, Glimmer! We know what Adora wants!" Adora almost growled:

"What's that supposed to mean?" Mermista rolled her eyes:

"You still think Catra can be saved. That saving her should take precedence over anything else!" Adora angrily retorted:

"She is the key! I'm sure of it! There's a reason she was the one giving that speech – she's leading this new Horde army! And she has no idea she is!" Mermista face-palmed herself and Perfuma cautiously stepped forward:

"Adora, what if this is who she is now? I think we can all agree that something has happened to her and she is no longer herself… but how do you know she can still be helped?" Adora raised her eyebrow in surprise:

"How do *I* know that she can be helped? How did *you* know that *I* could be helped? Come on, you're the therapist! We won't know until we try!" Perfuma drooped her head ashamedly and Micah stepped forward:

"That's not what Perfuma meant, Adora. I get that you want to help your friend, I really do. And if we had a better idea of what

we were dealing with, I would be all for it. But Catra isn't suffering from an evil spell or even a diagnosable mental illness. She has been physically altered by some kind of alien entity and no one here, except maybe Entrapta, can help with that." With that, Entrapta raised one of her sentient pigtails in support:

"That doesn't mean I wouldn't love to, though!" Adora teared up before finally screaming at everyone:

"What the hell is wrong with all of you?! This is the first lucky break we've had in weeks and you don't want to take it because you think Catra's in a worse state than I was when you saved me?! You're supposed to be the good guys! You saved me and you can save her too – whatever state she's in! Not only that but we owe her! We *all* owe her! So let's end this war and end it right!"

***

50 days before Prime's defeat

It had been just over a month since the meeting where the princesses had decided to relocate to the Crimson Waste. Once they had arrived, Entrapta and Bow had started working around the clock to get the ship up and running. They had soon discovered, with Adora's help, that it used to be Mara's ship. Mara, the previous She-Ra, had even left a message warning Adora about the Heart of Etheria – a message she had received too late.

While the two tech wizards worked, the rest of the Rebellion took it in turns to go on rescue missions around the planet to help however much they could. It was also so they could keep Prime distracted from what they were doing in the Crimson Waste as, like Adora said, this ship was the first lucky break they had had.

Today, Adora was having a mandated rest in her tent. She was just drifting off to sleep when Entrapta burst in yelling:

"Adora, I think I found a way to find Prime's exact location! You think you could get me next to one of those spires?"

***

19 days before Prime's defeat

Bow sat in the cockpit of Mara's ship as Entrapta counted down:

"5… 4… 3… 2… 1… Lift off!" With that, Bow activated the thrusters and Mara's ship left the ground.

Adora watched in wonder as the ship flew higher and higher, eventually leaving Etheria's atmosphere. So much had happened in the previous month. Most notably, the ship had finally been fully repaired and Entrapta had been able to hack into one of Prime's spires to identify his location. And now, finally, they were on their way to save Catra.

Glimmer had told her not to get her hopes up.

Bow had explained it would take them at least two weeks to reach her.

And Entrapta had said that, while she would give it her best shot, she could not guarantee that she could help Catra.

Adora tried to accept the reality her friends were presenting her, but she refused to. Catra had given everything to save her and Etheria. It was finally time for Adora to return the favour.

***

4 days before Prime's defeat

Adora smiled as Entrapta excitedly collected all the fuel crystals lying at her feet. They had been forced to make a stop on the way to Prime as the ship was falling apart and running on fumes. After quite an adventure, they had successfully recovered what they needed from the planet they had stopped on. However, they could not have done it without the help of the Star Siblings and the surprising yet brief return of She-Ra.

The Star Siblings were three siblings on the run from Prime who had also become stranded on the planet. After joining forces with Adora and her friends to get fuel for both their ship and Adora's, everyone had made it back to the surface where they were now mutually celebrating. This was when Starla shared some interesting information:

"Prime didn't always look like your friend. He used to be a much scarier version of his clones: tall, muscular and white. He only changed into a cat recently, like less than a year ago. He can change bodies and, if that's your friend's body, there may be a chance for you to save her. You just have to disconnect him." Adora's eyes widened:

"I can do that?" Jewelstar nodded:

"In theory. We've travelled through most of Prime's empire and have a pretty good idea of how he operates. He changes his body every few years or so, meaning he's probably no more than a form of sentient consciousness. And, logically, the only way you can properly defeat one of those is by erasing it completely. Or, in this case, disconnecting it from its host body." Adora stared blankly at Jewelstar before turning to Entrapta. She was still picking up fuel crystals.

"Entrapta, please tell me you got all that?" Entrapta looked up and nodded excitedly:

"Don't worry, I got it! We'll be able to save Catra – just you wait and see!"

***

0 days before Prime's defeat

Adora's plan had been simple. She would allow herself to be captured and bought before Prime. Out of all of them, she was the one he was most likely to want alive. After she was taken, Bow and Entrapta would head off to the server room to shut Prime down permanently while Glimmer would follow Adora to

make sure she did not get hurt. However, things had been going wrong since the moment they had landed in Prime's ship.

Glimmer had lost Adora almost immediately while both Bow and Entrapta were discovered and chased down several corridors before getting trapped next to the universe's creepiest swimming pool. Meanwhile, Adora had come face to face with her worst fear: a Catra who did not know her.

As Adora was led up to Prime's throne, she could not help but gasp in horror the second Catra came into view. As the Star Siblings had theorized, she had five tubes hooked up to her back, pumping some horrid green liquid into her. Her eyes were the exact same sickly green and they looked straight into Adora's:

"Hello Adora." The blonde's eyes watered in pain as she croaked:

"C-Catra? Are you in there?" Prime, speaking through the feline, laughed and stood up:

"I'm not Catra. I'm Horde Prime. I reign eternal. I see all and know all. And I know you, Adora." The blonde shook her head furiously:

"No. You. Don't." With that, Adora unleashed her unbridled rage and was surprised to see herself glowing. A sword appeared in her hand and, before she knew it, she had taken out every single clone on the platform. There was no one left except her and Catra. Prime, who now realized he had miscalculated, made Catra grab his personal weapon, a creepy white dagger, and lift it to her own neck. She-Ra screamed:

"Catra!" The blonde rushed forward and blocked Catra right before she could hurt herself. In doing so, she slammed the feline into the ground and watched as, for a brief second, her eyes changed back to their normal colours.

She knew it. Catra was still in there.

As if on cue, Glimmer suddenly yelled in Adora's ear:

"We all managed to make it to the server room and I smashed everything! There's nowhere for Prime to run – kill him!" With that, Adora grabbed the tubes which were still hooked up to feline's back and pulled them out, causing Prime to scream and Catra's body to convulse. The blonde immediately leaned over the love of her life and started to heal her, knowing that disconnecting Prime was not enough. She had to erase him.

The siren blared and Catra screamed. Adora used up all of She-Ra's energy before turning back into herself. Then, as she looked down at the healing feline, Prime delivered his final blow: Catra stabbed Adora right in the gut, causing her to cry out and collapse to the floor. After that, everything got blurry.

As Adora faded, she perceived Catra waking up, seeing her and throwing up. The blonde found the strength to call out her name:

"C-Catra?" The feline turned around and slowly said the magic words:

"H-Hey Adora…" Just then, Catra seemed to suddenly become aware of her surroundings, as well as her new look and altered body. She raised her hand to touch her extra eyes and Adora desperately called out:

"N-No, Catra! Don't-" It was too late. Catra looked like she was about to lose it and tear her own eyes out. Adora mustered all her remaining strength to reach for her hand and call out one final time:

"It's… okay… Catra… I… still… love… you…" Then, as everything got dark, Adora heard Catra's voice yelling something indecipherable. She then felt the feline lift her up into her lap and start to purr. Catra had not done that in so long… Adora had missed it more than she knew how to explain.

The blonde had missed so much and knew she should be sad that she was dying. But honestly, this was how she wanted to die. In Catra's arms, knowing the love of her life was finally safe.

Adora could see the light and was ready and willing to walk into it when she suddenly and inexplicably heard the only words that could compel her to stay:

"Adora, I love you too. I always have. Please, just this once, stay…"

Adora never knew how she did this but her eyes re-opened as if by magic and she found herself looking straight into Catra's once again. Despite how horribly disfigured her eyes were, each one still shone beautifully. The blonde gave a weak smile and whispered:

"Okay…" Catra, who still could not believe Adora had somehow come back, smiled and leaned down, finally kissing the love of her life.

***

300 days after Prime's defeat

Both Catra and Adora were sitting in their old spot in the Fright Zone. They both looked more or less like they used to before everything had gone wrong. You would not have known any time had passed at all without the mutual scars and Catra's disfigured ear and eye.

It had been difficult getting off Prime's ship, but after the kiss had brought She-Ra back and healed Adora, Catra had been successfully saved. As Prime was erased from existence, it was only a matter of time before the clones began to lose sight of their purpose and surrendered to the princesses.

The invasion had ended and the princesses had once again set about making everything right.

On the way back to Etheria, the Best Friend Squad had decided to investigate another planet that Prime had failed to conquer and had found another alien who had formed a telepathic connection with Catra: Melog. Only this time the alien was friendly and

imitated Catra by turning into an adorable cat. It had even given her some free therapy before she got back to Etheria.

Once the feline had got back to Etheria, a lot had happened very quickly. The princesses had worked out that Prime had wanted to activate the Heart of Etheria and had nearly succeeded in doing so. This led to a mission to disarm the weapon and release the magic as soon as possible. This was only successfully achieved with the help of Shadow Weaver and a very romantic kiss between Catra and Adora in the Heart of Etheria.

After this, Shadow Weaver was thrown back in her cell and Hordak was taken out of his. All of the clones were now landing on Etheria and were in desperate need of a leader. Entrapta was confident he could redeem himself by leading them and helping them find purpose in their lives in the Kingdom of Dryll. The other princesses had agreed provided he remained under Entrapta's supervision. So far, the project had been going very well.

At the same time, Catra had stood trial. Despite her incredibly weak physical state, the feline had insisted they get it over with. Unsurprisingly, she was immediately acquitted of all charges and put in the care of the Best Friend Squad.

It was a long road to recovery. The first several months had involved a lot of physical therapy for Catra with Entrapta removing all of her left eyes and back ports (on Catra's insistence). She now had a very cool eye patch and was visibly happier and more accepting of her appearance.

Once her more serious physical healing had ended, her therapy sessions with Perfuma had started. Unlike with Adora, these had not been court-mandated. However, Catra had voluntarily agreed to the idea of going to these sessions as long as Adora went with her.

The blonde and the feline were inseparable and madly in love to the point of it being embarrassing. Then again, Bow and Glimmer had also got together soon after their return to Etheria and

Angella had long since decided to start secretly planning their wedding.

Indeed, neither Catra nor Adora had known what marriage was before Angella had told them. And that was what they were doing in their favourite spot high above the Fright Zone.

They had both decided they wanted to talk about it and they preferred to do it somewhere that, despite everything, still felt a little like home. Adora cleared her throat and broke the awkward silence:

"So… um… I guess I should start. I… um… I think it would be really great to be married to you because… well… I love you more than I know how to explain and… um… I… I can't live without you." Catra almost laughed at how adorably awkward and unplanned that speech was, but she could not bring herself to. Instead she turned to her girlfriend and smiled lovingly:

"Me too. You are my everything, Adora. There's no one else in the whole universe who I'd want to spend the rest of my life with." The blonde looked up at the feline with a look of pure childlike wonder before blushing and crying from pure emotion. Catra did not say anything and simply leaned closer and gave Adora a much needed hug. She knew it was important to give Adora time to mentally process everything – even now her mind was still putting itself back together.

The fact was the two of them had been extremely messed up both physically and mentally by Horde Prime and Shadow Weaver. As a result, it took them both considerably longer to process things than it used to. While this had taken a while for them both to individually accept, the princesses had been very supportive and, ever since the two of them had had each other, it had become an easier burden to bear.

Catra patiently waited for the tears to stop and Adora eventually pulled back from the hug. When she did, she kept a gentle yet firm grip on Catra's arms in case the feline grew faint from staying

in the same position for so long. Considering all the alterations Prime had made to Catra's body, it was amazing she could still function at all like she used to.

Adora then cleared her throat and spoke again:

"I promise that no one will ever hurt you again. *I* will never hurt you again. You look out for me and I'll look out for you." Catra nodded and finished Adora's sentence:

"And I'll never hurt *you* again. Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other, right?" Adora's eyes watered again as she whispered:

"You promise?" A tear rolled down Catra's cheek as she nodded and breathed:

"I promise." With that, the two girls kissed and the moon set over the Fright Zone. Truthfully, the view had never been more breath-taking than it was at that moment.

Chapter End Notes

NO ONE DIED!!! I'm honestly so proud of myself for actually managing to give our heroines the happy ending they deserved! I genuinely hope you enjoyed reading this fic and it means the world to me that you did! Kudos and comments are always welcome. Have a great morning/ afternoon/ evening/ night!!! :))

End Notes

If you want to say hi, you can find me on Tumblr (@commanderlioness). I look forward to hearing from you! I hope you enjoyed reading my fic! :))

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!